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# Search for New Physics in anomalous jets using jet substructures with the ATLAS detector and LHC Run 3 data


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*"Te ne sei accorto, sì*
*Che passi tutto il giorno a disegnare*
*Quella barchetta ferma in mezzo al mare*
*E non ti butti mai"*

*Brunori Sas - La Verità*

*A chi sa che non sempre tutto è determinato*
*e lo accetta, passo dopo passo.*

# Abstract

This thesis implements the Anomaly Detection technique, a model-agnostic Machine Learning approach, to search for New Physics Beyond the Standard Model (BSM) in fully hadronic final states with large-radius jets in the ATLAS experiment. The study focuses on four resonant BSM benchmark signals, among which Dark Jets and Heavy Vector Triplets, for different mass hypotheses of the resonant particles in the range between 2 TeV and 6 TeV. The background to those signals is dominated by QCD multi-jet production, with additional contributions from $t\bar{t} \to W^+W^-b\bar{b}$, $Z(\to qq) + jets$ and $W(\to qq) + jets$. A Graph Neural Network is trained in an unbiased way on single jets from a Monte Carlo (MC) multi-jet sample simulating ATLAS Run-3 data, to compute the Anomaly Score (AS) of each jet. The statistical analysis on the di-jet invariant mass $m_{JJ}$ distribution started with the definition of Working Points on the AS distribution, to achieve background rejection rates from 20% to 99.9%, values tested to investigate the minimum amount of background to discard in order to enhance the signals. After a careful optimization and validation of the parameteric modelling of the signal and background distributions via spurious signal tests and signal injection tests, the expected upper limits at 95% Confidence Level on the cross section of the signals using binned maximum likelihood fits are derived using the CLs method. A complete validation was realized performing sensitivity studies to derive an estimation of the sensitivity of the analysis with the partial and full ATLAS Run 3 dataset. The results of the study show that an event selection based on the AS is competitive with the canonincal model-dependent seletions, presenting a possible improvement in the sensitivity to BSM signals, especially for the HVT benchmark signal in the VzWW process.

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# Introduction

It was 4 July 2012 when Joseph Incandela, CMS spokesperson, affirmed: "*They combine to give us a combined significance of five standard deviations*". With these exact words, he announced, confirmed by ATLAS spokesperson Fabiola Gianotti a few minutes later, the first observation of the Higgs boson [1, 2], which completed the Standard Model (SM) framework. Fourteen years later, no comparable discovery has followed within the SM paradigm at collider experiments, strengthening the hypothesis that it is the most complete and well-tested description of nature.
In reality, the SM probably is not as complete as it appears. In fact, there are many phenomena not included in the framework but confirmed by astrophysical and cosmological observations: among these, we can find the neutrino mass measurement, Dark Matter [3] and baryon asymmetry. All these processes fall into the category of New Physics (NP) Beyond the Standard Model (BSM). They have been hunted by ATLAS and CMS experiments using traditional data analysis techniques, targeting specific theoretical models but, unfortunately, nothing has been observed yet and only upper limits on production cross-sections were set. There are many reasons for this unexpected outcome: wrong physical model for experiments, wrong triggering while selecting data, or deviations too small to be observed through normal techniques.
A possible solution to some of these issues could be Anomaly Detection (AD), that is the search for data deviating from what is already known. In our field of interest, Particle Physics, we apply this method to look for anomalies (signal data), deviating from well known reacting and decaying particles (background data). The strength of this method lies in its model agnostic nature, meaning that it does not rely on a specific theoretical model to analyse data. This allows us to explore a more vast range of events, increasing the background rejection efficiency, giving us a first hint of the region where to look more in depth for New Physics with precise data analysis techniques. In this process, unsupervised Machine Learning (ML) helps speeding up everything.
This thesis investigates whether such an unsupervised approach can be applied to a concrete search. Using ATLAS official Monte Carlo (MC) samples simulating the ATLAS detector during Run-3, a search for BSM resonant signals decaying into hadronic final states with large-radius jets (used to probe boosted resonance topologies) has been conducted, preparing the necessary tools to finalise the analysis on real ATLAS data. Leveraging the Anomaly Score (AS) distributions computed by a Graph Neural Network (GNN) for each jet, the analysis strategy was defined, starting with the definition of Working Points (WPs), thresholds on the AS distribution corresponding to a given background rejection fraction. A crucial part of

the strategy was determining the correct modelling function for the background and signals di-jet invariant mass ($m_{JJ}$) distribution. After tuning and validating a Double-Sided Crystal Ball (DSCB) function to model the signals and a 5-parameter function for the background distribution, fits to the MC samples were executed, deriving the expected upper limits at 95% Confidence Level on $m_{JJ}$ using the CLs method, at different AS WPs. The study on MC samples was concluded and fully validated by performing sensitivity studies based on a binned maximum likelihood fit to the di-jet invariant mass distribution.
The thesis is structured as follows. In Chapter 1 the Standard Model is presented, together with theories of Physics beyond it. The LHC collider and the ATLAS experiment are discussed in Chapter 2, followed, in Chapter 3, by the description of the techniques used within the ATLAS collaboration to reconstruct and identify the particles produced in the collisions. Chapter 4 presents the Anomaly Detection approach. Chapter 5 presents the analysis conducted during this study and its results. Finally, conclusions are drawn in Chapter 6.

The original contributions of this thesis are related to the validation of the GNN training and the implementation of the analysis strategy on the MC samples. In particular, after determing that a jet-level AS is a good choice for the analysis, given the reduced correlation with kinematic variables, the WPs were computed, defining an event selection strategy based on the AS distribution. Major efforts were spent in the development of the procedures to model and fit the $m_{JJ}$ distribution, both for the background and the signals, through rigorous validation tests. The results of these studies were instrumental in sensitivity studies and in the derivation of the expected upper limits on the production cross-section of the signals. These studies were followed by the definition of a proposal for the analysis strategy to be applied on real ATLAS Run 3 data. All the steps and results of this work are presented in Chapter 5.

# Chapter 1

# (Beyond) The Standard Model

The Standard Model (SM) of Particle Physics is a relativistic Quantum Field Theory (QFT) describing three out of four fundamental interactions, strong, weak and electromagnetic (EM), and the behavior of elementary particles under them. For a long time attempts were made to to merge the fourth fundamental interaction, gravity, with the SM framework, but those have not been validated yet by experimental observations. Nevertheless, for our purposes, gravity does not play a significant role since the energy scales involved in the processes at a collider experiment, as the LHC, are much lower than the Planck scale, where gravitational effects become relevant.
What is remarkable about the SM is that it is a very well tested theory, with predictions confirmed by experimental observations with a very high precision. The discovery of the Higgs boson in 2012 at the LHC, which completed the SM framework, is a clear example of this.
Despite the success of the SM, there are many phenomena that are not explained by it, but are confirmed by astrophysical and cosmological observations, opening the road for Physics Beyond the Standard Model.
This chapter presents a brief overview of the SM, highlighting its major features. In addition, hints for Physics Beyond it are discussed.

## 1.1 An overview of the Standard Model

The fundamental constituents of the Universe are precisely described by the SM. They are called elementary particles, which are mathematically described as quantum fields $\psi(x)$ and their dynamics are modelled by Lagrangian densities $\mathcal{L}(\psi, \partial_\mu \psi)$ [4]. Such particles can be graphically pictured as presented in Fig. 1.1. They are divided into two fundamental classes based on their spin quantum number. The first class is composed of *fermions*, which cover the first three column of Fig. 1.1 and are organised in three *generations* of increasing proper mass; they have spin 1/2 and constitute *matter*. The second class is that of *bosons*, with integer spin, which *mediate* fundamental interactions and generate mass.
Fermions are further classified into two distinct categories depending on their participation in the strong interaction. The first category is relative to *quarks*. They carry *colour charge* (red, green, blue), making them triplets under $SU(3)$ and therefore interact via all fundamental forces, among which the strong one. Quarks

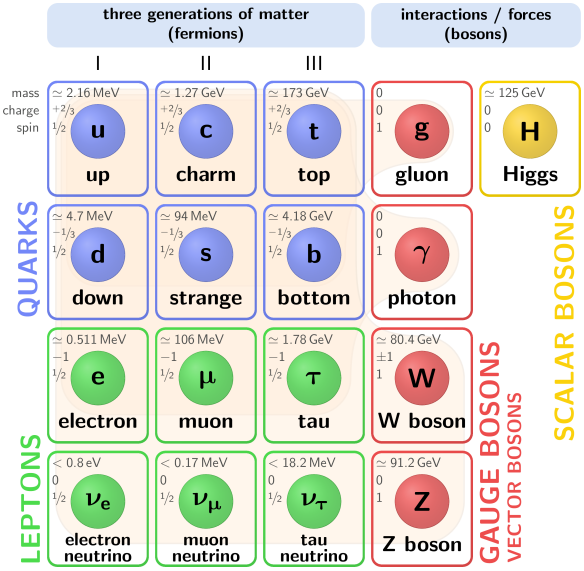



**Figure 1.1** The SM framework. Figure adapted from Ref. [5].

exist in six flavors, organized into three generations of weak SU(2) doublets:

$$\begin{pmatrix} u \\ d \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} c \\ s \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} t \\ b \end{pmatrix} \tag{1.1}$$

Quarks carry a fractional electromagnetic charge: the *up-type* ones $(u, c, t)$ have a charge of $+2/3$, while the *down-type* ones $(d, s, b)$ carry a $-1/3$ charge.
The second category of fermions is associated with *leptons*; there are six of them and similarly grouped into three generations:

$$\begin{pmatrix} e^- \\ \nu_e \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} \mu^- \\ \nu_\mu \end{pmatrix}, \quad \begin{pmatrix} \tau^- \\ \nu_\tau \end{pmatrix} \tag{1.2}$$

The charged leptons $(e^-, \mu^-, \tau^-)$ carry an electric charge of $-1$ and interact via electromagnetic and weak forces. Neutrinos $(\nu_e, \nu_\mu, \nu_\tau)$ are electrically neutral and interact exclusively via the weak force.
Both quarks and leptons, have their own anti-particles, which have the same mass as the matter components but opposite quantum numbers.
The second class of particles is associated with mediatiors and mass. Spin 1 vector bosons, known as *gauge bosons*, are the mediators of three of the fundamental interactions, which arise naturally from the requirement of local gauge invariance. Among those fields we find the 8 massless gluons $g$ mediating the strong interaction, the massless photon $\gamma$ is associated to electromagnetic interaction and 3 massive vector bosons, $W^\pm$ and $Z^0$, with masses $m_W = 80.36$ GeV, $m_Z = 91.19$ GeV, mediating the weak interaction.
In conclusion, a spin 0 scalar particle, the *Higgs boson* $H$, with a mass $m_H = 125.13$ GeV, completes the particle spectrum, arising as a physical state from the spontaneous breaking of electroweak symmetry.

The SM is a gauge theory, meaning that the Lagrangian is invariant under local transformations of the fields. The Lagrangian density describing the SM dynamics can be written as:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{SM}} = -\frac{1}{4}F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu} + i\bar{\psi}\gamma^{\mu}D_{\mu}\psi + (D_{\mu}\phi)^{\dagger}(D^{\mu}\phi) - V(\phi) + \bar{\psi}_i y_{ij}\psi_j\phi + h.c., \quad (1.3)$$

The gauge group of the SM, under which such Lagrangian is invariant, is a non-abelian symmetry group defined as:

$$SU(3)_C \otimes SU(2)_L \otimes U(1)_Y \quad (1.4)$$

where $SU(3)_C$ describes the strong interaction via Quantum Chromodynamics (QCD) with subscript $C$ standing for colour, and $SU(2)_L \otimes U(1)_Y$ represents the unified electroweak (EW) interaction, with $L$ associated to the left component of fermions and $Y$ to hypercharge.
The terms of the equation 1.3 above are presented in detail in the following sections.

### 1.1.1 Quantum Electrodynamics

The first and simplest gauge theory within the SM framework is Quantum Electrodynamics (QED). It describes the electromagnetic interactions between a charged massive fermion, with mass $m$ and represented by a field $\psi(x)$, and the photon, the massless gauge boson represented by the vector field $A_\mu$. Using the Lagrangian formalism [6], QED is constructed starting from the free Dirac Lagrangian for a massive fermion [7]:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{Dirac}} = \bar{\psi}(i\gamma^{\mu}\partial_{\mu} - m)\psi \quad (1.5)$$

In the equation above, $\bar{\psi} = \psi^{\dagger}\gamma^0$ is the Dirac adjoint of the field $\psi$ and $\gamma^\mu$ are the Dirac matrices derived from Pauli matrices $\sigma_i$ ($i$ =1,2,3 and $\mu$=0,1,2,3):

$$\gamma^0 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & \mathbb{I} \\ \mathbb{I} & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \gamma^i = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & \sigma_i \\ -\sigma_i & 0 \end{pmatrix} \quad (1.6)$$

The Dirac Lagrangian 1.5 is invariant under a global $U(1)$ phase transformation $\psi(x) \rightarrow e^{ie\alpha}\psi(x)$, with $e$ the electric charge of the fermion and $\alpha$ a constant phase. Such invariance is not preserved under a local $U(1)$ phase transformation $\psi(x) \rightarrow e^{ie\alpha(x)}\psi(x)$, where $\alpha(x)$ is a space-time dependent phase. In order to preserve the invariance, the partial derivative $\partial_\mu$ is replaced by the covariant derivative $D_\mu$:

$$D_{\mu} = \partial_{\mu} + ieA_{\mu}(x) \quad (1.7)$$

where $A_\mu(x)$ is a vector gauge field representing the photon field, which transforms as $A_\mu(x) \rightarrow A_\mu(x) - \partial_\mu\alpha(x)$. Including the gauge-invariant kinetic term to take into account for the new field $A_\mu$, we derive the full QED Lagrangian:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{QED}} = \bar{\psi}(i\gamma^{\mu}D_{\mu} - m)\psi - \frac{1}{4}F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu} \quad (1.8)$$

where $F_{\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu A_\nu - \partial_\nu A_\mu$ is the electromagnetic field strength tensor. The interaction term $-e\bar{\psi}\gamma^\mu\psi A_\mu$ rules the coupling of charged fermions to photons with a strength proportional to the electric charge $e$.
The invariance under a local $U(1)$ transformation gurantees, via the Noether's theorem [8], the existence of a conserved current and charge which, in the case of QED, are the electromagnetic current and the electric charge, respectively.

### 1.1.2 Quantum Chromodynamics

The building of the Lagrangian for QCD is similar to the one for QED: the Dirac Lagrangian is required to be invariant under a local symmetry group, which in this case is the non-Abelian $SU(3)_C$ group, where $C$ represents the triplet color degree of freedom (red, green, blue), the conserved charge of QCD [9]. This theory models the strong interaction between *quarks*, fundamental constituents of hadrons represented as fermionic fields $q(x)$, and *gluons*, the massless gauge bosons represented as vector fields $G^a_{\mu\nu}(x)$ with $a = 1, ..., 8$. Similarly to QED, the local transformation of the quark field is defined as $q(x) \to q'(x) = e^{ig_s T^a \alpha_a(x)} q(x)$, with $g_s$ the strong coupling constant and $\alpha_a(x)$ the local phase. The term $T^a$ appearing in the previous transformation equation is associated to the generators of the $SU(3)_C$ group, which can be expressed via the Gell-Mann matrices as $T^a = \frac{1}{2}\lambda^a$; such generators satisfy $[T^a, T^a] = if^{abc}T^c$ with $f^{abc}$ being the structure constants of $SU(3)$.
Also in this case, a covariant derivative is introduced to preserve the invariance of the Lagrangian under local transformations:

$$D_\mu = \partial_\mu + ig_s T_a G^a_\mu \tag{1.9}$$

The non-Abelian structure of the group, gives rise to the QCD field tensor:

$$F^a_{\mu\nu} = \partial_\mu G^a_\nu - \partial_\nu G^a_\mu - g_s f^{abc} G^b_\mu G^c_\nu \tag{1.10}$$

The presence of the non-linear structure factor $f^{abc}$ both in the commutators and in the tensor, is associated to a particular feature of QCD: the triple and quadruple gluon self-interaction of gluons, a feature not present in QED.
Finally, the Lagrangian describing the dynamics of QCD is written as:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{QCD}} = \bar{q}\left(i\gamma^\mu D_\mu - m\right) q - \frac{1}{4} F^a_{\mu\nu} F^{a,\mu\nu} \tag{1.11}$$

The term $g_s$, cited before in the local transformation, is usually presented as $\alpha_s = \frac{g_s^2}{4\pi}$, which is the running coupling constant of QCD, whose value depends on the energy scale $Q^2$ of the process. The non-Abelian nature of QCD gives rise to a peculiar behavior of $\alpha_s(Q^2)$. In fact, at high energy scales (meaning short distances), $\alpha_s(Q^2)$ decreases logarithmically, giving rise to the *asymptotic freedom*, enabling accurate calculations via perturbative QCD (pQCD). On the other hand, at low energy scales (meaning long distances), $\alpha_s(Q^2)$ increases, giving rise to the *color confinement*, which prevents colored particles from existing as isolated free states. In this regime, quarks and gluons undergo fragmentation and hadronization, producing collimated sprays of energetic hadrons, known as *jets*.

### 1.1.3 Electroweak model

Making use of the Glashow-Weinberg-Salam (GWS) model [7, 10], it is possible to derive a unified description of *electromagnetic* interaction, already presented in Sec. 1.1.1, and the final third interaction, the *weak* one.
To derive the Electroweak (EW) Lagrangian, the steps to follow are similar to those already presented for QED and QCD. In the first place, the symmetry group under which the Lagrangian is invariant is defined, which is $SU(2)_L \otimes U(1)_Y$ in this case, with $Y$ known as hypercharge, the quantum number of EW interactions.
Secondly, the description of fermions and gauge bosons is defined. Concerning the latter, we have four bosons: $W_\mu^i$ with $i = 1, 2, 3$ associated to $SU(2)_L$ and $B_\mu$ associated to $U(1)_Y$, with coupling constants $g$ and $g'$ respectively. Moving to fermions, they are chirality eigenstates. This means that they can be expressed as left-handed and right-handed components, which are defined as $\psi_{L,R} = \frac{1}{2}(1 \mp \gamma^5)\psi$, with $\gamma^5 = i\gamma^0\gamma^1\gamma^2\gamma^3$. The left-handed components of fermions transform as doublets under $SU(2)_L$ and are described as $L = (\nu, l^-)$ for leptons and $Q = (u, d)$ for quarks. They have quantum numbers $(T = 1/2, T_3 = \pm 1/2)$, with T being the isospin. The right-handed components, instead, transform as singlets under $U(1)_Y$, with quantum numbers $(T = 0, T_3 = 0)$.
The transformation of the fermion components is defined in a compact way as:

$$\begin{aligned} \psi_L(x) &\longrightarrow \psi'_L(x) = e^{i\vec{\alpha}(x)\cdot\vec{\tau} + i\beta(x)Y}\psi_L(x), \\ \psi_R(x) &\longrightarrow \psi'_R(x) = e^{i\beta(x)Y}\psi_R(x) \end{aligned} \tag{1.12}$$

where $\vec{\tau} = \frac{1}{2}\vec{\sigma}$ are the weak isospin, generators of $SU(2)_L$.

The following step towards the EW Lagrangian, is to introduce the covariant derivative to preserve the invariance of the Lagrangian under local transformations. The derivative is defined as:

$$D_\mu = \partial_\mu + ig\frac{\tau^a}{2}W_\mu^a(x) + ig'\frac{Y}{2}B_\mu(x) \tag{1.13}$$

At this point, the EW Lagrangian can be written as:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{EW}} = -\frac{1}{4}W^{a,\mu\nu}W^a_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{4}B^{\mu\nu}B_{\mu\nu} + i\bar{\psi}\gamma^\mu D_\mu\psi \tag{1.14}$$

where $W^{a,\mu\nu}$ and $B^{\mu\nu}$ are the field strength tensors associated to the gauge bosons $W_\mu^a$ and $B_\mu$, respectively.
In conclusion, if a rotaion is applied to the $W_\mu^a$ and $B_\mu$ fields, the four physical gauge bosons $\gamma, Z, W^\pm$ are obtained as:

$$\begin{pmatrix} A_\mu \\ Z_\mu \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\theta_W & \sin\theta_W \\ -\sin\theta_W & \cos\theta_W \end{pmatrix}\begin{pmatrix} B_\mu \\ W_\mu^3 \end{pmatrix}, \quad W_\mu^\pm = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(W_\mu^1 \mp iW_\mu^2) \tag{1.15}$$

The parameter appearing in the previous equation is the Weinberg angle $\theta_W$, which is defined as $\tan\theta_W = g'/g$.
The EW Lagrangian 1.14 does not provide a proper description of the mass of the bosons involved, which is in contrast with the experimental observations of massive $W^\pm$ and $Z^0$ bosons. The solution to this issue is provided by the Brout-Englert-Higgs mechanism (BEH), which is presented in the following section.

### 1.1.4 The Brout-Englert-Higgs mechanism

The BEH mechanism provides a theoretical framework to generate masses for the gauge bosons and fermions of the SM, while preserving the local gauge invariance of the Lagrangian. The mechanism is based on the concept of spontaneous symmetry breaking (SSB) of the group $SU(3)_C \otimes SU(2)_L \otimes U(1)_Y$ into $SU(2)_L \otimes U(1)_{EM}$ [11]. The SSB is realized by introducing a complex scalar field $\phi$, which is a doublet under $SU(2)_L$ and carries hypercharge $Y = 1/2$. It is defined as:

$$\phi = \begin{pmatrix} \phi^+ \\ \phi^0 \end{pmatrix} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} \phi_1 + i\phi_2 \\ \phi_3 + i\phi_4 \end{pmatrix} \tag{1.16}$$

The potential associated to the scalar field is defined as:

$$V(\phi) = -\mu^2 \phi^\dagger \phi + \frac{\lambda}{2} \left(\phi^\dagger \phi\right)^2 \tag{1.17}$$

where $\mu^2$ and $\lambda$ are constants. Among the two constants, $\lambda$ must be positive to ensure the stability of the potential, while $\mu^2$ can be either positive or negative. The shape of the potential is determined by the sign of $\mu^2$. If $-\mu^2 > 0$, the potential has a single minimum at $\phi = 0$, preserving the symmetry. If $-\mu^2 < 0$, the potential gets the well-known mexican hat shape presented in Fig 1.2.

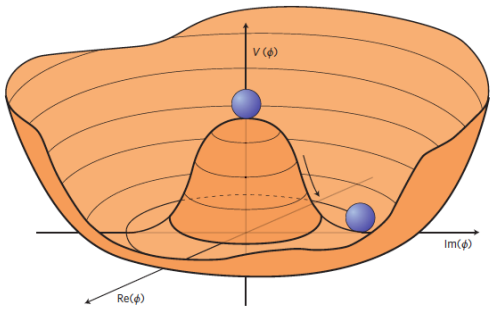



**Figure 1.2** Representation of the Higgs potential $V(\phi)$. Figure from Ref. [12].

In the latter case, the vacuum state, as known as the minimum of the potential, is degenerate and associated to a non-zero value of the scalar field $\phi$. In particular, the vacuum expectation value (VEV) $v$ of the Higgs field, defined as $v = \sqrt{\mu^2/\lambda}$, is not null. As a direct consqeuence, the global $U(1)_Y$ symmetry is spontaneously broken. The VEV is given by:

$$\langle \phi \rangle = \sqrt{\frac{\mu^2}{2\lambda}} = \frac{v}{\sqrt{2}} \tag{1.18}$$

Since the theory is built to be gauge invariant, in order to remove the unphysical degrees of freedom, the unitary gauge transformation is applied to the scalar field $\phi$. In this gauge, the Higgs field can be expressed as:

$$\phi = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ v + h(x) \end{pmatrix} \tag{1.19}$$

where $h(x)$ is the Higgs boson scalar field.
Using the definition of $\phi$ presented in Eq. 1.19, the EW Lagrangian density can be written as:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{L}_{\text{SM}} &= -\tfrac{1}{4}W^{a,\mu\nu}W^{a}_{\mu\nu} - \tfrac{1}{4}B^{\mu\nu}B_{\mu\nu} + i\overline{\psi}\gamma^{\mu}D_{\mu}\psi + \\ &-Y^{l}_{ij}\overline{L_i}\phi\, e_j - Y^{\nu}_{ij}\overline{e_i}\phi\, L_j - Y^{d}_{ij}\overline{Q_i}\phi\, d'_j - Y^{u}_{ij}\overline{Q_i}\phi\, u_j + \text{h.c.} \\ &+(D^{\mu}\phi)^{\dagger}(D_{\mu}\phi) - V(\phi)\end{aligned} \tag{1.20}$$

where the term $D_\mu$ is the covariant derivative defined in Eq. 1.13 and $Y_{ij}$ are the Yukawa couplings. Each line of the Lagrangian density 1.20 has as specific role. The first line represents the gauge bosons and how they interact with fermions, the second one contains the Yukawa couplings which is associated to Higgs coupling with fermions, and the third line contains the kinetic term for the Higgs field and its potential.
The Higgs potential $V(\phi)$, defined in Eq. 1.17, with che chosen gauge, can be expressed as:

$$V(h) = \frac{1}{2}m_h^2h^2 + \frac{m_h^2}{2v}h^3 + \frac{m_h^2}{8v^2}h^4 \tag{1.21}$$

The $m_h$ term appearing in the previous equation is the mass of the Higgs boson, which is a free parameter of the SM, depending on the parameters of the potential, as $m_h = \sqrt{2\lambda v^2} = \sqrt{2\mu^2}$. The cubic and quartic terms in $h$ represent self-interactions of the Higgs boson.
The Higgs boson mass has been measured by the ATLAS and CMS collaborations [1, 2] to be $m_h = (125.13 \pm 0.11)$ GeV, which is consistent with the SM predictions.

## 1.2 Hints of Physics Beyond the Standard Model

The SM presented in the previous section 1.1 is a very successful theory, which has been confirmed by experimental observations with a very high precision. Despite its success, the SM probably is not a complete theory, given the many open questions that are not answered by the SM and motivate the search for Physics Beyond the Standard Model (BSM).
Among these questions, we find the nature of the Higgs boson, whether it is the only scalar particle of this type or it is part of an extended Higgs sector. In fact, many extensions of the SM predict the existence of additional scalar or pseudo-scalar states, such as two-Higgs-doublet models (2HDMs), which are currently studied at the LHC by the ATLAS collaboration [13].
Together with theories to be proven, as the one just cited, there are many other already proven by astrophysical and cosmological observations. The first one is the existence of Dark Matter (DM), which is known to compose 26.4% of the Universe, together with a 68.7% of Dark Energy and a 4.9% of ordinary matter [14]. The presence of DM is inferred from its gravitational effects on visible matter, such as galaxies rotation curves [15], galaxy-galaxy gravitational lensing [16] and the Bullet Cluster [17], the result of the collision of two galaxy clusters. In order to observe DM at collider experiments, the approach, known as indirect search, is to detect

decay products of DM particles produced in particle collisions. This type of search was not able to provide any evidence of DM particles yet, leaving it an ongoing study at the LHC.
Another open question is the matter-antimatter asymmetry in the Universe, also known as baryon asymmetry. In fact, it is agreed that in the early Universe there was balance between matter and antimatter, but today in the Universe, after its cooling down, the balance is broken in favour of matter. Such unbalance could be associated with a violation of the $CP$ symmetry, which is a combination of charge conjugation $C$ and parity $P$. This motivates the search for new sources of $CP$ violation, which could be provided by BSM theories.
One final question, among many, is the hierarchy problem, which is associated to the Higgs boson mass. In fact, the Higgs boson mass value is subject to quantum loop corrections, which are quadratically divergent. This means that the Higgs boson mass receives contributions from all energies up to the Planck scale ($10^{19}$ GeV). Since the Higgs boson mass has been measured to be 125 GeV, an unnatural fine-tuning of the parameters of the SM would be required with large cancellations between different terms in radiative correction. This motivates the search for New Physics (NP) at the TeV scale, which could provide a natural explanation for the Higgs boson mass.

### 1.2.1 New Physics at colliders

After reading the BSM cases presented above, and many others not cited, it appears to be quite clear that New Physics Beyond the Standard Model should exist and, in principle, it should be accessible at the energy scales probed by the LHC. Given the lack of observations at CERN experiments, it is worth analysing the approach used to probe NP. This kind of experiments are conducted with two main different approaches: *precision measurements*, which are sensitive to small deviations from the SM predictions, and *direct searches*, which aim to produce new particles in high-energy collisions and probe them. The latter direction has been traditionally pursued by targeting a specific BSM model, which is known as *model-dependent* search. In this case, the search is optimized for a specific model and its parameters. The results of such searches are usually presented as exclusion limits on the space of parameters of the model.
A suitable alternative to model-dependent searches is the *model-independent* or *model-agnostic* approach, which searches for deviations from the SM predictions in a general way, without assuming any specific BSM model. This approach is more flexible and can be sensitive to a wider range of BSM scenarios. This type of search is gaining more and more interest in recent years in the LHC program for Run 3 and following.
A model-agnostic search for NP is the topic of this thesis, with the goal to prove its flexibility and sensitivity. Two possible BSM theories have been chosen as benchmark models to test the strategy, Heavy Vector Triplets (HVT) which could explain new narrow resonances, and Dark Jets (DJ) which are QCD-like jets produced by dark sectors.

### 1.2.2 Heavy Vector Triplets

Popular studied BSM scenarios are those presented in Simplified Models [18], which assume that NP are associated with new narrow resonances. Such assumption has the direct consequence of reducing the number of free parameters of the model, making it more predictive and easier to test.
The simplest and most studied Simplified Model is the Heavy Vector Triplet (HVT) model [19], which predicts the existence of electroweakly charged spin 1 bosons with a behavior similar to the SM $W$ and $Z$ bosons. This model introduces in the SM Lagrangian the presence of the real vector field $V_\mu^a$ $(a = 1, 2, 3)$, which is a triplet under $SU(2)_W$ and has zero hypercharge. Making a combination of these components, the physical states of the HVT model are obtained as:

$$V_\mu^\pm = \frac{V_\mu^1 \mp i V_\mu^2}{\sqrt{2}}, \quad V_\mu^0 = V_\mu^3 \tag{1.22}$$

The HVT decay with highest branching ratios with two leptons, two quarks or two bosons in the final state.
ATLAS and CMS collaborations have conducted many analyses to search for HVT decaying mainly in fully hadronic final states, which are the most abundant ones. The results of these searches are usually presented as exclusion limits at 95% confidence level on the mass of the HVT bosons, which are currently excluded in the range $[1.3, 3.1]$ TeV by ATLAS [20] and CMS [21]. The latter experiment also excluded the range $[3.3, 3.5]$ TeV. A typical plot of these kind of searches can be found in Fig. 1.3, showing the result of the ATLAS analysis with Run 2 data in fully hadronic final state.

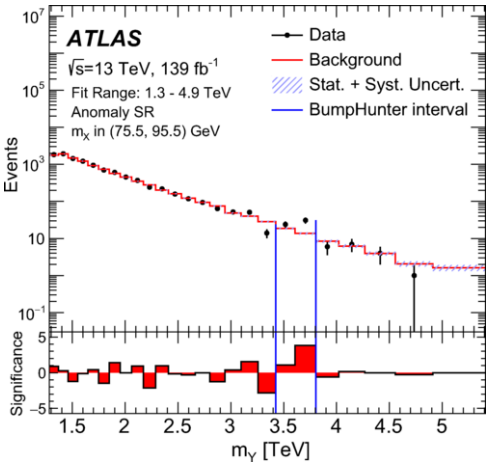



**Figure 1.3** Distribution of the invariant mass of the candidate Y boson in the ATLAS analysis [20] in fully hadronic final states. The ratio plot shows an excess in the [3608,3805]GeV range with a global significance of $1.43\sigma$.

### 1.2.3 Dark Jets

Many BSM theories predict the existence of other particles which are not part of the SM but are included in a new sector, known as *dark sector*. The latter interact with

the former via a *portal*, which is a mediator of the interaction. The dark QCD model, a strongly coupled dark sector, has gained interest in the last years as a possible explanation for DM. [22] In this model, the dark sector is composed of dark quarks and gluons, which are charged under a new gauge group $SU(N)_D$ and interact via a new strong force, similar to QCD.
The dark quarks can be pair-produced at colliders via a mediator particle. Once produced, they undergo a shower and hadronization process, similar to QCD, producing collimated sprays of dark hadrons, known as dark jets. This process is predicted to happen at a scale $\Lambda_D$, which is the confinement scale of the dark sector, with the assumption that $\Lambda_D << \sqrt{s}$, where $\sqrt{s}$ is the center-of-mass energy of the collision.
The experimental signature of those processes at colliders will be jets with missing energy or general features not compatible with QCD.
ATLAS and CMS collaborations have conducted many analyses to search for dark jets. In particular, the ATLAS collaboration, using Run 2 data, has conducted a search for a $Z' \to q_D \bar{q}_D$ resonance [23] in fully hadronic final states, where $q_D$ is a dark quark and $Z'$ is probed in the range of $[1.5, 3.5]$ TeV. The observed limit on the mass for such new resonance has been set up to 3.5 TeV, as presented in Fig. 1.4.

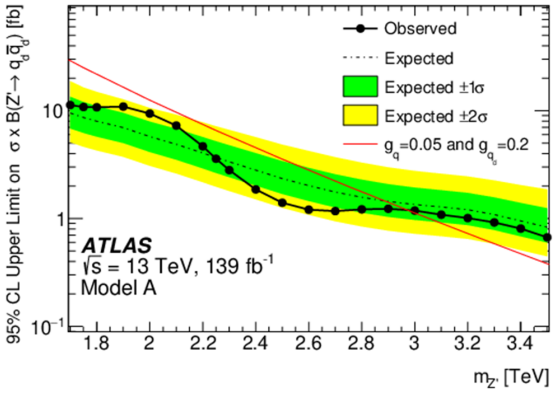



**Figure 1.4** Upper limits at 95% CL on the cross section times the branching ratio for a dark QCD process in the fully hadronic final state. The cited "Model A" is a model of the dark sector which predicts the production of a dark pion $\pi_d$ and a dark rho $\rho_d$. Figure from Ref. [20].

# Chapter 2

# The LHC and the ATLAS experiment

The history of the European Organization for Nuclear Research (CERN) traces back to the post-WWII era, when European physicists, including Edoardo Amaldi, Niels Bohr and Pierre Auger, promoted a collaborative international laboratory dedicated to fundamental science. CERN was established in September 1954 and today it hosts the world's largest and most energetic accelerator complex, centered around the Large Hadron Collider (LHC).
In the following, after a description of the LHC machine, the discussion covers the architecture of the ATLAS (A Toroidal LHC ApparatuS) detector, one of the four major experiments at CERN, including its main sub-systems and simulation procedures. A special focus is given to the proton-proton collision dataset collected by ATLAS at a center-of-mass energy of 13.6 TeV during LHC Run 3, which forms the basis for this study.

## 2.1 The LHC

The Large Hadron Collider (LHC) at CERN, with its 27 kilometres ring [25], is the world's largest particle accelerator. It has four major interaction points which host the major CERN experiments: ATLAS, CMS, LHCb and ALICE. LHC is situated about 100 metres underground for economic and geological reasons, as well as to provide radiation shielding. Depending on the run, protons or lead nuclei are collided, with a center-of-mass energy of 13.6 TeV and 5.36 TeV per nucleon respectively. In order to reach such high energies, a complex system of pre-acceleration is adopted, as presented in Fig. 2.1.

### 2.1.1 CERN's accelerator system

For proton-proton ($pp$) collisions, the process begins with the extraction of negative hydrogen ions ($H^-$), which are initially accelerated to an energy of 160 MeV by the Linear Accelerator 4 (LINAC4). Upon injection into the Proton Synchrotron Booster (PSB), the ions are stripped of their two electrons leaving only the bare

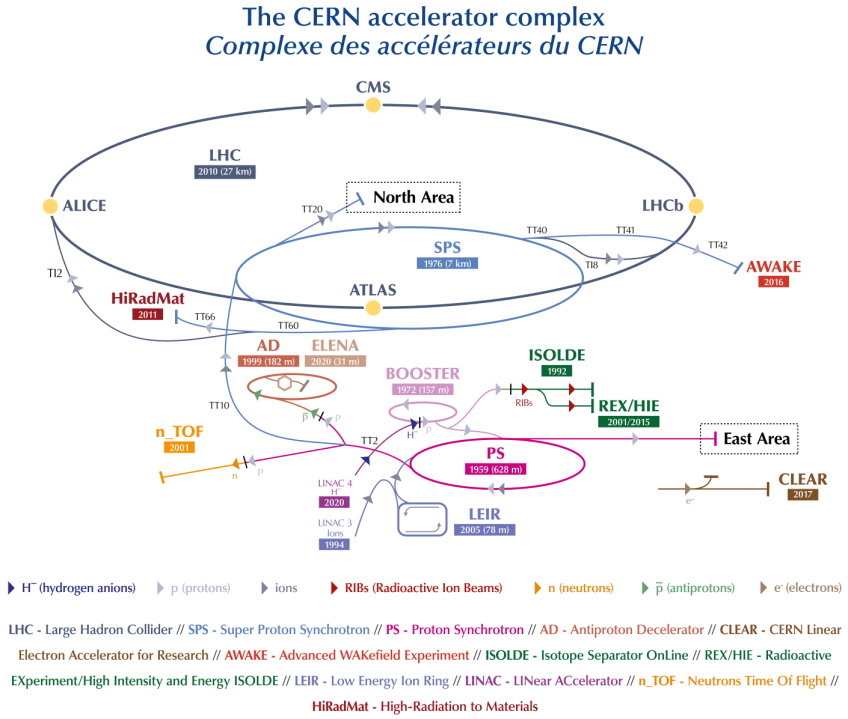



**Figure 2.1** CERN accelerating system. Figure from Ref. [24].

protons, which are grouped into bunches and boosted to an energy of 2 GeV. The protons then enter the Proton Synchrotron (PS), reaching an energy of 25 GeV. The final step takes place in the Super Proton Synchrotron (SPS) that accelerates the proton bunches up to the LHC injection energy of 450 GeV. Finally, the proton bunches are injected into the two counter-rotating beam pipes of the LHC, where they are accelerated to their maximum operational energy of 6.8 TeV per beam.
In heavy-ion operations (primarily based on lead nuclei, $^{208}$Pb), ions are initially accelerated by the Linear Accelerator 3 (LINAC3) to an energy of 4.2 MeV per nucleon. The nucleons are then accumulated and boosted to 72 MeV per nucleon inside the Low Energy Ion Ring (LEIR). In the next stage, the PS accelerates ions to 5.9 GeV per nucleon, before transferring them to the SPS where they reach an energy of 177 GeV per nucleon. When injected into the main LHC ring, the heavy-ion beams are accelerated to a final energy of 2.68 TeV per nucleon.
Particles are accelerated up to such high energies by means of radio-frequency (RF) cavities, resonant structures generating an oscillating electric field, with a fixed frequency of 400MHz, which accelerates charged particles each time they pass through. Particles with the target energy passing trough the cavity while the field is zero, will not be accelerated, while more (less) energetic particles will be decelerated (accelerated). Using this technique, it is ensured that particles stays in the cited bunches.

### 2.1.2 The LHC parameters

The LHC is composed of two circular beam pipes, denominated Beam 1 and Beam 2. Inside them, two particle beams, composed of a maximum of 2808 bunches with approximately $1.15 \times 10^{11}$ protons per bunch and spaced by 25 ns, travel separately close to the speed of light in opposite directions. There are eight Interaction Points (IPs) along the LHC ring, but only four of them are used for collisions, hosting the main LHC experiments: ATLAS at IP1, ALICE (A Large Ion Collider Experiment) at IP2, CMS (Compact Muon Solenoid) at IP5 and LHCb (LHC beauty) at IP8. The beam pipes and the interaction points are presented in Fig. 2.2.

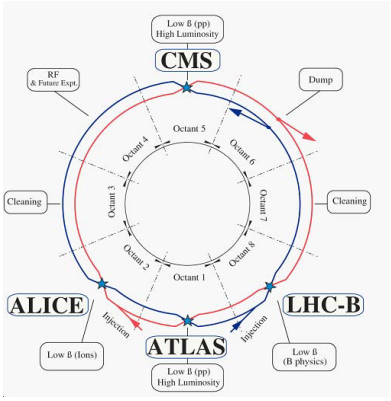



**Figure 2.2** Schematic layout of the LHC (Beam 1 clockwise, Beam 2 anticlockwise). Figure from Ref. [26].

In the following, the focus will be placed on proton-proton collisions, which are the ones used in this study.
Due to the very high speed, when the two beams collide, the energy of the center of mass, known as $\sqrt{s}$, is twice the energy of each beam (which is the same). In fact, knowing that $E^2 = m^2c^4 + p^2c^2$ and using the natural unit system ([m]=eV, [p]=eV), we get: $E^2 = m^2 + p^2 \simeq p^2$, where at the end an ultra-relativistic particle (p$\gg$m) was assumed. This information is used in the norm of the four-momentum of two colliding particles:

$$\sqrt{s} = \sqrt{P_\mu P^\mu} = \sqrt{E_{tot}^2 - |\vec{p_{tot}}|^2} = \sqrt{(E_1 + E_2)^2 - |\vec{p_1} - \vec{p_2}|^2} \simeq 2E \qquad (2.1)$$

where we assumed $E_1 = E_2$. The 6.8 TeV of energy reached by LHC protons confirm the assumption p$\gg$m and it leads to the known value of $\sqrt{s} = 13.6$ TeV for proton-proton collisions.
Accelerated beams are directed and curved by superconducting electromagnets with a magnetic field of up to 8.3 T [27]: 1232 dipole magnets and 392 quadrupole magnets are used to maintain the beams focused. Magnets are kept at a temperature of 1.9 K to ensure a 11600 A electric current which is needed for the intense magnetic field. Despite their essential contribution, magnets also represent one of the main limitations of this apparatus. In fact, from the Lorentz force equation $\vec{F} = q(\vec{E} + \vec{v} \times \vec{B})$, it is possible to get a connection between the external magnetic field $\vec{B}$ (the one generated by superconducting magnets), the momentum $p$ of the

particle circulating inside the beams and its radius of curvature $R$, which is:

$$p[GeV] = 0.3B[T]R[m] \tag{2.2}$$

It is evident from Eq. 2.2 that, to keep a constant momentum $p$ of the particles circulating inside the beams, a higher magnetic field $B$ is required in case of reduction of the radius of curvature $R$. Unfortunately, current technologies set a limit to the magnetic field generated by a magnet, limiting also the minum dimension of an accelerator ring.
Performance of the LHC is evaluated based on an essential parameter: the instantaneous luminosity $\mathcal{L}$. It defines the number of collisions per $cm^2$ and per second produced in the collider and thus it is measured in $cm^{-2}s^{-1}$. It is computed as follows [28]:

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{N_b^2 n_b f_{rev} \gamma}{4\pi\epsilon_n \beta^*} F \tag{2.3}$$

where: $N_b$ is the number of particles in a bunch, $n_b$ is the number of bunches in a beam, $\epsilon_n$ is the normalized transverse beam emittance, $\beta^*$ is the beta function at the collision point, $\gamma$ is the Lorentz relativistic factor computed as $\gamma = 1/\sqrt{1 - v^2/c^2}$ , $f_{rev}$ is the revolution frequency. There is a connection between the beta function and the transverse beam size $\sigma$, which is $\sigma = \sqrt{\epsilon_n \beta^*/\gamma}$. F represents the geometric luminosity reduction factor:

$$F = \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 + \left(\frac{\theta_c \sigma_z}{2\sigma^*}\right)^2}} \tag{2.4}$$

where $\theta_c$ is the full crossing angle at the interaction point, $\sigma_z$ is the RMS bunch length and $\sigma^*$ is the transverse RMS beam size at the interaction point. When the instantaneous luminosity goes below a fixed threshold during operations, beams are dumped and a new fill of the LHC is performed.
During LHC Run 3, $\mathcal{L}$ gets a value of order $10^{34}$ $\text{cm}^{-2}s^{-1}$ for both ATLAS and CMS experiments, while for LHCb and ALICE it is $10^{32}$ $\text{cm}^{-2}s^{-1}$ and $10^{27}$ $\text{cm}^{-2}s^{-1}$ respectively.
The instantaneous luminosity is linked with the number of collisions per second :

$$\frac{dN}{dt} = \mathcal{L}\sigma_{tot} \tag{2.5}$$

where $\sigma_{tot}$ is the total cross section, which is the measure of the probability of a specific interaction process to happen. If the instantaneous luminosity is integrated over time, the number of events collected is obtained:

$$N_{events} = \sigma_{tot} A \epsilon \int \mathcal{L} dt \tag{2.6}$$

where $A$ is the acceptance of the detector and $\epsilon$ is the efficiency of the event selection criteria.

### 2.1.3 LHC Run Schedule

The LHC operations are structured into extended physics data-taking campaigns named *Runs*, which are separated by planned technical maintenance and upgrade periods for both the machine and the detectors, which are known as Long Shutdowns (LS). It was Run 1, from 2010 to 2013, that started the LHC physics program, operating at center-of-mass energies of $\sqrt{s} = 7$ TeV and 8 TeV, with a delivered integrated luminosity of 28 $fb^{-1}$. Run 1 culminated in the discovery of the Higgs boson by the ATLAS and CMS collaborations. Following upgrades during LS1, meant to enable higher-energy operations, Run 2 took place between 2015 and 2018 at $\sqrt{s} = 13$ TeV, delivering an integrated luminosity of approximately 156 fb$^{-1}$. After another round of upgrades during LS2 the collider entered the Run 3 era in 2022, which lasted until June 2026, operating at an increased center-of-mass energy of $\sqrt{s} = 13.6$ TeV. After having delivered an integrated luminosity of approximately 351 fb$^{-1}$, the LHC was turned off for the beginning of LS3. This new stop will be used to prepare the LHC for the High-Luminosity LHC (HL-LHC) era, which is expected to start in 2029 and will last until 2042. The HL-LHC will operate at the same center-of-mass energy of Run 3 and is expected to deliver an integrated luminosity of 3000 fb$^{-1}$ during the future Runs.
A graph showing the LHC delivered integrated luminosity during the different Runs, together with the recorded luminosity by ATLAS, is shown in Fig. 2.3.

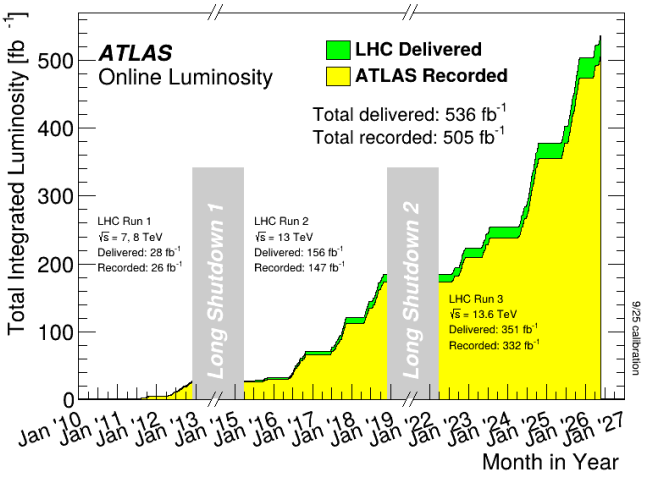



**Figure 2.3** Cumulative integrated luminosity delivered to and recorded by the ATLAS Experiment during LHC Run 1, 2 and 3. Figure from Ref. [29].

## 2.2 *pp* collisions at the LHC

As presented in Sec. 2.1.2, at the LHC protons are collided every 25 ns at a center-of-mass energy of $\sqrt{s} = 13.6$ TeV. Theoretical calculations to model such events using QCD are not trivial, since protons are not elementary particles but composite states of quarks and gluons, collectively referred as *partons* [30]. The canonical approach used with other theories, the *perturbation theory*, can still be used in the

case of high-energy interactions, known as *hard scattering*, where the strong coupling constant $\alpha_s$ is small enough to allow a perturbative expansion. It fails at low energy scales, in the so called *soft scattering*, where $\alpha_s$ becomes large and the perturbative expansion diverges.
In these cases, the *factorization theorem* allows to compute the total cross-section of *pp* collisions as a convolution of short-distance partonic matrix elements with long-distance Parton Distribution Functions (PDFs), which describe the probability of finding a parton with a given momentum fraction $x$ inside the proton.
The situation described above gets a degree of complexity when considering that, in a single bunch crossing, multiple *pp* collisions can occur. This phenomenon, known as *pile-up*, is discussed in Sec. 2.2.1.
As said, the calculation of the total cross-section of *pp* collisions is not trivial. For this reason, event generators are used to simulate the physics of *pp* collisions, as described in Sec. 2.3.8 for ATLAS.
In Fig. 2.4 a Feynman diagram of a *pp* collision is shown, where the two protons are represented as two bunches of partons, among which only two of them collide in the hard scatter and produce the final state. All the other processes are referred to as *Underlying Events (UE)*, which are discussed in Sec. 2.2.1.

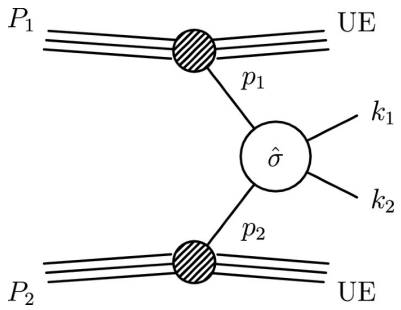



**Figure 2.4** Feynman diagram of a *pp* collision. Figure from Ref. [31].

### 2.2.1 Pile-Up and hadronisation

The partons coming out of the hard scattering process emit gluon radiation and produce quark pairs in a cascading parton shower (Sec. 2.2.3).
When approaching energies compatible with the QCD scale $\Lambda_{\text{QCD}} \approx 200/300$ MeV, the soft scattering regime is reached, with the divergence of the perturbative expansion and the araising of colour confinment. For this reason, colour charged partons must bind into colour-neutral hadrons. This non-perturbative transition is known as *hadronisation* [31]. The processes and collisions not related to the primary hard scatter are defined as *Underlying Events*, which can rise from multiple sources, such as initial of final state radiation. This type of events, together with soft scattering processes from other partons, are responsible for the Pile-Up (PU) phenomenon. PU degrades event reconstruction and it has to be carefully controlled to ensure a correct physics analysis. When referring to PU, the average number of *pp* collisions per bunch crossing is presented, using the symbol $\langle\mu\rangle$.
In Fig. 2.5, a plot showing the PU distribution in ATLAS from Run 1 to Run 3 is

presented. It is evident that the average number of *pp* collisions per bunch crossing has increased over the years, reaching a value of $\langle\mu\rangle \approx 62$ during Run 3.

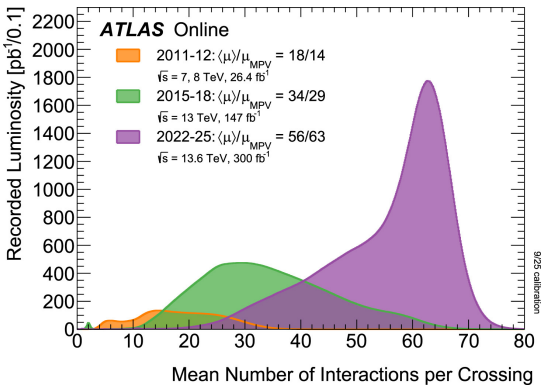



**Figure 2.5** Pile-Up distribution in ATLAS from Run 1 to Run 3. Figure from Ref. [32].

### 2.2.2 Electromagnetic Showers

Before discussing the hadronic showers, which are essential in the formation of jets, the main focus of this thesis, it is important to introduce a similar and equally important type of shower, the electromagnetic one. Electromagnetic showers develop when high-energy electrons or photons interact with heavy materials. They are the basis of the electromagnetic calorimeter design, which is used to measure the energy of electrons and photons (Sec. 2.3.5). The passive material, or absorber, is typically a high-Z material with a high probability of interacting with the incoming particles. These interactions reduce particles' energy and slowly stop them.
Electromagnetic showers develop via two primary mechanisms: bremsstrahlung and pair production. Electrons (and positrons) lose energy via bremsstrahlung, which can be defined as the emission of photons (radiation). Those photons undergo pair production, converting them into electron-positron pairs which then emit more photons via bremsstrahlung. This cycle repeats until electrons and photons lose their kinetic energies.
The count of particles involved in the cascade grows exponentially, forming a literal *shower* of particles, as shown in Fig 2.6.

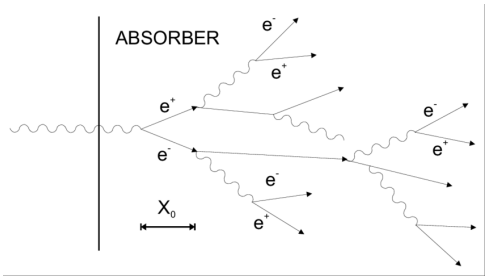



**Figure 2.6** Schematic of an electromagnetic shower starting from a photon.

The fundamental parameter of the electromagnetic shower is the radiation length $X_0$, the mean distance over which an electron loses a factor $1/e$ of its energy. A

typical EM shower has a longitudinal profile of $\sim 20\ X_0$. The calorimeter must be deep enough to contain the entire shower and measure the energy of the incoming particle.

### 2.2.3 Hadronic Showers

Hadronic showers develop when particles subject to the strong interaction collide with nuclei in the calorimeter passive absorber. These inelastic collisions initiate a nuclear cascade with complex modelling. The shower, in fact, contains both an electromagnetic and a hadronic component. Neutral pions ($\pi^0$), for instance, decay immediately into photon pairs, initiating the electromagnetic sub-showers presented before. Charged pions ($\pi^{\pm}$), instead, continue to undergo strong interactions, producing secondary hadrons.
The characteristic scale of the hadronic shower development is the interaction length $\lambda$, a scale much larger than $X_0$. Again, the hadronic calorimeter needs to be deep enough to manage the containment of the entire shower.

## 2.3 The ATLAS detector

A Toroidal LHC ApparatuS (ATLAS) [33] is the world's largest collider particle detector, situated at Interaction Point 1 at CERN. 44m in length and 25m in height are required to investigate collisions between particles accelerated by the LHC, to study phenomena such dark matter, the Higgs boson and top quark. The ATLAS detector is composed of multiple sub-detectors organized in layers with a cylindrical symmetry around the beam pipe. Among the main sub-detectors we can find: the Inner Detector (ID), the Electromagnetic Calorimeter (ECal), the Hadronic Calorimeter (HCal) and the Muon Spectrometer (MS), as shown in Fig. 2.7.

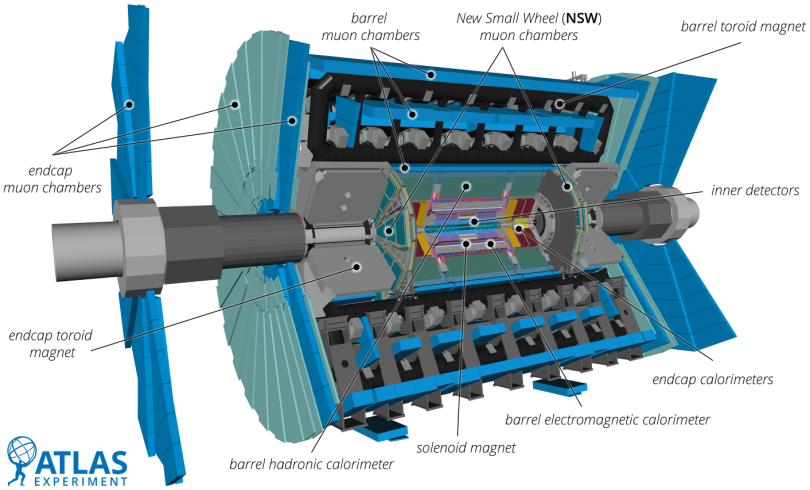



**Figure 2.7** ATLAS schematic. Figure from Ref. [34].

### 2.3.1 Coordinate system

Before analysing the ATLAS detector, it is important to introduce the coordinate system used to describe the position of particles and their momenta inside the sub-detectors. In Fig. 2.8 an overview of the system is presented.

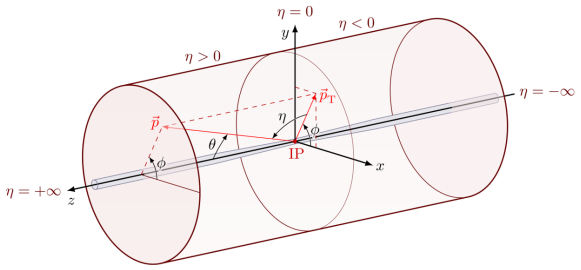



**Figure 2.8** Schematic of ATLAS coordinate system

Cartesian axes $(x,y,z)$ are constructed as follows. The origin is set in the interaction point (IP). From it, the z-axis departs parallel to the beam tunnel with positive z-values in anticlockwise direction. As a direct consequence, the x-y plane is perpendicular to it, with positive x-values towards the center of the LHC and positive y-values upward. On this Cartesian system, a more natural cylindrical coordinate system $(r, \theta, \phi)$ is defined to describe geometric position and components of particle momenta. $r$ is the absolute distance from the interaction point. $\phi$ is the azimuth angle, measured around the z-axis, with values $[-\pi, \pi]$. $\theta$ is the polar angle, measured starting from the z-axis, with values $[0, \pi]$.
Two more coordinates are defined to describe the position of particles in the detector: the rapidity $y$ and the pseudo-rapidity $\eta$. They are defined as:

$$y = \frac{1}{2} ln\left(\frac{E + p_z}{E - p_z}\right) = \text{arctanh}\left(\frac{p_z}{E}\right) \tag{2.7}$$

$$\eta = -ln\left[tan\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)\right] = \text{arctanh}\left(\frac{p_z}{\mid \vec{p} \mid}\right) \tag{2.8}$$

where $\vec{p}$ is the three-momentum of the particle and $p_z$ is its component along the z-axis. $E$ represents the energy of the particle. $y$ and $\eta$ get values in the range $[-\infty, \infty]$, being zero for $\theta = \pi/2$ and $\pm\infty$ for $\theta = 0$ or $\theta = \pi$.
A schematic of the connection between the pseudo-rapidity and the polar angle $\theta$ is shown in Fig. 2.9.
These latter two variables are introduced because the difference of rapidities between two particles is a Lorentz invariant quantity under boosts along the z-axis. Since Lorentz boosts are applied to move from the laboratory frame to the center-of-mass frame of the colliding particles, $\eta$ and $y$ are widely used instead of the polar angle $\theta$. In case of an ultra-relativistic particle, the rapidity and the pseudo-rapidity are approximately equal, $\eta \approx y$, as shown in Eq. 2.7 and Eq. 2.8. The main difference between the two is that the rapidity depends both on the energy of the particle and its momentum, a combined measurement not trivial at high energies, while the

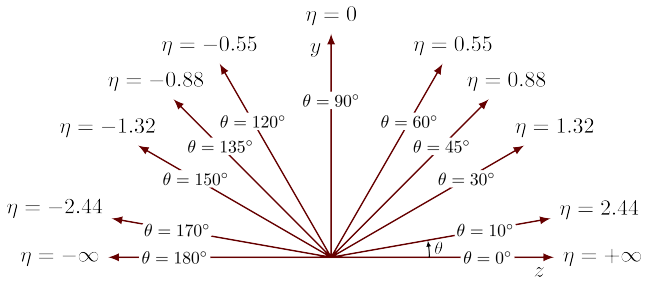



**Figure 2.9** Schematic of pseudo-rapidity as a function of the polar angle $\theta$.

pseudo-rapidity depends only on the particle's momentum. For these reasons, the pseudo-rapidity is preferred to the rapidity, making $(r, \eta, \phi)$ the used coordinate system. With such choice of coordinates, the detector components placed at high values of pseudo-rapidity are addressed as *forward region*.
The pseudo-rapidity and the azimuth angle, are used to define a geometrical distance, applied when computing the separation between two massive physics objects:

$$\Delta R = \sqrt{\Delta y^2 + \Delta \phi^2} \tag{2.9}$$

Prior to an analysis of materials, some more useful quantities are defined. The first one is the transverse momentum $p_T$, which is the projection of the momentum of the particle in the transverse plane $(x, y)$ of the interaction, defined as:

$$p_T = \sqrt{p_x^2 + p_y^2} \tag{2.10}$$

The importance of this variables relies in the fact that the particles collided at the LHC, protons, are not elementary particles, but composite states of partons. The result of this is that the energy of the center-of-mass of the colliding partons is not known, since it depends on the momentum fraction $x$ of the partons inside the protons. On the other hand, collisions happen mostly along the z-axis, generating Lorentz boosts mainly along this axis. This means that the transverse plane is not affected by these boosts, making the kinematics closed in this plane. For this reason, the transverse momentum $p_T$ is used to define the kinematics of the events, instead of the total momentum $|\vec{p}|$.
Similarly, the transverse energy $E_T$ is defined as the projection of the energy of the particle in the transverse plane $(x, y)$ of the interaction, defined as:

$$E_T = E \cdot \frac{p_T}{|\vec{p}|} \tag{2.11}$$

A fundamental variable for the purposes of this thesis is the invariant mass $m_{inv}$, which is associated to the energy of a system of particles. In the case of two particles, using their four-momenta $P_1$ and $P_2$, $m_{inv}$ is defined as:

$$m_{inv} = \sqrt{(P_1 + P_2)^2} = \sqrt{(E_1 + E_2)^2 - |\vec{p_1} + \vec{p_2}|^2} \tag{2.12}$$

The invariant mass is a Lorentz invariant quantity, which is used to measure the mass of a resonant state, composed of a particle decaying into two others. In fact,

the invariant mass of the system will be equal to the mass of the mother particle. Based on what has been discussed on Lorentz boosts at the LHC, the sum of the the transverse momenta of the events is expected to be zero, since the initial state of the collision has no transverse momentum. For this reason, if a particle is not detected, as it happens with neutrinos, its transverse momentum, known as missing transverse momentum $\vec{p_T^{miss}}$, can be computed as the opposite of the sum of the transverse momenta of all the detected particles in the event:

$$\vec{p_T^{miss}} = -\sum_i \vec{p}_{T,i} \tag{2.13}$$

The computed variable is shown graphically in Fig. 2.10, where the missing transverse momentum is represented as the opposite of the vectorial sum of the transverse momenta of all the detected particles in the event.

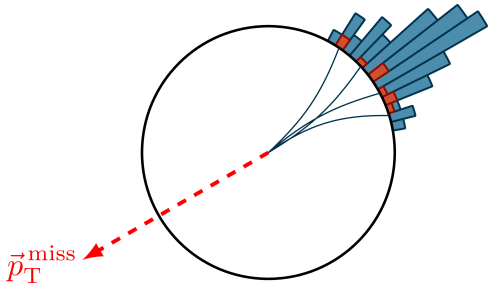



**Figure 2.10** Schematic of missing transverse momentum computation.

### 2.3.2 Magnetic system

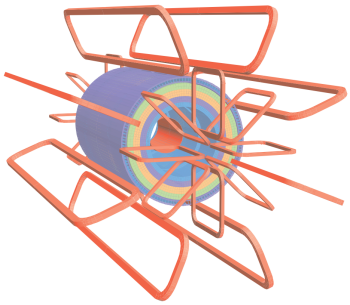


**Figure 2.11** ATLAS magnetic system. Figure form Ref. [35].

Magnetic fields play a crucial role in the ATLAS detector, allowing the tracking of charged particles and the measurement of their momenta via the sagitta method [36]. The ATLAS detector relies on a hybrid superconducting magnet system composed of four sub-components: a central solenoid, a barrel toroid and two end-cap toroids [35]. This complex system was adopted to reduce particle interactions with inactive material and, more importantly, to obtain a higher momentum resolution. Cooled to 4.5 K using liquid helium, the system covers a total volume of 26 m in length and 21 m in outer diameter. A schematic of the ATLAS magnetic system is shown in

Fig. 2.11.
The central solenoid is positioned inside the calorimetry system directly around the Inner Detector cavity, where it generates a highly uniform 2 T axial magnetic field parallel to the beam pipe deflecting charged particles in the transverse plane. It measures 5.3 m in length, 19 cm in thickness and an inner diameter of 2.44 m. To minimize dead material in front of the Electromagnetic Calorimeter, the solenoid shares a single cryostat vessel and supportive cylinder with the barrel ECal.
Providing the deflection field for the outer Muon Spectrometer, the barrel toroid is composed of eight large rectangular coils mounted radially with eight-fold azimuthal symmetry around the calorimeters. Extending 25.3 m in length with inner and outer diameters of 9.4 m and 20.1 m, respectively, it generates a peak magnetic field 3.9 T. Two smaller end-cap toroid structures, 5 m long with an inner and an outer diameter of 1.65 m and 10.7 m respectively, are inserted into each end of the barrel to extend coverage into forward regions. They generate a peak field 4.1 T. Both the barrel and end-cap toroids bend charged particles in the longitudinal plane.

### 2.3.3 Particle tracking

As mentioned in the previous section, magnets are fundamental to measure the momentum of charged particles. In fact, when a charged particle enters a magnetic field, it is deflected by the Lorentz force, leading to a curved trajectory, whose radius of curvature is proportional to the momentum of the particle. By measuring the curvature of the track, the momentum can be inferred.
The method used to measure the particle momentum is the sagitta method [36], where the sagitta $s$ is defined as the distance between the midpoint of the chord connecting two points on the track and the track itself. The sagitta is related to the radius of curvature $R$, the length of the chord $L$ and the angle $\theta$ under the arc by the following equation:

$$s = R\left[1 - cos\left(\frac{\theta}{2}\right)\right] \simeq \frac{L^2}{8R} \tag{2.14}$$

where the assumption of small angles was used in the final step.
Making use of the relation 2.2 between the radius of curvature $R$, the momentum $p$ and the magnetic field $B$, the sagitta can be expressed as:

$$p = \frac{0.3BL^2}{8s} \tag{2.15}$$

As direct consequence of this latter equation, the reltive uncertainty on the momentum measurement is equal to the relative uncertainty on the sagitta measurement, $\frac{\Delta p}{p} = \frac{\Delta s}{s}$, which, using $\sigma_x$ position uncertainty and N number of measured points, leads to:

$$\frac{\sigma_p}{p} = \frac{\sigma_x[m]}{0.3BL^2[Tm^2]}\sqrt{\frac{720}{N+5}}p[GeV] \tag{2.16}$$

From Eq. 2.16 it is evident that the momentum resolution can improve with a stronger magnetic field, a longer track length and a higher number of measured points but it worsens with higher momentum particles since $\frac{\sigma_p}{p} \propto p$ .

### 2.3.4 The Inner Detector

The Inner Detector (ID) [37] is the closest system to the interaction point. Its function is to reconstruct the trajectories of charged particles, measure their transverse momentum and identify both primary and secondary interaction vertices of decays. Covering a pseudo-rapidity region of $|\eta| \leq 2.5$, 7.02 m long and 2.30 in diameter, it is inserted in the central solenoid (Sec. 2.3.2), providing the tracking sub-systems an external magnetic field of 2 T parallel to the beam axis. In order to balance both optimal resolution, material budget and radiation exposure, the ID utilizes three concentric silicon-based tracking technologies organized radially outward from the beam pipe: the Pixel Detector, the Semiconductor Tracker (SCT) and the Transition Radiation Tracker (TRT). In Fig. 2.12 a schematic of the ID is shown.

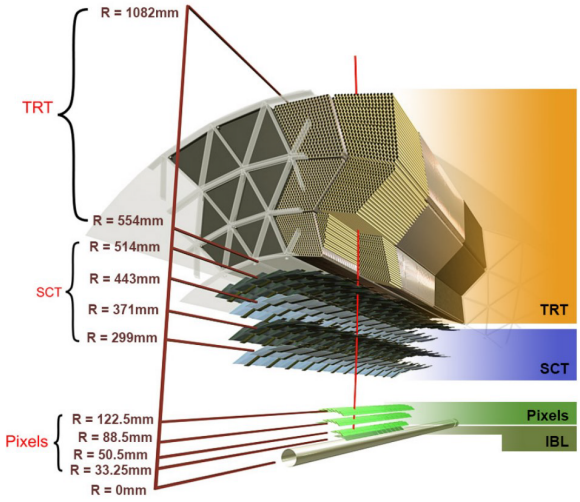



**Figure 2.12** 3D representation of the ATLAS inner detector. Figure form Ref. [38].

#### Pixel Detector

The closest system to the beam pipe is the Pixel Detector. It is composed of three pixel layers placed at distance of 50.5 mm, 88.5 mm and 122.5 mm from the IP respectively in the barrel. In the end-caps, there are installed three disks on each side located between $z = \pm 495$ mm and $\pm 650$ mm. The pixel system has the finest granurality, delivering a spatial resolution of 10 $\mu$m in the $(r, \phi)$ plane and 115 $\mu$m along the longitudinal $z$-axis.
During LS1, an additional innermost layer was added at $r = 33.25$ mm. It is called the Insertable B-Layer (IBL) and it was added to improve the tracking performance, providing coverage up to $|\eta| = 2.58$ and to increase the radiation resistence of the ID.

#### SemiConductor Tracker

Outside the Pixel Detector, the SemiConductor Tracker (SCT) is positioned. It is composed of four barrel layers at distances between 299 mm and 514 mm and 18 overall end-cap disks. SCT delivers a spatial resolution of 16 $\mu$m in the $(r, \phi)$ plane

and 580 $\mu$m along the longitudinal $z$-axis.

### Transition Radiation Tracker

The outermost region of the ID is composed of the Transition Radiation Tracker (TRT) situated between 554 mm and 1082 mm from the IP. Unlike the inner silicon-based detectors, the TRT consists of approximately 300,000 polyimide drift tubes, 4 mm each in diameter and equipped with a central gold-plated tungsten wire. The tubes are filled with a gas mixture based on Xenon-$CO_2$-$O_2$ (70%-27%-3%). TRT provides a single-hit spatial resolution of 130 $\mu$m in the barrel region with $|\eta| < 0.7$. In the end-caps, with $0.7 \leq |\eta| \leq 2.0$ the structure of the tubes is the one of disk, as for the other systems. The main feature of TRT is to provide continuous tracking by recording an average of 36 hits per charged track. Additionally, it is able to distinguish electrons from other objects by detecting the transition radiation photons which are emitted when charged particles cross the active materials inside the tubes.

## 2.3.5 Calorimeters

Calorimeters are used in ATLAS to measure the energy of particles by means of a destructive measurement on the particles. For this reason, calorimeters in ATLAS are placed outside the Inner Detector, allowing a complete reconstruction of the particle trajectory before it is absorbed [39].
Covering a region up to $|\eta| < 4.9$, the calorimetry system features sampling technology with dense absorbers alternated with active media to completely contain electromagnetic and hadronic showers. The idea behind this technique is to have a low probability of signals in the muon spectrometer from a particle different from a muon, which is the only particle that should cross the calorimeter without being absorbed (apart from not interacting particle such as neutrinos).
Liquid argon (LAr) serves as the active material, while being kept at a temperature of 88.5 K by three cryostats. When a charged particle crosses LAr, light is produced, which is collected by wavelength-shifting fibers and routed to photo-multipliers (PMTs) for the conversion to signal.
The calorimeter complex in ATLAS is divided into two components: the Electromagnetic Calorimeter (ECal) and the Hadronic Calorimeter (HCal). A schematic of the complex can be seen in Fig. 2.13.

### Electromagnetic Calorimeter

The LAr ECal is composed of lead (Pb) absorbers (passive material) separated by LAr gaps (active material) with an accordion-shaped geometry. This particular layout is chosen to obtain high sampling rate while keeping a fast signal extraction time, ensuring uniform cover in $\phi$. As previous systems, also ECal has a symmetric structure, with three main components: the barrel, with coverage $|\eta| \leq 1.475$ and the two end-caps in the range $1.35 \leq |\eta| \leq 3.2$. The region $1.37 \leq |\eta| \leq 1.52$ is known as *crack-region*, given the large amount of inactive material present in this area, which leads to a degraded energy resolution.

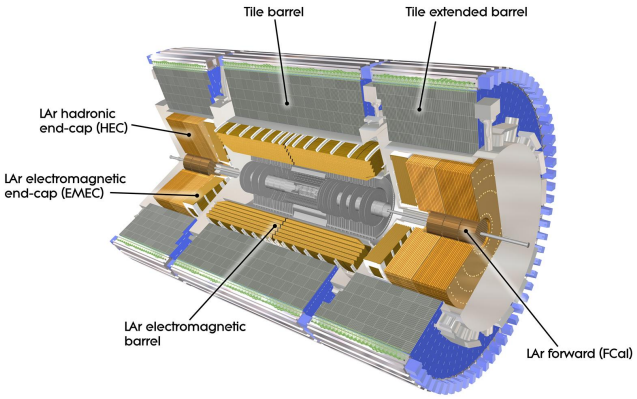



**Figure 2.13** Schematic of the ATLAS calorimeter system. Figure form Ref. [35].

Based on the $\eta$ region, the thickness of the ECal varies between 22 to 33 $X_0$, which is sufficent to contain the full electromagnetic showers.
The ECal is structured in three layers in the radial direction, each with a different granularity in $\eta$ and $\phi$. The first layer has a fine granularity in $\eta$, enabling the discrimination between showers coming from electrons, photons or neutral pions. The second layer collects the majority of the electromagnetic shower energy, with fine granulality in both coordinates. The third and final layer measures high-energy shower tails.
The ECal energy resolution has been measured during test-beams and, as a function of the beam energy, it is computed as:

$$\frac{\sigma_E}{E} = \frac{10.1\%}{\sqrt{E[\text{GeV}]}} \oplus 0.17\% \tag{2.17}$$

where the first term is the stochastic term, dominant at low energies, summed in quadrature with the term accounting for the non-uniform response of the detector.
A schematic representation of the ATLAS ECal is shown in Fig. 2.14.

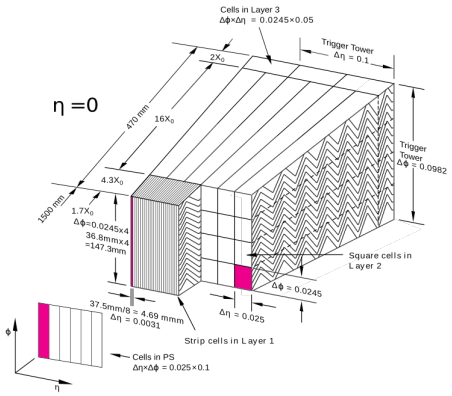



**Figure 2.14** Schematic view of the accordion shape of the ATLAS ECal at $\eta = 0$. Figure form Ref. [40].

### Hadronic Calorimeter

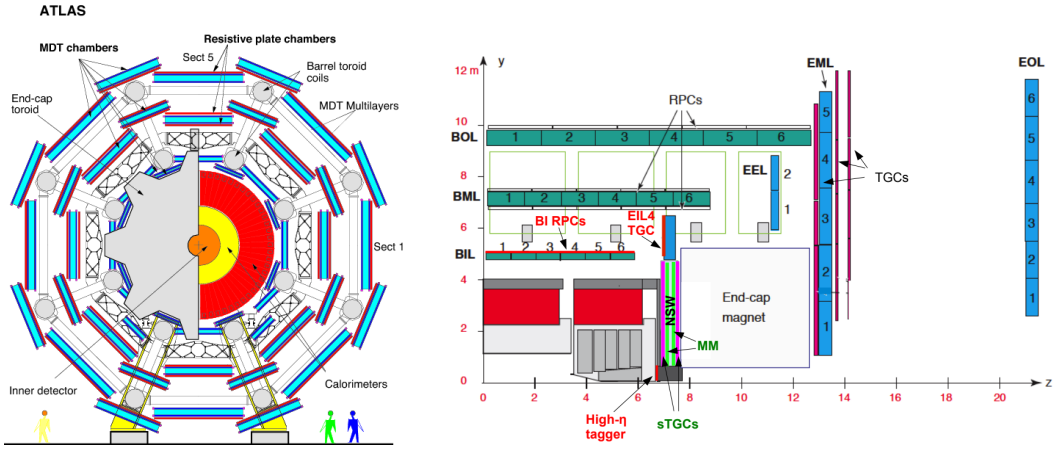
Hadronic energy measurements are handlead by the HCal, which is composed of three sub-sections: the Tile calorimeter, the Hadronic End-Cap Calorimeter (HEC) and the Forward Calorimeter (FCal). The Tile calorimeter is a sampling calorimeter with steel as absorber and scintillating tiles as active material, covering the central region of the detector with $|\eta| \leq 1.7$. With an inner diameter of 4.46 m and a outer one of 8.50 m, it covers 7.4 $\lambda$ (the interaction length) at $\eta = 0$.
The HEC is based on two wheels per end-cap, with copper as absorber material covering up to 5.7 $\lambda$. With an outer diameter of 4.06 m, it covers the intermediate region of the detector with $1.5 \leq |\eta| \leq 3.2$.
In conclusion, the FCal covers the region $3.1 \leq |\eta| \leq 4.9$ and it is the closest component of the calorimeter system to the beam pipe. It is composed of three modules (FCal1, FCal2, FCal3), with copper as absorber for the FCal1, reaching 27.6 $X_0$, and tungsten for the other two, which allows to reach 90 $X_0$. The FCal is designed to resist to high radiation doses, being exposed to a high flux of particles, since a big fraction of collisions is associated with low momentum transfer.
The overall hadronic calorimeter resolution can be parametrized as:

$$\frac{\sigma_E}{E} = \frac{52\%}{\sqrt{E[\text{GeV}]}} \oplus \frac{1.6 \text{ GeV}}{E[\text{GeV}]} \oplus 3.0\% \tag{2.18}$$

where the first term, as for the ECal, is the stochastic term; the second one is associated to the noise from the read-out electronics and the last one is a constant term keeping tracks of unknown effects.

### 2.3.6 Muon spectrometer

The Muon Spectrometer (MS) forms the outermost layer of the ATLAS detector, with a total length of 44 m and an outer diameter of 25 m. Making use of the toroid magnets (Sec. 2.3.2) and the sagitta method (Sec. 2.3.3), it tracks particles with $p_T > 3$ GeV that are not absorbed by the different calorimeters in the region $|\eta| \leq 2.7$, which are mainly muons. Targeting a resolution of 10% for 1 TeV muon tracks, MS is required to measure sagittas down to approximately 500 $\mu$m, which is quite a challenge for the detector. As for the other ATLAS sub-detectors, the MS is organized in a barrel and in an end-cap region. The barrel covers the central region $|\eta| < 1.05$ and it consists of three concentric cylindrical shells placed at radii of 5 m, 7.5 m, and 10 m from the beam line. The two end-cap regions cover the forward zones, $1.05 < |\eta| < 2.7$ for tracking and $1.05 < |\eta| < 2.7$ for Level 1 trigger. The end-cap detectors are divided in Small Wheel, located in front of the end-cap toroids, and Big Wheel, behind them. They are mounted on large perpendicular wheels centered at longitudinal positions $|z| = 7.4$ m, 10.8 m and 21.5 m. A schematic view of the MS is shown in Fig. 2.15.
The tracking and trigger instrumentation follow a 16-fold azimuthal ($\phi$) layout, matching the geometry of the toroidal magnet coils. Sub-detector stations are alternated large sectors, positioned between adjacent coils, and small sectors, covering regions directly aligned with the magnet structures. Precision tracking and




(a) (b)

**Figure 2.15** Fig. 2.15a represents the transverse view of the ATLAS Muon Spectrometer. Fig. 2.15b shows the longitudinal $(z, r)$ view of the MS, plane orthogonal to the magnetic field from the barrel coils and therefore banding plane for muons. Figure from [41].

momentum measurement rely primarily on Monitored Drift Tube (MDT) chambers. Fast triggering is taken care by Resistive Plate Chambers (RPCs).

### Tracking chambers

Each MDT chamber contains aluminum drift tubes of 30 mm diameter and 400 $\mu m$ thick wall, filled with an Ar:$CO_2$ gas mixture (93%:7%) at a pressure of 3 bar. A central tungsten-rhenium anode wire of 50 $\mu$m diameter is insterted in the tubes. It operates at 3080 V, providing a gas gain of order $10^4$ and yielding a muon sagitta resolution of $\sigma_S = 45$ $\mu$m. The drift chambers are composed of multi-layers of MDTs, each one containing three or four tube layers separated by aluminum spacers. Optical alignment systems continuously monitor structural deformations to preserve the tracking resolution. Alignment represents the dominant source of uncertainty in high $p_T$ muon measurements; with low momentum particles, the uncertainty is dominated by fluctuations in the energy deposit.
To sustain expected HL-LHC background conditions, the original Small Wheels were completely replaced for Run 3 by the New Small Wheel (NSW) system. It introduces two complementary thin-gap technologies across 16 sectors per wheel: resistive-strip MicroMegas (MMs) for precision tracking and Thin Gap Chambers (TGCs) for fast triggering. MMs modules employ a $\sim$ 130 $\mu$m amplification gap defined by a metallic micro-mesh, achieving a 100 $\mu$m spatial resolution.

### Trigger chambers

In the barrel region ($|\eta| < 1.05$), doublets and triplets of Resistive Plate Chambers (RPCs) are mounted. They function as continuous gaseous detectors operating without wires, built from parallel bakelite plates separated by a 2 mm gas gap operating under an electric field of 4.9 kV/mm. RPC readout strips achieve an exceptional timing resolution of 1.5 ns and spatial resolution of 10 mm both in $z$

and $\phi$ direction.
In the forward end-caps ($1.05 < |\eta| < 2.4$), fast triggering is handled by TGCs, which are designed to work under high flux of particles. They utilize a 3.2 mm strip pitch to provide a 4 ns time resolution and a spatial resolution of 2-6 mm in the bending plane and 3-7 mm in the non-bending plane.

### 2.3.7 Trigger system

At the LHC, proton bunches collide every 25 ns, resulting in a collision rate of 40 MHz and a projected data occupancy of $60\times10^6$ MBs$^{-1}$. Clearly, the ATLAS detector cannot record all of these events. The ATLAS Trigger and Data Acquisition (TDAQ) system [41, 42] is designed to select interesting events for further analysis while discarding uninteresting ones, reducing the data rate by five orders of magnitude to a manageable level. This reduction relies on a two level scheme: Level-1 (L1) and High-Level Trigger (HLT). An overview of the ATLAS TDAQ system is shown in Fig. 2.16.

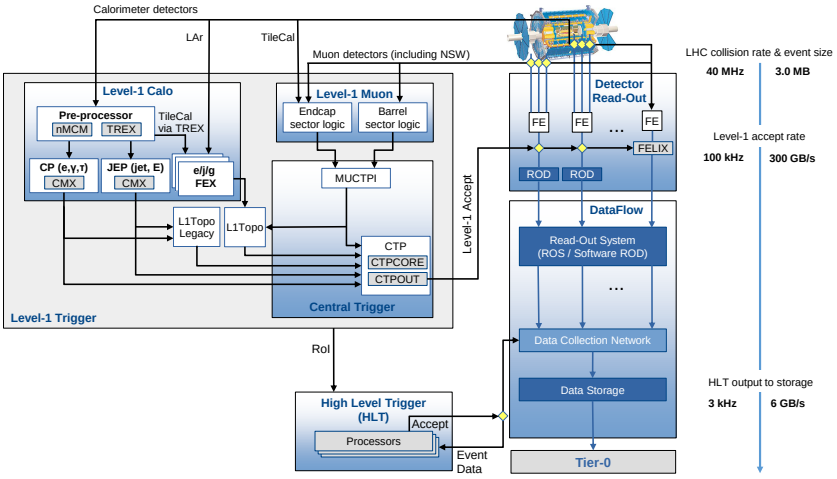



**Figure 2.16** Schematic view of the ATLAS TDAQ system in Run 3. Figure form Ref. [41].

The L1 trigger, implemented using custom electronics, reduces the event rate to 100 kHz, which is the maximum rate that the ATLAS readout system can handle. It operates with a latency (time needed to take the decision) below 2.5 $\mu$s. The L1 Trigger searches for objects like electrons, photons, jets, $\tau$-leptons, large $E_T$ and large $E_T^{miss}$ using reduced-granularity information from the calorimeters (L1Calo). Events containing high-$p_T$ muons, instead, are hunted by muon system (L1Muon), composed of the RPCs and TGCs. If an event passes the L1 selection, it is sent to the HLT, together with some Regions of Interest (RoIs) identified by the L1 trigger. The HLT then processes the buffered events, operating at higher levels of detail than

the previous stage. It operates using full-granularity information from the ATLAS sub-detectors. To minimize network bandwidth, the algorithms initially focus on RoIs, defined in $\eta$ and $\phi$ coordinates by the L1 stage. With a latency of 550 ms, the HLT reduces the event rate to approximately 3 kHz before storage.
Dedicated streams organize the stored events. While the primary physics stream retains full event information, the Trigger-Level Analysis (TLA) stream saves only partial reconstructed objects, bypassing bandwidth bottlenecks for high-rate processes. Accepted data is finally transferred to Tier-0 for offline processing.

### 2.3.8 The ATLAS Simulation Infrastructure

In order to interpret the data collected by the ATLAS detector and compare it with theoretical predictions, a detailed simulation of the detector response is required. The ATLAS simulation infrastructure is integrated within the Athena software framework [43], implementing the GEANT4 simulation toolkit to simulate the interaction of particles with matter [44].
This process is composed of two main steps: the *simulation* and the *digitization*. In the first one, Monte Carlo (MC) generators calculate the short-distance hard scattering, followed by parton showering, ignoring the detector geometry. After this, the generated particles with a proper lifetime $c\tau \geq 10$ mm are propagated through the detector geometry, using the GEANT4 toolkit. It simulates particles' interactions with the detector material and it records the energy deposits, together with the position and time of particles, referred as *hits*. Truth-level information is preserved throughout the process to track the exact parent-daughter decay trees.
The digitization step converts the previously cited hits into simulated electronic signals, emulating the readout electronics. To replicate realistic run conditions, the hits are combined with events due to cavern backgrounds and electronic noise. Soft QCD events are overlaid too, in order to model pile-up effects. The output of this stage are into Raw Data Objects, delivering a data format identical to the real detector readout. Consequently, identical reconstruction software used for real data are applied to simulated ones.
In conclusion, simulated events are re-weighted to match the average pile-up distribution observed in data.

# Chapter 3

# Hadron reconstruction in ATLAS

Before running the analysis, the signals recorded by the different ATLAS sub-detectors must be transformed into physical objects to deal with. In this chapter, the reconstruction of jets is presented, since they are the main objects of interest for the analysis conducted in this thesis.

## 3.1 Tracks reconstruction in ID

The ATLAS detector relies on a complex magnetic system, as described in Sec. 2.3.2, to bend the trajectories of charged particles, allowing for the measurement of their momentum. The starting point of these measurements is the reconstruction of charged particle trajectories, or *tracks*, in the Inner Detector (ID). They can be identified by groups of three-dimensional spatial points known as *hits*. Given the magnetic field configuration, tracks in the ID follow helicoidal trajectories, which can be described by the parameters: the transverse momentum $p_T$, the azimuthal angle $\phi$, the polar angle $\theta$, the impact parameter $d_0$, the longitudinal impact parameter $z_0$ and $q/p$, the momentum dividing the charge. Those parameters are graphically represented in Fig. 3.1.

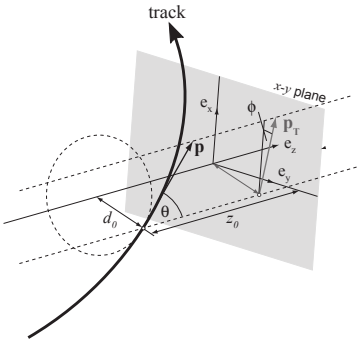



**Figure 3.1** Parameters describing a track in the ATLAS detector. Figure form Ref. [45].

The tracks are reconstructed using an *inside-out tracking* strategy, starting from the innermost layers of the ID and moving outwards, with the requirement of at least 8 hits and $p_{\mathrm{T}} > 500$ MeV . The reconstruction algorithm begins by identifying clusters of hits in both the Pixel and SCT sub-detectors. Those clusters then form *track seeds*, which are composed by triplets of them. Using a combinatorial Kalman filter, the track seeds are extended into full track candidates, on which a global $\chi^2$ minimization fit is performed to determine the initial trajectory parameters. After adding compatible hits from the TRT sub-detector, if the requirements are satisfied, another fit with higher precision is performed to refine the track parameters.
The tracks which have been reconstructed as described above, are then stored and used to reconstruct the primary interaction vertex (PV). Among all vertices, the one with the largest scalar sum of squared track transverse momenta, $\sum p_{\mathrm{T}}^2$, is identified as the vertex of the hard scattering (HS) and its position is taken as reference point to reconstruct all the other objects.

## 3.2 Jets reconstruction

As described in Sec. 2.2, the scattering of two partons in a *pp* collision produces high-energy quarks and gluons, which undergo a process of parton showering and hadronization, producing collimated sprays of particles, which are known as *jets*. A schematic of the jets nature is presented in Fig. 3.2.

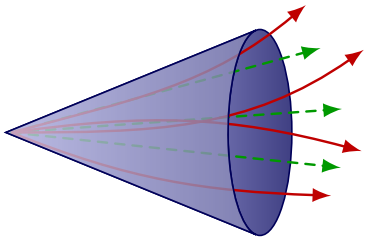


**Figure 3.2** Drawing of a jet, showing the cone of particles produced by the hadronization of a parton.

Jets costituents then form hadrons due to the QCD colour confinement, which are detected by the ATLAS sub-detectors.
The reconstruction of jets is a complex process, which requires the combination of information from different sub-detectors. The diffent components of the spray are detected and reconstructed as different objects, which are then combined to form the final jet object. The combination is the not trivial part and dedicated algorithms have been developed to perform it.

### 3.2.1 Jet constituents reconstruction

The reconstruction of jets starts with the reconstruction of their constituents, which are the physical objects detected by the ATLAS sub-detectors. This process uses different algorithms depending on the target physics regime and kinematic regime,

combining the measurements of the ID with those from calorimeters. The common starting point is the clustering of calorimeter cells, which are grouped into *topological clusters*.

### Topoclusters

Topoclusters, or jet topological clusters, are three-dimensional clusters of energy deposits in calorimeter cells. They dynamically adapt their spatial volume based on the topology of the energy shower across both the LAr and Tile calorimeter layers. The formation of topoclusters is controlled by the parameter $\zeta_{cell}$, the cell signal significance[46], computed as the ratio between the signal $E_{cell}$ and the average noise $\sigma_{noise,cell}$ in the cell:

$$\zeta_{cell} = \frac{E_{cell}}{\sigma_{noise,cell}} \tag{3.1}$$

All the cells with $\zeta_{cell} \geq 4$ are considered as seeds for the topocluster formation. Starting from these seed cells, the cluster is grown by adding adjacent cells with lower significance, $\zeta_{cell} \geq 2$. Finally, all the cells with $\zeta_{cell} \geq 0$ are added to the cluster if they are adjacent to a cell already added to the cluster.
In the case of overlapping particle showers, the topocluster can contain multiple local energy maxima, which are then split into two separate clusters, with the requirement $E_{\text{cell}} > 500$ MeV.
To each topocluster is assigned a four-momentum $P_{\text{clus}}$ and it is treated as a pseudo-particle. In fact the mass is set to zero, since there is no information about the mass of the particles producing the energy deposits, and the energy is computed as the sum of the energies of the cells in the cluster:

$$E_{\text{clus}} = \sum_i E_{\text{cell},i} \tag{3.2}$$

The direction parameters of the cluster, $\eta_{clus}, \phi_{clus}$, are determined from the energy-weighted barycenter of the cluster relative to the nominal origin of the ATLAS coordinate system:

$$\eta_{\text{clus}} = \frac{\sum_i |E_{\text{cell},i}|\eta_{\text{cell},i}}{\sum_i |E_{\text{cell},i}|}, \qquad \phi_{\text{clus}} = \frac{\sum_i |E_{\text{cell},i}|\phi_{\text{cell},i}}{\sum_i |E_{\text{cell},i}|} \tag{3.3}$$

Absolute cell energies are utilized in the denominator weighting to prevent directional bias from negative cell energy fluctuations induced by noise or pile-up subtraction. Those kinematic variables are used to distinguish between electromagnetic and hadronic showers. In fact, as described in Sec. 2.2.3, hadronic showers contain also EM components, resulting in the fact that the reconstructed clusters are only partially hadronic. For this reason, after Local Cell Weighting (LCW) calibrations of the topoclusters, a probability $P_{\text{EM}}^{\text{clus}}$ is assigned. It tells us the probabilty that the deposit is electromagnetic versus hadronic. Topoclusters with $P_{\text{EM}}^{\text{clus}} < 0.5$ are identified as hadronic, otherwise they are identified as electromagnetic.

### Particle Flow (PFlow)

The Particle Flow (PFlow) algorithm [47] is built to optimize the reconstruction of jets with lower transverse momentum, 0.5 GeV $\leq p_T \leq$ 40 GeV. This algorithm relies on the fact that at lower energies, the momentum resolution is higher than the energy one. This feature is evident in the formulas associated with the two resolutions, Eq. 2.16 and Eq. 2.18, which show the different scalings with respect to the momentum ($\sigma_{p_T}/p_T \propto p_T$) and energy ($\sigma_E/E \propto 1/\sqrt{E}$) respectively.
The algorithm begins by the selection of the tracks to target: 0.5 GeV $\leq p_T \leq$ 40 GeV, $|\eta| < 2.5$, at least 9 silicon hits, zero pixel holes and $E_{clus}/p_{trk} > 0.1$ ($E_{clus}$ is the energy of the matched topocluster and $p_{trk}$ is the momentum of the track). After this, PFlow subtracts from the matched topoclusters the expected energy deposit from charged hadrons of the selected tracks, replacing it with the expected energy deposit estimated from the track momentum $p_{trk}$, ensuring higher resolution. If the residual energy of a topocluster after subtraction is consistent with fluctuations expected from a single-particle signal, the remnant cluster is completely removed. If significant energy remains, it is treated as a neutral energy remnant.
The finalized PFlow constituents consist of selected charged tracks for charged hadrons and un-subtracted or remnant topoclusters for neutral hadrons and photons.

### Track Calo-Clusters (TCCs)

The angular separation between the products of hadronic decays is highly reduced in the case of highly boosted regimes. The high track density and calorimeter energy overlap degrade the performance of the PFlow algorithm. Track-CaloClusters (TCCs) offer a solution to this limitation [48]. They combine the track directional precision with topocluster energy measurements. TCCs match the tracks, which are extrapolated from the primary vertex to calorimeters, with topoclusters if their relative angular separation satisfies:

$$\Delta R < \sqrt{\sigma^2_{\text{clus}} + \sigma^2_{\text{trk}}} \tag{3.4}$$

In the equation above $\sigma_{clus}$ is the topocluster width and $\sigma_{trk}$ represents the track extrapolation uncertainty. Unlike PFlow, TCCs do not perform energy subtraction; instead PU is removed.
The TCC objects preserve fine angular substructure within large-radius ($R = 1.0$) jets, improving jet mass and substructure observable resolutions ($\tau_{21}, D_2$).

### Unified Flow Objects (UFO)

While PFlow excels at low $p_T$ and TCCs dominate in highly boosted regimes, Unified Flow Objects (UFO) synthesize the two methodologies into a single unified input [49].
UFO are built by first executing the PFlow algorithm, where charged PFlow objects associated with pile-up interaction vertices are removed. From the remaining neutral PFlow topoclusters uncorrelated soft radiation is removed. The surviving neutral clusters and hard-scatter ID tracks that were not subtracted during the initial step are passed into the TCC cluster-splitting algorithm.

By combining PFlow subtraction at low $p_T$ with TCC angular splitting at high $p_T$, UFO inputs optimize small-radius ($R = 0.4$) and large-radius ($R = 1.0$) jet performance simultaneously across the full momentum spectrum.

### 3.2.2 Constituents combination and jets formation

After having reconstructed the constituents of the jets, they are combined to form the final jet object. The combination is performed applying sequential recombination algorithms, which must satisfy two main requirements: *infrared* and *collinear safety*. The first one, infrared safety, requires that the addition of a soft particle to the jet cluster does not impact on the jet itself. The second one, collinear safety, requires jet invariance under the splitting of a constituent particle into two collinear particles. The sequential recombination algorithms are based on the iterative combination of pairs of constituents $(i, j)$, which are combined into a single object if their distance $d_{ij}$ is smaller than the distance $d_{iB}$ between each of them and the beam. These distances are defined as:

$$d_{ij} = min(p_{Ti}^{2k}, p_{Tj}^{2k}) \frac{\Delta R_{ij}^2}{R^2} \ , \quad \mathrm{d_{iB}} = \mathrm{p_{ti}^{2k}} \tag{3.5}$$

where R is the radius parameter of a jet and $p$ is an additional parameter about the power of energy. $p$ could be equal to 1, falling in the $k_t$ algorithm, 0 for the Cambridge/Aachen and -1 in case of anti-$k_t$ algorithm [50].
For the purpose of this thesis, the anti-$k_t$ algorithm is used, since it produces regular cone-like jets around hard seeds and it is less sensitive to soft radiation. Typically in ATLAS large-radius jets are reconstructed with a radius parameter of $R = 1.0$ to collect energy deposits from boosted decays. Small-radius jets, instead, are built with $R = 0.4$ and are usually used to identify highly energetic partons generating a shower.
In Fig. 3.3 an example of anti-$k_t$ application with large-radius jet $R = 1.0$ is shown in the case of a parton-level event associated with soft radiation.

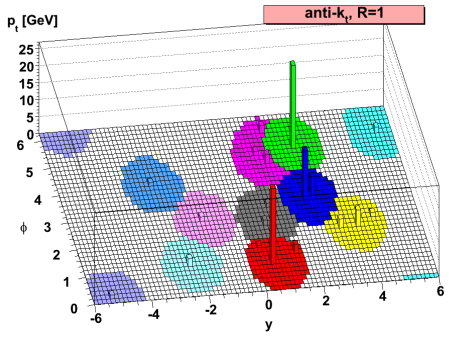



**Figure 3.3** Example of anti-$k_t$ application with large-radius jets. Figure from Ref. [50]

### 3.2.3 Jet calibration

To ensure accurate measurements, a structured calibration workflow is implemented on the reconstructed jets. In the first place, a correction due to the presence of

pile-up is applied. It consists in the subtraction to the jet energy, based on the average energy contribution from PU ($\rho$) and the jet area. This correction is applied making use of MC simulations.
The second step is the Jet Energy Scale (JES) calibration, which accounts for detector response and resolution effects, as well as for the presence of inactive material in the calorimeter. JES is applied matching the reconstructed jets with the corresponding truth jets in MC simulations, and it is derived as a function of the jet $p_T$ and $\eta$.
Another calibration, known as Global Sequential Calibration (GSC), is applied via sequential multiplicative corrections, to absorb residual differences in the ATLAS response due to variations in the energy distributions of constituents or the jet flavor and topology. GSC is derived from energy measurements in certain sections of the experimental apparatus.
Finally, an *in-situ* calibration is applied to correct for residual differences between data and MC simulation, using well-measured reference objects such as photons or $Z$ bosons.
Associated to each approach cited above, a systematic uncertainty is derived, which is then propagated to the final analysis. At low $p_T$ the dominant uncertainty is due to PU and different detector response; JES, which is below 5%, is the main source of uncertainty at high momentum ($p_T > 400$ GeV).
The JER, jet energy resolution, can be espressed, as a function of $p_T$ in a form similar to those for the energy resolution of the calorimeters:

$$\frac{\sigma_{p_T}}{p_T} = \frac{S}{\sqrt{p_T}} \oplus \frac{N}{p_T} \oplus C \tag{3.6}$$

with S the stochastic term associated with detector response, N the noise term and C the constant term associated with jet formation, which is the major contribution at high momentum.

## 3.3 Jet substructure variables

A single hadronic final state can be reconstructed in different ways, from multiple small-radius jets to a single large-radius jet, depending on the boost regime of the event. In the latter case, the reconstructed jet contains the highly collimated decay products of the original parton, which form a subtructure within the jet, differentiating it from the case when the jet is produced by a single parton. In Fig. 3.4 an example is shown of the top quark decaying hadronically in the channel $t \to Wb \to q\bar{q}'b$, in three different boost regimes. In particular, from Fig. 3.4c it is visible that the highly boosted red large-radius jet contains a subtructure of three smaller jets, differentiating it from the case of a single parton small-radius jets, as shown in Fig. 3.4a.
Subtructure can then discriminate between jets originating from different physical processes, such as the three body decay of the top quark, the two body decay of a $W/Z$ boson or a multi-body decay for QCD or BSM jet. Specific variables, based on the kinematic properties of the jet constituents and their spatial distribution within the jet, have been developed to allow this classification. Those variables presented below are used in the analysis conducted in this thesis, as comparison with the results obtained from the Anomaly Detection approach.

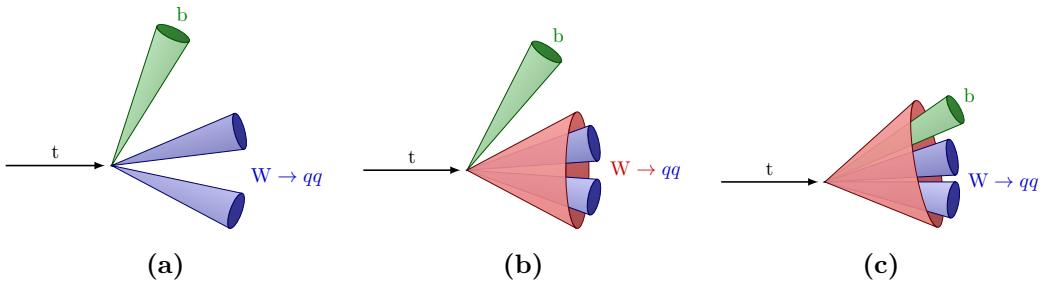



**Figure 3.4** Diagram illustrating different boosted jet regimes of the hadronic top decay and their reconstruction. The three subfigures represent (a) a lowly boosted top quark, (b) a moderately boosted top quark, and (c) a highly boosted top quark. In each case, the decay products of the top quark are shown, along with the corresponding jet reconstruction.

### 3.3.1 $N$-Subjettiness ($\tau_N$)

The $N$-subjettiness [51], denoted as $\tau_N$, is used to quantify the compatibility of a jet reconstruction with an $N$-prong hypothesis. Following the jet reconstruction as described in the previous section, $\tau_N$ is calculated as:

$$\tau_N = \frac{1}{R_0 \sum_i p_{\mathrm{T},i}} \sum_i p_{\mathrm{T},i} \min\left\{\Delta R_{1,i}, \Delta R_{2,i}, \ldots, \Delta R_{N,i}\right\} \tag{3.7}$$

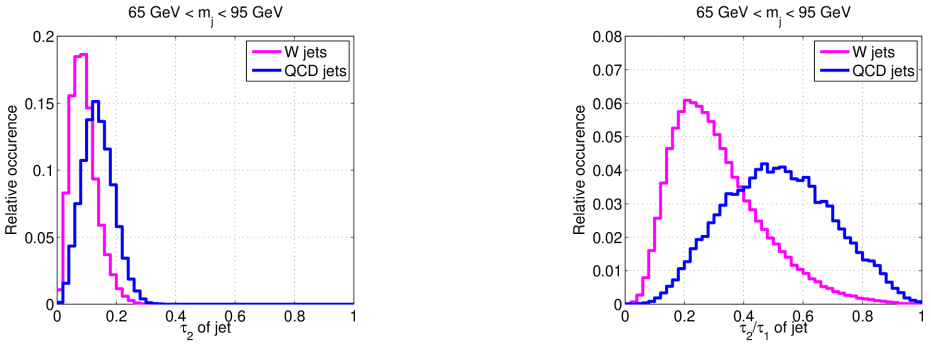
where $i$ runs over all jet constituents, $R_0$ is the jet radius and $\Delta R_{k,i}$ represents the distance between constituent $i$ and subjet axis $k$. Small values of $\tau_N$ indicate that the radiation is aligned with the direction of the $N$ subjects, therefore the jet is compatible with an $N$-prong hypothesis, while large values of $\tau_N$ indicate that the jet are compatible with the $N+1$-prong and higher hypothesis. The ratio of two subjettiness is usually preferred to discriminate between different prong hypotheses. It is defined as:

$$\tau_{N,N-1} = \frac{\tau_N}{\tau_{N-1}} \tag{3.8}$$

The ratio $\tau_{21} = \tau_2/\tau_1$ can isolate two-prong vector boson decays such as $W/Z$ from single-prong QCD jets. $\tau_{32} = \tau_3/\tau_2$, instead, can be used to tag three-prong top quark decays.
In Fig. 3.5 example distributions of $\tau_2$ and $\tau_{21}$ are shown for jets produced in $W$ and QCD processes. It shows that the two-prong hypothesis is more compatible with the former than the latter and this can be identified more easily using the ratio $\tau_{21}$.

### 3.3.2 Energy Correlation Functions (ECFs) and $D_2$

Energy Correlation Functions (ECFs) [52, 53] are used, once again, to tag jets with substructure without necessitating the definition of candidate subjet axis. Referred




(a) (b)

**Figure 3.5** (a) Distribution of $\tau_2$ for jets produced by $W$ and QCD. (b) Distribution of $\tau_{21}$ for the same entities. Figure from Ref. [51]

to the jet $J$, they are defined as:

$$\mathrm{ECF}_0 = 1, \quad \mathrm{ECF}_1 = \sum_{i \in J} p_{\mathrm{T},i} \tag{3.9}$$

$$\mathrm{ECF}_2(\beta) = \sum_{i<j \in J} p_{\mathrm{T},i} p_{\mathrm{T},j} (\Delta R_{ij})^{\beta} \tag{3.10}$$

$$\mathrm{ECF}_3(\beta) = \sum_{i<j<k \in J} p_{\mathrm{T},i} p_{\mathrm{T},j} p_{\mathrm{T},k} (\Delta R_{ij} \Delta R_{ik} \Delta R_{jk})^{\beta} \tag{3.11}$$

where $\beta$, usually set to 1, is an angular weighting exponent. A combination of these function is used to define $D_2$, which is a powerful discriminant to identify two-prong substructure within jets. The $D_2$ variable is derived as:

$$D_2 = \frac{\mathrm{ECF}_3 \cdot (\mathrm{ECF}_1)^3}{(\mathrm{ECF}_2)^3} \tag{3.12}$$

Similarly to $\tau_2$, lower values of $D_2$ are associated with a higher probability of the jet being produced by a two-prong decay, while higher values indicate more probable single-prong origin. An example of the $D_2$ distributions for jets produced by $Z$ and QCD processes is shown in Fig. 3.6.

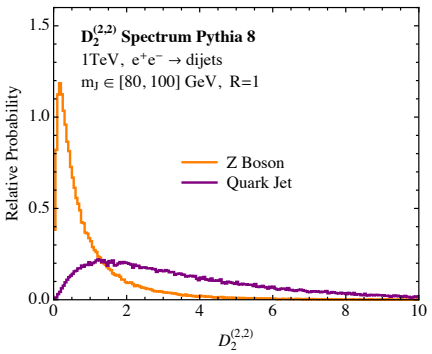



**Figure 3.6** Distribution of $D_2$ for jets produced by $Z$ and QCD. Figure from Ref. [53]

# Chapter 4

# Anomaly Detection

As previously discussed in Sec. 1.2, SM is not a complete theory and the existence of New Physics beyond it has been predicted by many theoretical models. The usual model-dependent searches for BSM physics rely on MC simulations generated for specific BSM hypotheses to define signal-enriched regions. They provide optimized sensitivity for the specific process although they remain blind to a broader scenario and they have not yet produced any significant discoveries. This motivates the exploration of alternative approaches.
*Model-independent searches* are the most common solution, as they do not rely on specific theoretical assumptions [54]. They have been used for a long time among the High Energy Physics (HEP) community to derive limits on the production cross-section of BSM signals. Despite their name, these searches were still too dependent on the theoretical assumptions or on the simulation for the event selection and the background modelling, limiting their power. Beyond that, their sensitivity was limited by the look-elsewhere effect [55].
Anomaly Detection (AD) addresses these constraints by identifying rare patterns without the assumption of a explicit signal hypotheses.

## 4.1 What is Anomaly detection?

Anomaly Detection (AD) [56, 57] is a term used to refer to a series of algorithms involved in the identification of patterns or features among data deviating significantly from a baseline reference distribution. Such deviations are referred to as *anomalies*, *outliers* or *signals*. The baseline, instead, is addressed as *normal* or *background* data. Given their behiavour, anomalies could be generated by a distinct mechanism with respect to the one producing the background set and for this reason it is worth to investigate them.
AD relies on the assumption that anomalies are rare and they represent a small portion of a whole dataset. This assumption is realistic because it is what happens everyday in airports, finance, healthcare: normal events are way more common then deviations.
In order to compensate the loss of sensitivity due to their model agnostic nature and to maximize the potential to identify anomalies, AD algorithms need to learn and recognize huge amounts of normal data. By doing so, they should be able



**Figure 4.1** Explicative drawing of anomalies. Figure adapted from Ref. [57].

to flag more easly an event as anomalous if it deviates from the learned normal behaviour. Given the complexity and the high dimensionality of the task, given the quick development in the field, Machine Learning (ML) and Deep Learning (DL) techniques are the most suitable tools to implement AD tasks. These are, in fact, able to learn from past by using vast datasets.

## 4.2 Deep Learning

Deep Learning (DL) tries to replicate the behaviour of a human brain and, analogously, its basic unit is named *neuron* [58, 59]. From its dendrites it receives input values; they are processed and then summed in a weighted sum. After applying an activation function, the signal is sent in output through the axon, towards the next dendrites. Neurons are organized in layers, constituting a network. The first one is defined *input layer* and it receives original data as input; the last one is the *output layer* and its output is the output of the model. Between them there are hidden layers, performing mathematical computations. A model with just one hidden layer is Perceptron. If the number of layers is large, the model is defined as Deep Neural Network (DNN). In Fig. 4.2 a graphical representation of a Perceptron and a DNN is shown.

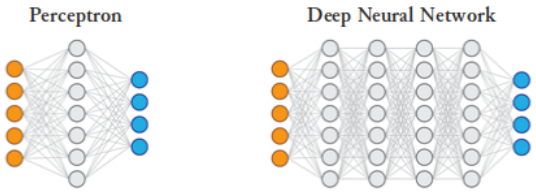



**Figure 4.2** Comparison between a Perceptron and a Deep Network. Figure from Ref. [58]

### 4.2.1 Mathematical definition

The aim of a model training is to find the best function $f$ that connects input $\mathcal{X}$ and output data $\mathcal{X}$, $f : \mathcal{X} \to \mathcal{Y}$ . In order to achieve this goal, the function connecting a

layer to the following is defined as [60]:

$$O_i^L = \sigma\Big(\sum_j W_{ij}^L I_j^L + B_i^L\Big) \tag{4.1}$$

where $I_i^L$ is the input vector, $O_i^L$ the input vector, $W_{ij}^L$ is the weight matrix (which has to be optimized during training), $B_i^L$ represents the bias vector for the layer $L$ and $\sigma$ is the activation function applied before signal leaves the neuron. When dealing with an hidden layer, the assumption $I_i^L = O_j^{L-1}$ is made. The activation function is a mathematical function setting a threshold to determine whether the neuron is active or not. Among the most used ones and of interest for the purpose of this study, there is the Parametric Rectified Linear Unit (PReLU) [61]. It is computed as follows:

$$\mathrm{PReLU}(x) = \begin{cases} x, & \text{if } x \geq 0 \\ ax, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{4.2}$$

where $a$ is a learnable parameter.

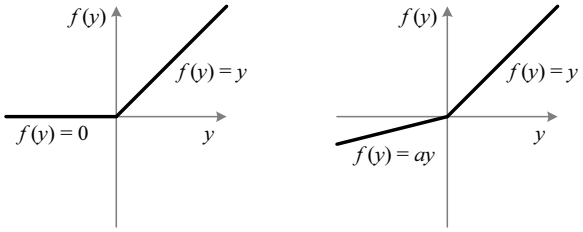



**Figure 4.3** Comparison between ReLU (Rectified Linear Unit) on the left and PReLU on the right. Figure from Ref. [61]

### 4.2.2 Loss function

The model implementation is based on math and also the process of it learning does. A loss function $\mathcal{L}$ is defined from the distance between the input and the output of the model. During the training phase (one of the steps of the learning), the goal is to minimize this function adjusting weights of the model. A possible method to do so is the stochastic gradient descent (SGD). Defining $\mathbf{p} \in \mathbb{R}^s$ as the vector containing weights and biases, SGD is computed as [58]:

$$\mathbf{p} \to \mathbf{p} - \eta \left( \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial p_r} \Delta p_r \right)_{x^{\{i\}}} \tag{4.3}$$

where $\eta$ is the learning rate, an hyperparameter that has to be optimized, computed as the ratio between the step size and the absolute value of the gradient. $\Delta p_r$ is a perturbation associated to the step. To calculate the gradient back-propagation is applied: weights are computed while forward feeding the model and then computed again when data passes backwards. Values are combined to present the best estimation of weights.

### 4.2.3 Learning paradigms

ML and DL methods can be classified based on how the labels of data are used to train models. Main categories are: *Supervised, Unsupervised, Semi-Supervised and Weakly-Supervised Learning.*[57]
In Supervised Learning, shown in figure 4.4, labeled data is used to train DL models and it can be implemented only with sufficient normal and anomalous data.




**Figure 4.4** Data used for Supervised Learning. Figure from Ref. [57]

Unsupervised Learning is based on not labeled data, as shown in figure 4.5, and models implementing it are trained to find a structure among the input features. Then model performance is tested using a mixed dataset containing both background and signal data.
Semi-Supervised Learning is a hybrid of previous techniques, implemented in the most varied ways.
Weakly-Supervised Learning, in conclusion, is associated with trainings executed using noisy samples.




**Figure 4.5** Data used for Unsupervised Learning. Figure from Ref. [57]

### 4.2.4 The steps for a model to learn

The process of training a DL model is divided into three main phases: training, validation and test loop. They are defined "loop" because in each of them a different section of the dataset is used and the code loops over it.
The most important stage is the training loop. In this phase, parameters of the model are adjusted in order to best fit to data. By doing so, DL model should be able to recognise very well normal data and their structure.
The second step is the validation loop, where a valuation of the performance of the model is elaborated using the validation set. The valuation and the search for the best weights of the model are executed computing a given metric, such as the distance between output and input over training and validation set. When this distance is minimum within the validation loop, the model's weights are saved.
The trained and tuned model is then tested, freezing the model's weights and using a dataset containing unseen data, the test set. The purpose of this phase is to validate results previously obtained and get a preview of what will happen once the model will be running with completely new data.

### 4.2.5 Estimating the model's performance

In order to understand how well a model is performing, it is necessary to define a quantitive estimator. Since an AD task is generally a classification task (normal data or not), the most common estimators are the Area Under the Curve (AUC) [62] and the Receiver Operating Characteristic (ROC) curve [63] They are computed starting from the confusion matrix, where four groups are presented to quantify misclassification errors: true positive (TP), true negative (TN), false positive (FP) and false negative (FN). From them, rates are calculated:

$$\mathrm{TPR} = \frac{\mathrm{TP}}{\mathrm{TP} + \mathrm{FN}} \ , \quad \mathrm{FPR} = \frac{\mathrm{FP}}{\mathrm{TN} + \mathrm{FP}} \tag{4.4}$$

where TPR is the True Positive Rate and FPR is the False Positive Rate. ROC curve, as shown in figure 4.6, is a plot showing the trade-off between TPR and FPR at various classification thresholds. The curve is usually over the line where TPR=FPR and the closer it is to the top left corner, the better the model is learning. AUC is, as the name suggests, the area under the ROC curve; it is computed using an integration method, for instance the trapezoidal rule. A random classifier can only obtain a AUC=0.5 (TPR=FPR); a perfect classifier flies to a $AUC \to 1$.

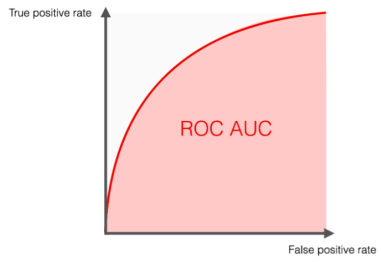



**Figure 4.6** ROC curve and AUC explained

## 4.3 Anomaly Detection in High Energy Physics

Searches for NP could gain a reasonable benefit from the implementation of AD techniques, given the multiple limitations of the field. There are two main categories by which AD be used in this context: *outlier detection* and *overdensity estimation* [64]. The first one is based on the identification of events that are outliers, deviating for the common behaviour of the dataset, usually in the tails of distributions. This region is typically challenging to model and it is often dominated by statistical fluctuations, making it difficult to distinguish between real anomalies and random noise. The second one, instead, is based on the identification of a localised excess of data points over an expected smooth background.
The increasing popularity of AD in HEP is due to its model agnostic nature, which allows to scan a broader range of events, without any stringent assumption on the theoretical model, just hunting from outliers. Together with this, large unlabeled datasets have been collected by collider experiments, boosting the usage

of unsupervised learning techniques.
In this approach, the data is divided into two categories: *background*, containing Standard Model events, and *signal*, including the hypothetical NP.
Typically, before the raise of AD, the searches for NP were conducted on simulated MC data in the first stage, applying a proper event selection to define a region of interest, called Signal Region (SR), in the phase space of parameters where the signal is expected to be found. Then, after validating the found parameters, the search was performed on real data, looking for an excess of events in the SR with respect to the background prediction, as shown in figure 4.7.
This approach relied strongly on simulated MC data.

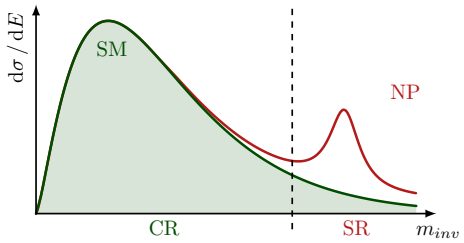



**Figure 4.7** Schematic drawing of a bump hunt search, where the SR and the Control Region (SR) are defined to isolate a potential signal from the background.

With the implementation of AD, the dependance on MC simulations can be reduced. The DNN, in fact, can be trained and validated directly on real data, in a CR where the presence of signal is not expected. For this reason, similar implementations of AD are referred to as *data-driven* approaches.
Once the DNN is trained, it is used to compute the Anomaly Score (SR) of the data, a distribution of the probability for it to be anomalous, as shown in Fig. 4.8. AS is defined as a distance between the input and the output of the model. The assumption to be verified is that anomalous data will have a different distance with respect to the background, making the two AS distributions separated: the greater the separation is, the easier it will be to distinguish signal events from background ones and discarding the latter.

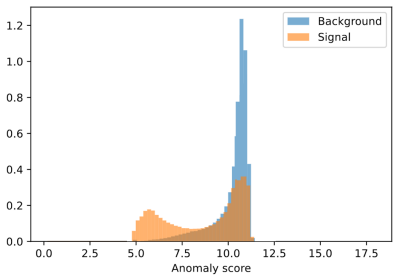



**Figure 4.8** Example of AS distribution plot

On the AS distributions Working Points (WPs) are defined. They are used to reject a given amount of background: by selecting events with score greater (or lower, depending on the definition of AS) than a fixed threshold, the number of background

events is reduced, hoping to have enhanced the signal. After the WPs computation, the second part of the search for WP can begin, with the application of common statistical analysis tools to derive an estimatore of the impact tof AD on banchmark signals.

## 4.4 Towards the statistical analysis

To better understand Anomaly Detection and how it is used to execute hunts for BSM processes, we can use an example.
Assuming we need to find a church in a town we do not know, without any technology. Instead of desperately walking around, we decide to climb an hill where we know that we can scan the whole town without so much effort. Once on top of the hill, it is possible to identify the neighbourhood of the church or the "spatial region" where it is situated. We can also get some information we would not have got in the town, such as the colour of the roof or of the facade of the building we are looking for. Then we climb down the hill and go straight to the point we observed. Thanks to the details we obtained up there, we are able to find the church quite quickly and more easily.
In other words, the church represents New Physics to be found, climbing the hill is training a DNN within the Anomaly Detection approach, climbing down is using statistical data analysis techniques. Such approach has a huge potential.



**Figure 4.9** View of Rome from the Janiculan Hill. From it, it is possible to scan the whole city and identify the neighbourhood of the Basilica of Saint Mary Major, for instance. Photo from Ref. [65].

To apply Anomaly Detection it is necessary to hypothesize that anomalies are rare and they represent a small portion of a whole dataset. This assumption is realistic in everyday life, where normal events are way more common then deviations, but also in Particle Physics: if anomalies were more frequent, we would have already

observed NP through common data analysis.

# Chapter 5

# ATLAS analysis with AD in hadronic final states

The final and crucial chapter of this thesis is dedicated to present the implementation of the Anomaly Detection approach within an ATLAS analysis. This study searches for boson resonances associated with BSM physics decaying into fully hadronic final states in the described detector, making use of the AD technique.
The goal of this analysis is to prove the feasibility of the AD approach in a full analysis, exploring its generalization capabilities, while hunting for New Physics and trying to improve the sensitivity of the search with respect to the state-of-the-art methods.
At the moment, the status of the analysis is the following. The R&D phase on the MC sample for the DNN model can be defined as concluded, as it is for the statistical analysis and modelling on the MC dataset. The latter is associated with the original work of this thesis, which is the main contribution to the analysis on the MC samples, as described in details in the sections below. The preparation of the field to move towards the usage of the real data is currently on going, expecting the switch in dataset to happen soon.
In the following sections, an overiew of the analysis is presented, with a description of the dataset and the Graph Neural Network model used for the AD implementation. After this, an important portion of the chapter is dedicated to the description of the original work related to this thesis, which is the execution of the statistical analysis on the MC dataset, with the aim of testing the AD approach in a full analysis. This work is conducted within the `Frequentist Framework` [66], a well established tool used inside the ATLAS collaboration.

## 5.1 The dataset

The analysis focuses on exploring the data collected by the ATLAS detector during the LHC Run-3 from 2022 to 2024. It corresponds to a total integrated luminosity of 165 $\text{fb}^{-1}$, with a center-of-mass energy of $\sqrt{s} = 13.6$ TeV [29].
Before running the full analysis pipeline on the real data, a preliminary study is performed on a MC dataset, which is used to train and validate the AD model and to test the statistical tools developed. The latter aspect is the goal of this thesis,

which aims to conduct the analysis on the MC sample and validate the tools. In this preliminary stage, a sample simluating 2023 events is used, the one developed during *MC23d* campaign, corresponding to a integrated luminosity of 25.76 fb$^{-1}$. The composition of the dataset is described in the following.

### 5.1.1 Final states

This analysis hunts for BSM physics in the form of heavy resonances with masses in the TeV range which decay into quarks forming final states with two large-radius jets (reconstructed using the anti-$k_T$ algorithm with a radius parameter of $R = 1.0$) with UFO constituents. Such signatures are chosen because they are predicted by several NP models. Together with this, the high mass of the resonances results in highly boosted decay products, which are collimated and reconstructed as single large-radius jets each. This leads to a final state where jets can present a complex substructure, which can be exploited by the AD model to identify possible anomalies and NP candidates.

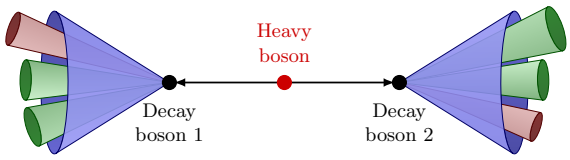



**Figure 5.1** Schematic drawing of a heavy boson decaying into two bosons subsequently decaying into two large-radius jets (blue cones) with substructure, both normal (green cones) and anomalous (red cones).

### 5.1.2 Signal processes

Despite the model-agnostic nature of the AD approach, a set of benchmark signal processes has to be chosen to test the sensitivity of the technique. In this analysis, two main physical processes are considered: Heavy Vector Triplet (Sec. 1.2.2) and Dark Jets (Sec. 1.2.3).
The Dark sector is probed using a sample of a $Z'$ boson with mass $m_{Z'} = 3.5$ TeV, decaying into a pair of dark quarks with a mass $m_{q_D} = 20$ GeV each .
HVT, instead, are explored with three different processes. The first one is the decay of a heavy vector boson $V$, assumed to be the candidate $Y$ boson, into a BSM vector boson $X$ and the SM Higgs boson $H$. The masses of the $V$ and $X$ bosons are varied in order to explore different kinematic configurations, among $m_V = [2.3, 3.4, 5.0, 6.0]$ TeV and $m_X = [100, 200, 2500, 400]$ GeV respectively. The mass of the Higgs boson, instead, is fixed to its SM value of $m_H = 125$ GeV.
The second HVT process considered is the decay of a heavy vector boson $V$, into a pair of SM $W$ bosons. Once again, the mass of the $V$ boson is varied among $m_V = [2.0, 3.0, 4.0, 5.0]$ TeV, while the masses of the $W$ bosons are fixed to their SM value of $m_W = 80$ GeV.
In conclusion, the third process studied is the decay of a heavy $W'$ boson into a $W$

and a $Z$ BSM bosons, with single masses at $m_{W'} = 3.0$ TeV, $m_W = 200$ GeV and $m_Z = 400$ GeV.
In all the three cases, bosons are assumed to decay into quarks, forming jets in the final state.
In Fig. 5.2 an example of a Feynman diagram of a HVT process ($VcXH$) is shown.

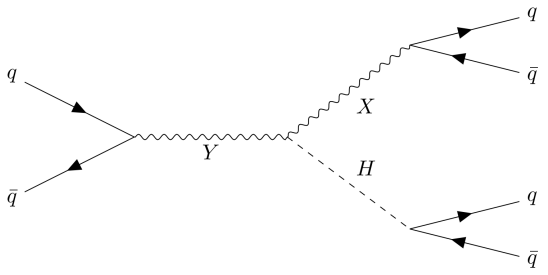



**Figure 5.2** Feynman diagram of a $VcXH$ process.

The complete list of signal processes considered in the analysis, together with their corresponding masses and theoretical cross-sections assumed, is reported in Tab. 5.1. The theoretical cross-sections are those associated with the generated processes and they are derived from the ATLAS internal database for $MC23d$ campaign.

| Signal Name | Process | Masses [GeV] | Theoretical cross-section [pb] |
|---|---|---|---|
| VcXH_2300 | $V \to XH$ | $m_V = 2300$, $m_X = 100$ | $4.7435 \cdot 10^{-1}$ |
| VcXH_3400 | $V \to XH$ | $m_V = 3400$, $m_X = 200$ | $4.1550 \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| VcXH_5000 | $V \to XH$ | $m_V = 5000$, $m_X = 2500$ | $1.6359 \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VcXH_6000 | $V \to XH$ | $m_V = 6000$, $m_X = 400$ | $2.1811 \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| VzWW_2000 | $V \to WW$ | $m_V = 2000$ | $3.8476 \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VzWW_3000 | $V \to WW$ | $m_V = 3000$ | $3.5969 \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| VzWW_4000 | $V \to WW$ | $m_V = 4000$ | $4.5256 \cdot 10^{-5}$ |
| VzWW_5000 | $V \to WW$ | $m_V = 5000$ | $6.2648 \cdot 10^{-6}$ |
| Wprime | $W' \to WZ$ | $m_{W'} = 3000$, $m_W = 200$, $m_Z = 400$ | $6.9682 \cdot 10^{-16}$ |
| DarkJet | $Z' \to q_D \bar{q}_D$ | $m_{Z'} = 3500$, $m_{q_D} = 20$, $m_{\bar{q}_D} = 20$ | $1.05853 \cdot 10^{-9}$ |

**Table 5.1** Signal processes considered in the analysis, with their corresponding masses and theoretical cross-sections. It is worth noting that the theoretical cross-section for the Wprime process is extremely low with respect to the other processes; this difference is due to the inclusion of the Branching Ratio for the decays of the sample.

### 5.1.3 Background processes

The main backgrounds to this search are SM processes with multiple jets in the final state. The dominant contribution comes from QCD multi-jet events, which are characterized by a very high cross-section. Other relevant contributions come from $t\bar{t}$, $W$+jets and $Z$+jets processes, which are associated with lower cross-sections but still relevant in the signal regions.

In Fig. 5.3 a plot is shown, containing the stacked distribution of the di-jet invariant mass $m_{JJ}$, which is the variable of interest for this analysis, for the dominant background processes considered in the analysis.

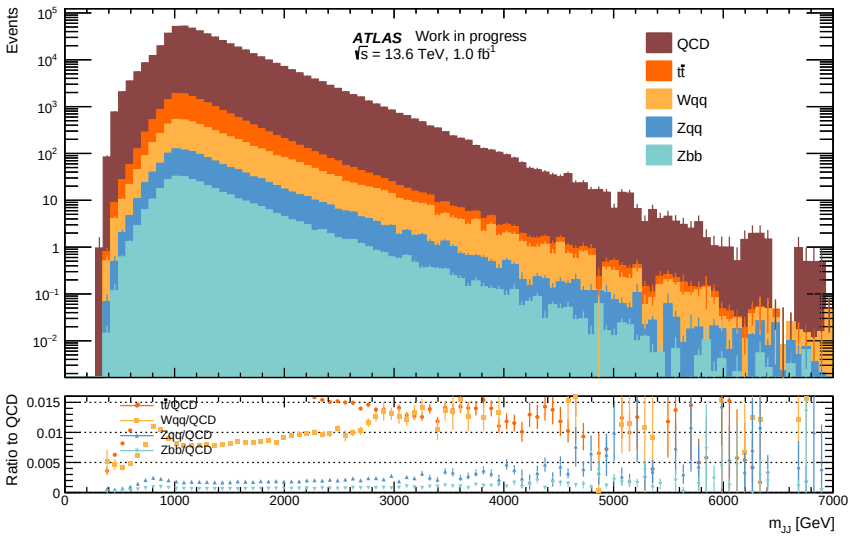



**Figure 5.3** Stacked distribution of $m_{JJ}$ for the dominant background processes.

As evident from the plot in Fig. 5.3, the dominant background contribution comes from QCD jets, followed by $t\bar{t}$, $W$+jets and $Z$+jets processes. Concerning the latter, the contribution coming from $b$ jets is kept separate from the one coming from light jets, leveraging the information coming from $b$-tagging algorithms.
The plot shows three other main features of the distribution. The first feature is the integrated luminosity of the sample, which has been set to be 1 fb$^{-1}$, normalizing properly the distribution.
The second one is the steeply falling nature of the distribution ($\sim \frac{1}{q^2}$), which is a common feature of QCD-like processes. This, in principle, makes the search for NP resonances more challenging, as they are expected to appear as small bumps on top of the background distribution.
The last feature, connected to the previous, is that, in reality, the background distribution is not smooth in the entire range of the variable. Instead, the distribution presents a turn on region, around 1 TeV, due to the trigger and kinematic requirements applied on the transverse momentum $p_T$ of the jets during the event preselection, which are described in Sec. 5.1.5. The relation between those requirements and the turn on region comes from the equation of the invariant mass of two objects, which is defined as $m_{JJ} = \sqrt{2p_{T,1}p_{T,2}(\cosh(\Delta\eta) - \cos(\Delta\phi))}$.

### 5.1.4 Weights for the sample

To create a MC sample, the full dataset over the entire kinematic region of interest is not generated entirely all at once. Instead, it is generated slice by slice, in steps of $H_T$, which is defined as the scalar sum of the transverse momentum $p_T$ of the jets in the event. This choice is made for two reasons. In the first place it is used to

prevent the generation of a huge number of events in the low energy region where the QCD distribution has a peak, guaranteeing a reasonable number of events in the high energy region, which is the one of interest for many analyses. Secondly, this approach reduces the computational cost to generate a sample. All these slices are associated with different section of the phase space which are assumed to be orthogonal, meaning that the interference between the terms is negligible. For this reasons, the total cross-section of the process can be computed as the direct sum of the partial cross-sections of each slice. This translates in the fact that the generated slices of MC histograms can be simply summed together bin per bin to form the total QCD distribution to study.
When combining the slices, a proper normalization and reweighting has to be applied, in order to have a correct representation of the entire sample.
For each event a weight is defined, to take into account both the effect just cited and other aspects. Among those we find a compatibility, in terms of acceptance or efficiency, between the MC and the real data, which is not always guaranteed, or pile-up effects which have to be included. All these aspects are combined and taken into account by the variable *weight_total_NOSYS* of the dataset.

### 5.1.5 The event preselection

After generating the MC samples and applying the reconstruction algorithms described in Chap. 3 for large-radius jet ($R = 1.0$), an event preselection is applied to the dataset, to reduce its size and to reproduce the typical event selection applied on real data.
The first step of preselection is the application of three trigger requirements. First of all, a jet has to fire the single jet trigger item which requires events with $E_T > 100$ GeV at L1 trigger and $E_T > 460$ GeV at HLT. Secondly, it is required that the object raising this trigger is the leading jet of the event, where the leading jet is defined as the one with the highest transverse momentum $p_T$. Finally, a cut on the leading jet $p_T$ is applied, requiring it to be greater than 470 GeV. This latter requirement is meant to take into account the data bandwidth limitations: given the smoothly falling shape of the $p_T$ distribution, the region with lower $p_T$ is more populated, leading to a higher number of events to be stored, which is not sustainable given the limited bandwidth available.
Together with the trigger criteria, a set of kinematic cuts is applied to the events, to properly define the objects of interest. In particular, each event is required to have at least two large-radius jets (and less than four), each of it (leading and sub-leading i.e. highest and second-highest $p_T$) with mass greater than 50 GeV, $p_T$ greater than 200 GeV and pseudorapidity $\eta$ within the range $[-2.0, 2.0]$.
The requirements applied during the event preselection are summarized in Tab. 5.2. Events passing this preselection form the dataset used to train and test the ML model, which is the core of the AD approach.

## 5.2 Training the ML model

The Anomaly Detection stage of the analysis is impemented using a Graph Neural Network (GNN) architecture [67].

| Preselection requirements |
|---|
| Triger item `HLT_j460_a10_sd_cssk_pf_ftf_preselj225_L1J100` |
| Trigger fired by leading jet |
| $p_{\mathrm{T},leadjet} > 470$ GeV |
| $2 <$ #jets $< 4$ |
| $m_{leadjet} > 50$ GeV |
| $m_{subleadjet} > 50$ GeV |
| $p_{\mathrm{T},jets} > 200$ GeV |
| $\lvert\eta_{jet}\rvert \leq 2.0$ |

**Table 5.2** Trigger and object definition requirements applied during the event preselection.

This type of architecture is chosen given the sparse and variable nature of jets, which can be represented very well as graphs, a data structure with the ability to represent variable-size objects and their relations. A visual representationof the jet-graph association is presented in Fig. 5.4.

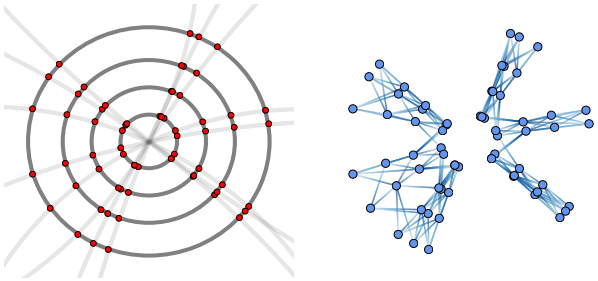


**Figure 5.4** Visualisation of sparse jets in the transverse plane on the left and their representation as graphs on the right. Figure from Ref. [67].

Each graph can be represented compactly as $G = (V, E)$, where $V$ is the set of nodes and $E$ is the set of edges connecting the nodes. In the context of this analysis, each graph is associated with a single jet, a node represents a single constituent of the jet and an edge represents the relation between two constituents, defined based on the separation between them in $\Delta R$ exponentiated ($e^{-\Delta R}$). Two nodes, in fact, are connected, meaning that they can exchange information, if their separation is lower than a certain threshold, which has been set to $\Delta R < 0.6$ in this study. Such relatively high threshold increases the number of connections among the graph, allowing the network to learn more complex relations inside the jets. The nodes have stored in their features the kinematic information of the constituents, such as $p_T$, $\eta$ and $\phi$, together with their mass and taste.
The dataset, mapped into graphs, is then used as input to train a particular type of GNN architecture, named EGAT.

| Graph component | Feature |
|---|---|
| Nodes | $p_T$, $\eta$, $\phi$, mass, taste |
| Edges | $e^{-\Delta R}$, active if $\Delta R < 0.6$ |

**Table 5.3** Input features for each constituent (node) of the jet (graph), connected based on a distance criterion (edge), used to train the GNN model.

### 5.2.1 The architecture in use

The assignment to compute the AS is performed feeding the graphs into an EGAT architecture, a Edge Graph ATtention Network [68]. This is a particular type of GNN architecture which implements the Multi-Head Attention mechanism using graphs [69], with the goal to let the network learn which nodes are more relevant for the task ongoing. For the purpose of this search, this mechanism is implemented leveraging also the information stored in the edges (from which the "Edge" in the name of the architecture comes from). The edges, in our case, carry information about the separation between two constituents, which could be crucial to learn the substructure of the jets and to identify possible anomalies.
In Fig. 5.5 a schematic representation of the implemented EGAT architecture is shown, with the main components highlighted. The yellow boxes represent a MLP layer (multilayer perceptron), a fully connected layer which is used to increase (decrease) the dimensionality of the input features. It is composed by a linear transformation, followed by a normalisation step and a dropout one, to conclude with a non-linear activation function, in this case a PReLU. The MLP is stacked in n layers, with the number of layers being a hyperparameter of the model. The light blue boxes represent the graph layers, which are the core of the architecture, meant to learn the relations between the nodes of the graph and to update their features accordingly. Its main component is the EGATConv layer, which implements the attention mechanism on both the nodes and the edges of the graph [68]. It is followed, again, by normalisation, dropout and PReLU activation. As for the MLP, also for the blue boxes the number of layers applied is a hyperparameter of the model. After the finaly MLP layer, a global pooling layer is applied to the graph, to select, reduce and connect the most relevant nodes [70].

### 5.2.2 Training the model

The GNN model is trained with a fully unsupervised approach. The training dataset is composed exclusively by 320 $k$ QCD multi-jet background events, looping over them to minimizes a Deep Support Vector Data Description (DeepSVDD) loss function [71]. This function computes the distance between the output of the network and a predefined coordinate vector $c$, centre of hypersphere in the latent feature space. The DeepSVDD loss can be graphically as presented in Fig. 5.6 and it is computed as follows:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{DeepSVDD}} = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} \|\phi(x_i;\mathcal{W}) - c\|^2 + \frac{\lambda}{2}\sum_{l=1}^{L} \|W^l\|_F^2 \tag{5.1}$$

where $n$ is the batch size (an hyperparameter of the training); $\phi(x_i;\mathcal{W})$ instead

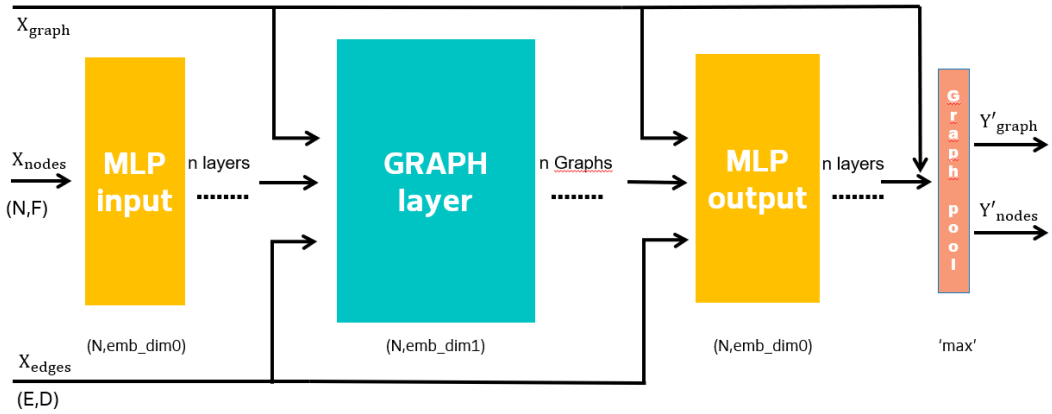



**Figure 5.5** Visual representation of the EGAT architecture, with the three main components. The black arrows represent the flow of the data, highliting the edges usage.

denotes the output representation of the input $x_i$ generated by the EGAT architecture, parameterized by weights $\mathcal{W}$. The second termn in the function is a regularization term, with $\lambda$ being a hyperparameter, which penalizes the weights of the network to avoid overfitting and trivial solutions.

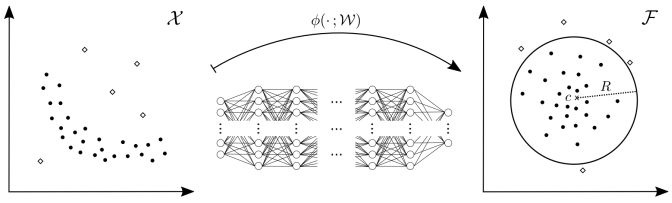



**Figure 5.6** Visual representation of the DeepSVDD loss function, which computes the distance between the output of the network in the space $\mathcal{F}$ and the centre of the hypersphere $c$. Figure from Ref. [71].

Minimizing this distance forces the network to learn a compact representation of the input background sample. The assumption, to be proved, is that anomalous jets, which could feature exotics substructures or topologies, lead to higher distances from $c$ when passed as input in the test phase of the model, forming the so called outliers. The test phase, in fact, where the model performance is evaluated, is performed using a mixed dataset, containing both background and signal events.
The DeepSVDD loss function is used also to compute the AS for each jet, which is defined as:

$$AS = \|\phi(x_i; \mathcal{W}^*) - c\|^2 \tag{5.2}$$

where $\mathcal{W}^*$ are the weights of the trained model, which are fixed during the test phase.
The three phases of the training of the model, training, validation and testing (Sec. 4.2.4) are executed using complementary datasets, to avoid any bias in the evaluation of the model performance. The splitting of the dataset to compose the sets for the three phases is presented in Tab. 5.4.

| Phase | Dataset | Number of events |
|---|---|---|
| Training | QCD multi-jet | 320 k |
| Validation | QCD multi-jet | 30 k |
| Testing | QCD + other Backgrounds + Signals | 2.6 M |

**Table 5.4** Splitting of the dataset to compose the sets for the three phases of the training of the model. The training and validation sets are composed exclusively by QCD multi-jet events, while the testing set is composed by a mixed dataset, containing both all backgrounds and signals.

### 5.2.3 Performance of the GNN

The performance of the EGAT model on the MC samples is evaluated using the AUC metric (Sec. 4.2.5), which is computed for each signal process considered in the analysis and inserted in the dataset during the test phase. Results are reported in Tab. 5.5, where the AUC values for each signal are shown.
Discrimination power varies substantially depending on the process considered and the resonance mass. HVT decays into $WW$ final states are the ones achieving higher discrimination, with an AUC up to 95.8%. Similarly, $V \to XH$ decays present strong background rejection, yielding a maximum AUC of 87.6% for the (6.0 TeV, 400 GeV) mass configuration. Moreover, signal processes with higher resonance masses tend to be more easily discriminated from the background, which is expected, since the raising jets are more boosted and their substructure is more defined than lower mass resonances, allowing the network to learn more complex structures. The Dark Jets and Wprime processes, instead, are the ones with the lowest performance, with an AUC of 59.6% and 64.9% respectively. These lower results can be explained analysing what the network is learning. In Sec. 5.3 the correlation between the AS and the jet features is studied to understand whether a cut on the AS could introduce a bias in the kinematic distributions of the jets, which is not desired. The plots in Fig. 5.8 can also be interpreted as a representation of the features of QCD jets learned by the GNN. In particular, the network seems to learn more in detail kinematic features of the jets, such as the mass and the transverse momentum. Less information is extracted from the $D_2$ variable, which is a measure of the substructure of the jets. From this it is evident that a sample as the Dark Jets, which has a complex substructure similar to the one of QCD jets and a peak in the $m_{JJ}$ distirbution outside the core of the AS vs $m_{JJ}$ correlation, is more difficult to discriminate from the background, leading to a lower AUC value. A similar reasoning can be applied to the Wprime process, which can be considered a 3-prong process, with a complex substructure to learn. Probably, in these cases, more specific features should be used to improve the performance of the model, such as the presence of displaced vertices, a typical feature of dark jets.
The results discussed above are consistent with those presented in the following sections, where the AS distributions are studied together with the correlation between the AS and the features of QCD jets, the sample on which the model is trained.

| Signals | AUC (%) |
|---|---|
| VcXH ($m_V$ = 2300 GeV, $m_X$ = 130 GeV) | 72 |
| VcXH ($m_V$ = 3400 GeV, $m_X$ = 200 GeV) | 81.5 |
| VcXH ($m_V$ = 5000 GeV, $m_X$ = 2500 GeV) | 79.7 |
| VcXH ($m_V$ = 6000 GeV, $m_X$ = 400 GeV) | 87.6 |
| VzWW ($m_V$ = 2000 GeV) | 84.7 |
| VzWW ($m_V$ = 3000 GeV) | 91.6 |
| VzWW ($m_V$ = 4000 GeV) | 94.3 |
| VzWW ($m_V$ = 5000 GeV) | 95.8 |
| Dark Jets | 59.6 |
| Wprime | 64.9 |

**Table 5.5** AUC (%) values obtained with the trained EGAT model for each signal.

### 5.2.4 Anomaly Score distribution

The main goal of the AD approach is finally executed in the test phase, where the trained model is used to compute the AS for each jet in the mixed dataset. Such quantity is computed at jet level, for both the leading and subleading jets, providing a measure of how anomalous each jet is with respect to the background sample used for training. The distribution is presented in Fig. 5.7a for the leading jet and in Fig. 5.7b for the sub-leading jet, where the background is presented in the dashed blue line as a unique term, containing the different components summed up. In Fig. 5.7c and Fig. 5.7d the same distributions are shown, but this time the background is split into its components, to better understand the contribution of each process to the overall AS.

As visible from the plots in Fig. 5.7, the AS distribution for the background is concentrated at lower values with respect to the signal processes, which tend to populate the high score region. In particular, the $VzWW$ processes are the ones with the highest AS, while the Dark Jets and Wprime processes are the ones with the lowest AS, which is consistent with the AUC values reported in Tab. 5.5. For these reasons, it is expected that the $VzWW$ processes will be the easiest among our benchmarks to detect in the statistical analysis, while the Dark Jets process will be more challenging to identify.
It is worth noting that the AS distribution is realized excluding the QCD events used in the training phase, which are set to have a negative score. This choice is made in order to avoid any bias in the evaluation of the model performance.
Prior to realizing the plots in Fig. 5.7, events are filtered to select the invariant mass region of interest and a custom defined weight, *fWeight*, is applied to the events, in order to rescale the sample to an integrated luminosity of 1.0 $\text{fb}^{-1}$.
Starting from the AS distribution, different WPs are defined, as threshold values to cut on the jet level AS in order to reject between 20% and 99.9% of background events. Given the shapes presented, events with a Score greater than a specific WP are kept, defining the SR at that WP. In Tab. 5.6 the WPs defined in this analysis are reported, together with the corresponding background rejection factor.

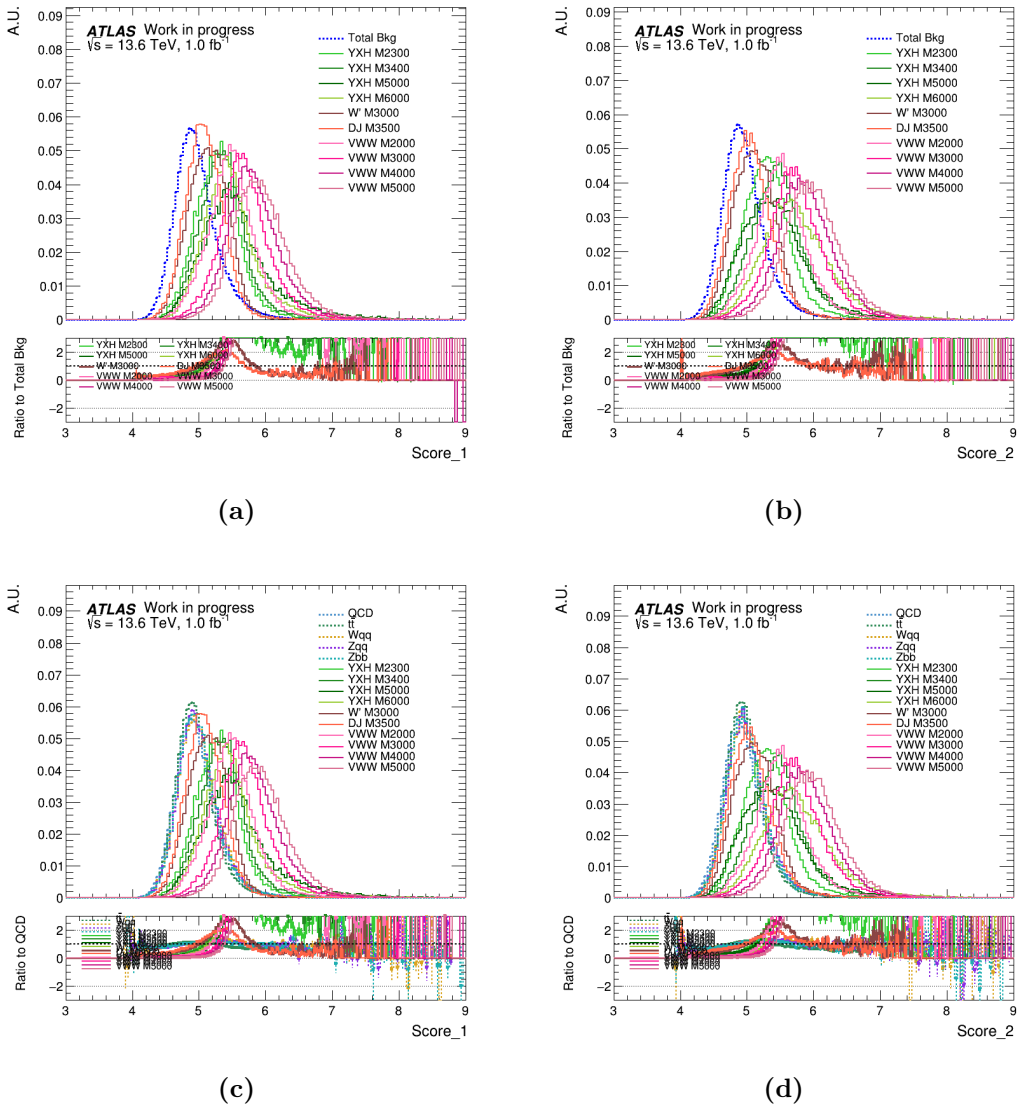



**Figure 5.7** Score distributions for the leading (a,c) and sub-leading (b,d) jets, with the background shown as a single term (a,b) and split into its components (c,d).

| **BKG rejection (%)** | 20 | 30 | 40 | 50 | 60 | 70 | 80 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **AS cut value** | 4.61 | 4.67 | 4.73 | 4.79 | 4.84 | 4.91 | 4.98 |
| **BKG rejection (%)** | 85 | 90 | 95 | 97 | 99 | 99.9 | |
| **AS cut value** | 5.03 | 5.10 | 5.21 | 5.29 | 5.47 | 5.89 | |

**Table 5.6** WPs and respective rejection factors computed on the QCD background.

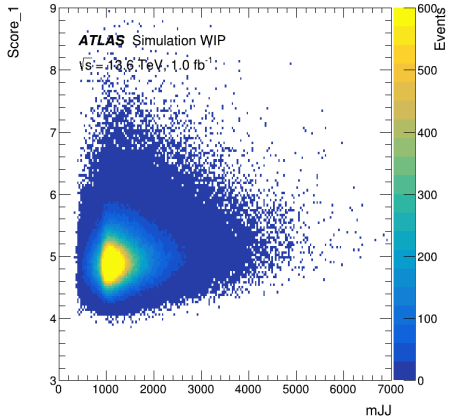
## 5.3 Correlation of the Score with kinematic variables

An important step before proceeding with the statistical analysis is to evaluate the correlation of the AS with key kinematic variables. This evalution is needed to verify that the AS is not strongly coupled with the kinematics of the events, which would

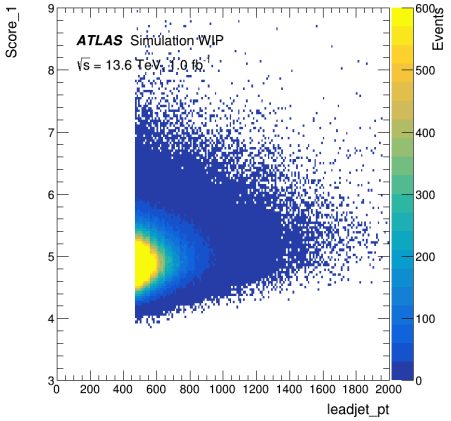
lead to a distortion of the background invariant mass distribution after applying a cut on the AS. In fact, the first crucial variable to be evaluated is the di-jet invariant mass $m_{JJ}$, which is the variable of interest for this analysis used to search for NP resonances. Together with this, also the coordinates $p_T, \eta, \phi$ of the leading and sub-leading jets are evaluated, to guarantee a full understanding of the correlations. In Fig. 5.8 the correlation plots of the score vs the other variables are shown, for the leading jet of QCD events, the main background component.
As visible from the plots in Fig. 5.8, the AS is not strongly correlated with most of the kinematic variables considered. A slight correlation is visible with the leading jet mass, which is one of the training features of the model. Such correlation, anyway, is compensated by the reduced correlation with the sub-leading jet mass, which balances the situation. Results just presented are compatible with those obtained for the sub-leading jet score and its related variables.
From this step it is possible to conclude that it is not expected to introduce any bias in the background distribution after applying a cut on it based on the AS.
Another way to visualize the impact of the AS on the background distribution is to plot the di-jet invariant mass $m_{JJ}$ before and after applying a cut on the AS, at different WPs. If the correlation is low, the shape of the distribution should not change significantly after applying the cut. If this assumption is not verified, artificial sculpting is introduced in the background distribution by the AS cut, which could degrade the accuracy of the search. Plots associated with this study on the QCD distribution are shown in Fig. 5.9.
The plots in Fig. 5.9 show that, as expected, the shape of the $m_{JJ}$ distribution is not significantly affected by the AS cut, even at high WPs, confirming that the AS is not strongly correlated with the di-jet invariant mass. In particular, the sculpting effect is not observed, guaranteeing that the background distribution can still be modeled with a smooth function even after applying an event selection based on AS.

## 5.4 Event selection

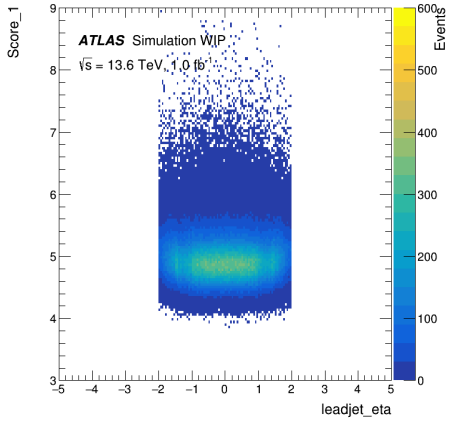
The statistical analysis begins determining the event selection to apply on the dataset, to define the SRs and CRs with the goal to reduce the background contamination in the former.
The two criteria used to define the selection are based on the AS and the rapidity difference $|\Delta y|$ between the two leading jets. The first criterion has been already introduced in Sec. 5.2.4, where the WPs are defined in terms of background rejection factors, which are used to cut on the AS of the two jets separately.
The second requirement is based on the rapidity difference $|\Delta y|$ between the leading jet $y_1$ and the sub-leading one $y_2$, defined as $|\Delta y| = |y_1 - y_2|$. Given the definition of the rapidity of a jet, Eq. 2.7, different values of its difference correspond to different $x_B$, the Bjorken scaling variable [72], which expresses the fraction of the momentum of the proton carried by the parton involved in the collision. This quantity is inserted in the defintion of the Parton Distribution Functions (PDFs) [73], which are used to compute the probability of finding a parton with a certain $x_B$ inside the proton. In particular, lower the values of $|\Delta y|$, more collimated the two jets are, higher the



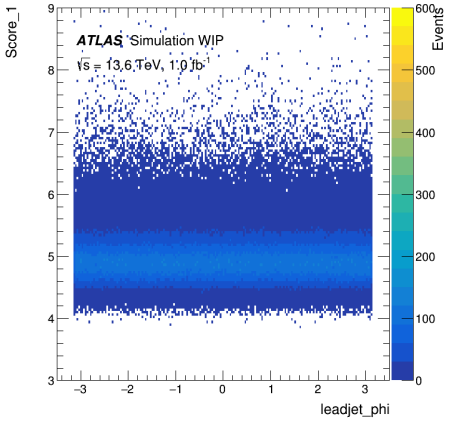

(a)



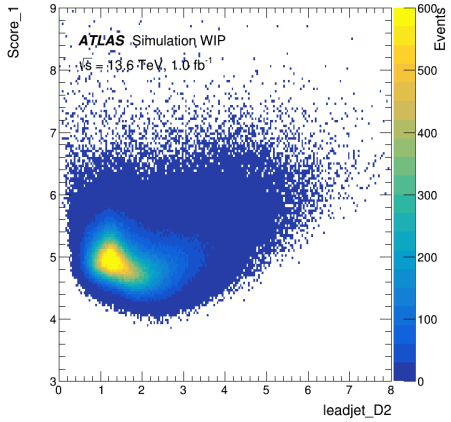

(b)



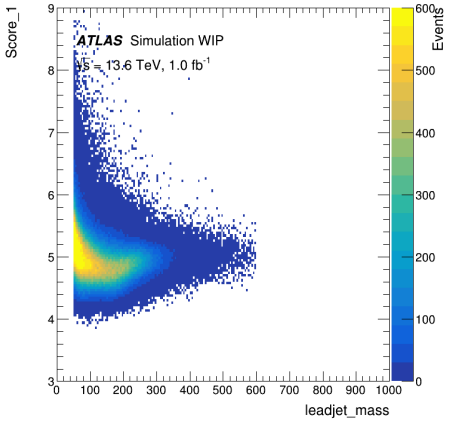

(c)




(d)

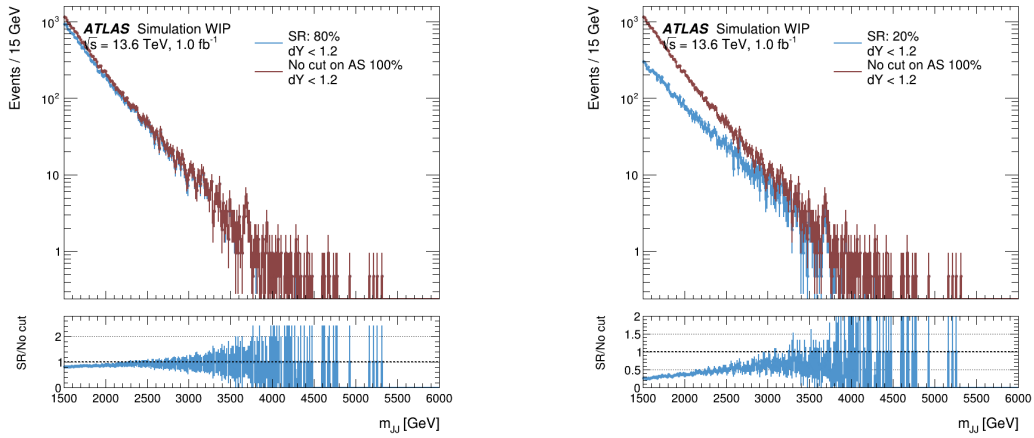



(e)




(f)

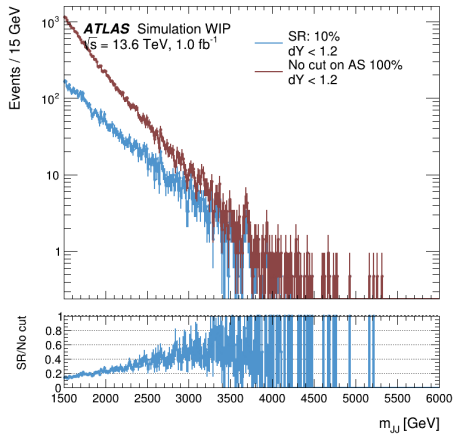
**Figure 5.8** Plots representating the correlation of the jet 1 Score with (a) di-jet invariant mass $m_{JJ}$, (b) leading jet $p_T$, (c) leading jet $\eta$, (d) leading jet $\phi$, (e) $D_2$ and (f) mass.



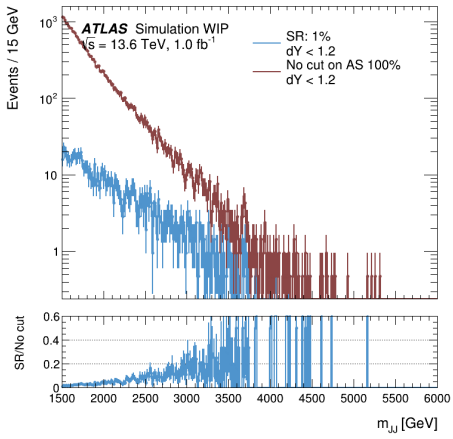

(a)




(b)




(c)




(d)

**Figure 5.9** Plots representating the QCD $m_{JJ}$ distribution before and after applying a cut on AS at WP (a) 20, (b) 80, (c) 90, (d) 99.

values of $x_B$ and, consequently higher the probability that the parton is a valence one instead of coming from the sea. In Fig. 5.10 the distribution of $|\Delta y|$ is shown for the total background (summed components) and the signal processes.
As visible from the plot in Fig. 5.10, the signal processes are concentrated at lower values of $|\Delta y|$, while the background distribution has a peak at higher values of $|\Delta y|$. From the ratio plot, it is possible to define a threshold on $|\Delta y|$ to reduce the background abundance, which is set to $|\Delta y| < 1.2$. Other figures containing the same distribution but for the individual background components are reported in Appendix A.
It is worth noticing that the main difference between the Fig. 5.10 where the signal/background separation is more clear and those reported in Appendix A where the separation is not so obvious, is due to the application in the former of the selection on the di-jet invariant mass region where the fits will be executed, which is

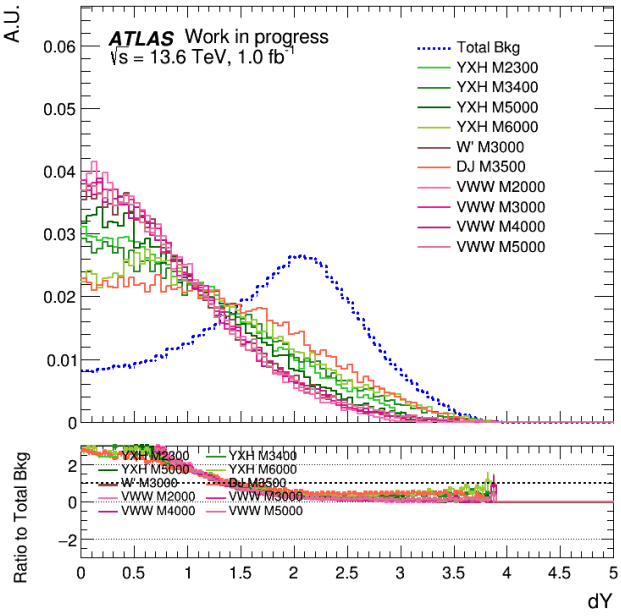



**Figure 5.10** Distributions of $|\Delta y|$ variable between the leading and the sub-leading jet, with the selection of di-jet invariant mass region applied.

not applied in the latter. The fit range, where the NP searches will be executed, has been determined to be $[1.5, 6.0]$ TeV, as discussed in following sections.
At this point it is possible to define the SRs and CRs based on the criteria just discussed. The Signal Regions will be those with events with AS>WPs and $|\Delta y| < 1.2$, while the Control Regions will be those with opposite cut on AS, which means AS<WPs and $|\Delta y| < 1.2$. The efficiency of these two selections for the background and the signal processes is reported in Tab. 5.7, where it is possible to notice that the application of the $|\Delta y|$ cut impacts consistently on the background, reducing its efficiency by a factor of 2. On the other hand, the signal processes are less affected by this latter cut, which justifies the choice to apply it.

## 5.5 Modelling the samples

The searches for NP are conducted performing a binned likelihood fit of signal+background to the sample in the variable of interest. For the purpose of this analysis, the variable of interest is the di-jet invariant mass $m_{JJ}$. It is the most relevant parameter of a HVT or Dark Jets model since it is expected to show a resonant peak in case of NP presence.
It is necessary to parametrize the signal and background samples, to describe them with a function instead of using directly the histogrammed spectra. Functions used to describe the background and the signals are discussed in the following sections.

| Sample | Efficiency Cut: Score | Efficiency Cut: Score & $\|\Delta y\|$ |
|---|---|---|
| Background | 1.27 % | 0.61% |
| VcXH_2300 | 8.93% | 7.63% |
| VcXH_3400 | 16.61% | 13.48% |
| VcXH_5000 | 22.53% | 17.53% |
| VcXH_6000 | 30.97% | 22.27% |
| VzWW_2000 | 29.22% | 25.57% |
| VzWW_3000 | 56.27% | 46.09% |
| VzWW_4000 | 71.60% | 56.08% |
| VzWW_5000 | 80.81% | 62.43% |
| DarkJets | 1.08 % | 0.82% |
| Wprime | 1.61% | 1.44% |

**Table 5.7** Background and signal efficiencies after applying the two different event selection cuts, based on the AS at WP 90% and the rapidity difference $|\Delta y| < 1.2$.

### 5.5.1 Signals

The signal samples, containing the BSM candidate processes, present a clear resonant peak in the $m_{JJ}$ distribution, expected to be centered around the mass of the resonance. The width of the resonance is assumed to be narrow with respect to the mass range considered. This assumption and the peak-like shape of the signal can be observed in Fig. 5.11, where an example of the $m_{JJ}$ distribution for a VcXH_3400 process is shown.

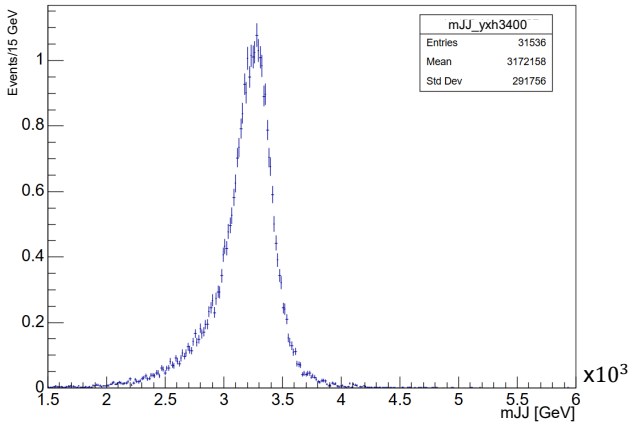



**Figure 5.11** Example of the $m_{JJ}$ distribution for a VcXH_3400 process, showing the peak expected for a resonant process.

The BSM samples are modeled and parametrized using a Double-Sided Crystal Ball (DSCB) function, which is an asymmetric function composed by a Gaussian core and two power-law tails. The function is implemented using the `RooCrystalBall Class` from `ROOT` [74] and it is defined as follows:

$$f_{DSCB}(m_{JJ};\mu,\sigma,\alpha_L,n_L,\alpha_R,n_R) = \begin{cases} A_L \cdot \left(B_L - \frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_L}\right)^{-n_L} & \text{for } \frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_L} \leq -\alpha_L \\ \exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}\cdot\left[\frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_L}\right]^2\right) & \text{for } 0 \leq \frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_L} \\ \exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}\cdot\left[\frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_R}\right]^2\right) & \text{for } \frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_L} \leq \alpha_R \\ A_R \cdot \left(B_R + \frac{m_{JJ}-\mu}{\sigma_R}\right)^{-n_R} & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{5.3}$$

with:

$$A_{L/R} = \left(\frac{n_{L/R}}{|\alpha_{L/R}|}\right)^{n_{L/R}} \cdot \exp\left(-\frac{|\alpha_{L/R}|^2}{2}\right), \quad B_{L/R} = \frac{n_{L/R}}{|\alpha_{L/R}|} - |\alpha_{L/R}| \tag{5.4}$$

The Eq. 5.3 defines the signal probability density function (PDF) used in the fits, with the parameters $\mu$ and $\sigma$ representing the mean and standard deviation of the Gaussian core, while $\alpha_L$, $n_L$, $\alpha_R$, and $n_R$ define the shape of the left and right tails of the distribution. Making use of this PDF, the command `pdf.fitTo()` of `ROOT` is excecuted to perform a binned fit to the $m_{JJ}$ distribution of the signal samples and extract the best-fit parameters for each of them. This command runs with the aim to minimize the negative log-likelihood of the PDF. The minimization is performed using the `MINUIT` class which implements the `MIGRAD` algorithm to minimize the function and `HESSE` to compute the uncertainties on them.
To ensure a good convergence of the fit, the procedure is devided in two steps. First a Gaussian fuction is fitted in a small window around the peak of the distribution, where the window is defined as centred in the MC mass od the resonance and with a width of 1 $\sigma$ roughly estimated from the MC distribution. The parameters obtained from this first fit are then used as initial values for the DSCB fit, which is performed in a wider window around the peak, excluding the noise and oscillating tails of the distribution. In Fig. 5.12 the results of the DSCD for the VcXH_3400 and VzWW_2000 processes are shown, with and without the application of the cut on AS at 99% WP. In Appendix A all the other DSCB fits for the other signal processes are reported. WP 99% is presented here and chosen to be the one to run the analysis on, since it is one of the most stringent cuts on the AS while guaranteeing a good efficiency for the signal processes, as shown in Tab. 5.7. From this moment on, all the plots and results presented with the AS cut applied will refer to the WP 99%, unless otherwise specified.
Some observations can be made from the plots in Fig. 5.12 and in Appendix A.
First of all, as pointed out in Tab. 5.7, the impact of the AS cut on the signal efficiency is manageble, with a reduction of the number of events in the SRs but not a significant distortion of the shape of the distribution. Concerning the latter, the choice of the DSCB function as PDF to describe the signal samples is justified by the good agreement between the fit and the MC sample histograms, with a reduced $\chi^2$ ($\chi^2/ndf$) between 1 and 2 in almost all cases. Two cases capture the attention when looking at their modelling: Dark Jets and VcXH_5000. The former is the one with the lowest efficiency after the AS cut, due to the high similarity between its score distribution and the one of the background, as shown in Fig. 5.7.

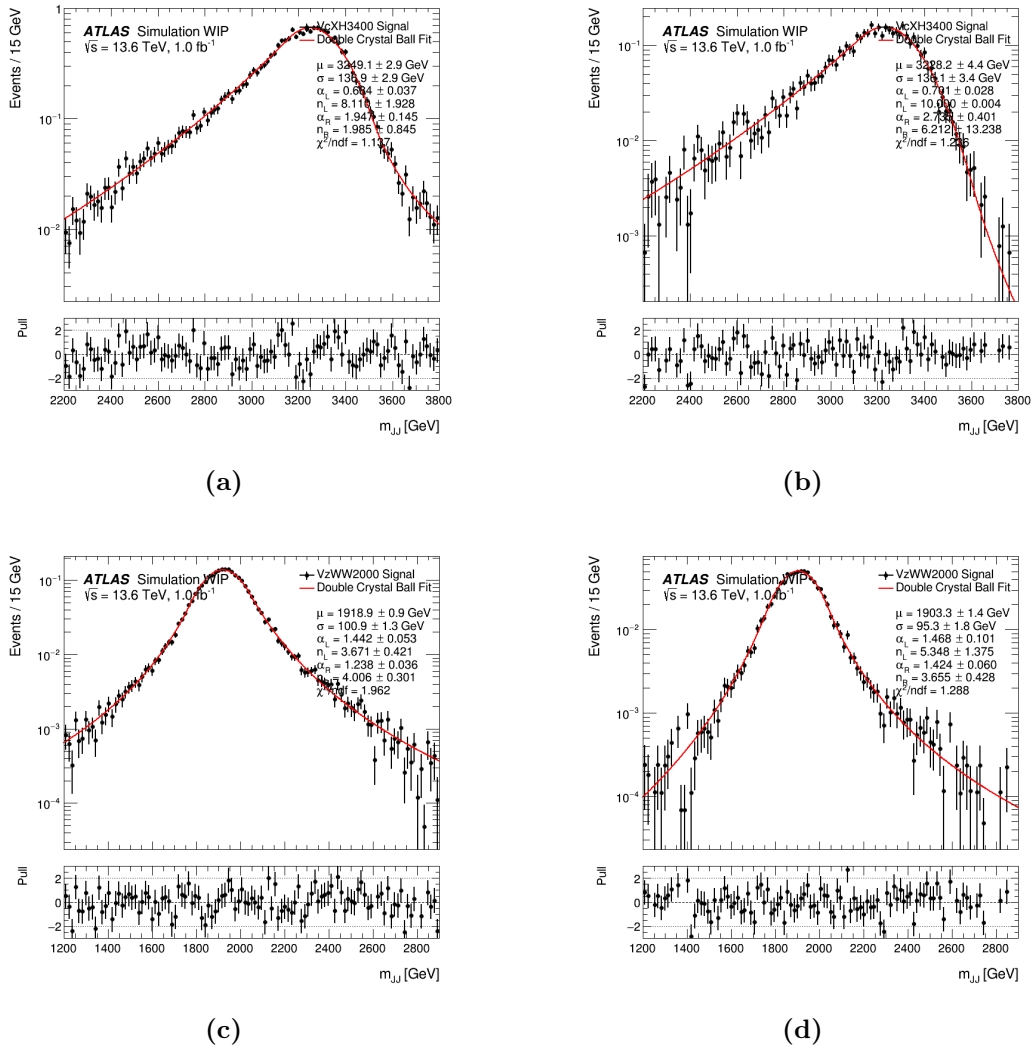
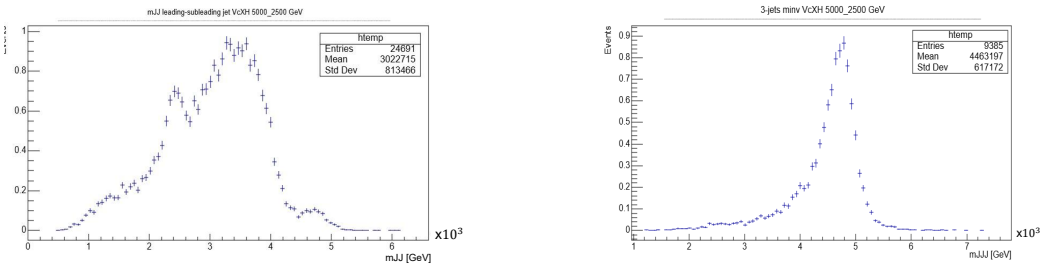



**Figure 5.12** DSCB fits to the $m_{JJ}$ distribution for signals (a) VcXH_3400 with no AS cut, (b) VcXH_3400 with AS cut at WP 99%, (c) VzWW_2000 with no AS cut, (d) VzWW_2000 with AS cut at WP 99%,

This translates into a more noisy $m_{JJ}$ distribution at WP 99%, which, nevertheless, can be still parametrized with the DSCB function. Differently, the VcXH_5000 process is modelled with difficulty by the DSCB function even without the AS cut. The limitation is more clear when looking at the $m_{JJ}$ for the sample, presented in Fig. 5.13a, where a double peak structure is visible, which is not captured by the chosen PDF. The modelling function in use, instead, could adapt better to the tri-jet invariant mass distribution, $m_{JJJ}$, visible in Fig 5.13b. This situation can be explained considering the kinematics of the simulated sample, where the $X$ boson has been produced with a mass of 2.5 $TeV$. Consequently, when the $V$ boson decays (assumed at rest), a large fraction of its momentum is transferred to the less massive product, the $H$ boson, which will undergo a more boosted decay, producing a more collimated pair of jets that can be reconstructed as a single large-radius jet. On the

other hand, the $X$ boson will decay into a pair of jets that are more separated and can be reconstructed as two distinct jets. The result of this is a final state composed by three reconstructed large-radius jets, which is not well described by the DSCB function in the $m_{JJ}$ distribution. A schematic drawing of the bosons decaying and the reconstructed jets is shown in Fig. 5.14.




**(a)** **(b)**

**Figure 5.13** Invariant mass distribution for the VcXH_5000 sample in case of (a) two or (b) three reconstructed jets in the final state.

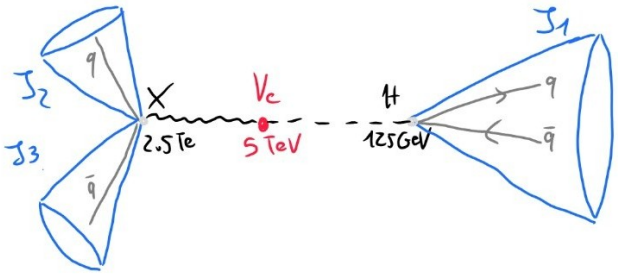



**Figure 5.14** Schematic diagram of the VcXH_5000 decay. The final state is more likely to be composed by three reconstructed large-radius jets.

For the reasons just discussed and because the variable of interest for the purpose of this analysis is $m_{JJ}$, the VcXH_5000 sample is excluded at the moment from the statistical analysis, while the Dark Jets sample is kept, since it can be still modelled with the DSCB function.
The parameters obtained from the DSCB fits are used to create an `xml card` for each signal sample, which will be used in the upper limits derivation as initial guesses for the fits, as discussed in the following.

### 5.5.2 Background

The background samples, containing the SM processes, present a smoothly falling distribution ($\sim \frac{1}{q^2}$) in the $m_{JJ}$ variable, as shown in Fig. 5.15, where an example for the QCD process is shown.
In order to determine the best function to model the background samples, ATLAS recommendations on the matter are followed [75].
The mass range to be considered for the fits is set to be $[1.5, 6.0]$ TeV, in order to

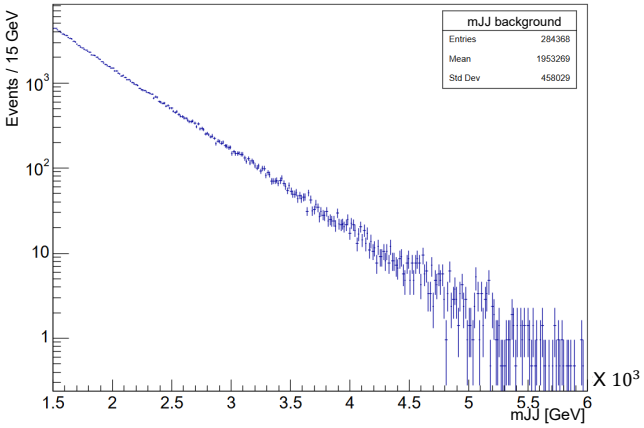



**Figure 5.15** Example of the $m_{JJ}$ distribution for a background process, without cuts on AS or $|\Delta y|$ applied, showing the smoothly falling shape.

allow a reasonable amount of events in the sidebands ($m_{JJ}$ region outside the peak of the signals) and guranteeing the trigger requirements.
The chosen function to model the background is power law functional form, defined as:

$$f_{BKG}(x) = p_0 \cdot (1-x)^{p_1} \cdot (x)^{\sum_{i=2}^{N} p_i \cdot \log(x)^{i-2}} \tag{5.5}$$

where $x = \frac{m_{JJ}}{\sqrt{s}}$ and $\sqrt{s}$ is the center-of-mass energy of the collision, 13.6 TeV for the LHC Run 3 data. N, the order of the polynomial, is a parameter to be determined, which defines the number of free parameters in the function. The term $p_0$ is indeed fixed to 1, since it is a normalization factor, which is already taken into account by the `RooFit` framework, the one responsable to execute fits [76].
The function defined above is the one forming the background PDF, which is used to perform the fits on the background samples.
Making use of the `Frequentist Framework` of the ATLAS collaboration and the `quickFit` [77] tool contained in it (which leverages the `RooFit` framework), a set of fits is performed on the background samples. The fits are executed to find the parameters that minimize the negative log-likelihood composed only by the background PDF, with different polynomial orders, to determine the best one to use in the analysis. Each fit is iterated 1000 times, with Poissonian fluctuations applied to the data, to ensure a good convergence of the fit and to avoid local minima. The best number N of free parameters to use is determined as the one with the minimum mean value of the reduced $\chi^2$ [78]. The distributions of the reduced $\chi^2$ for the different background functions are shown in Fig. 5.16.
As visible from the plot in Fig. 5.16, the best choice for the background PDF is the one with 4 free parameters, which is the one with the lowest mean value of the reduced $\chi^2$.
For these reasons, the background PDF used in the fits is defined as:

$$f_{BKG}(x) = p_0 \cdot (1-x)^{p_1} \cdot (x)^{p_2 + p_3 \cdot \log(x) + p_4 \cdot \log^2(x)} \tag{5.6}$$

Due to increasing correlation of the log parameters in the exponent, the 4-parameter functions need initial parameters reasonably close to the optimum in order to

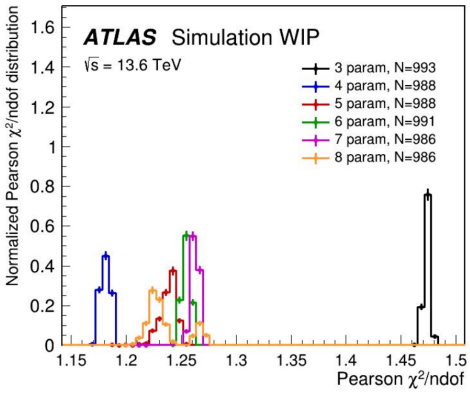



**Figure 5.16** Distributions of the reduced $\chi^2$ for different number of free parameters in the background PDF.

converge. These parameters are determined by performing a preliminary fit on the background sample on which the event selection is applied, together with the sample rescaled to a 1 $fb^{-1}$ luminosity applying the fWeight branch. The fit is executed setting the initial values and ranges to be quite wide. The parameters derived from this rough fit are then used to create an `xml card` for the background sample. The parameters contained in the `xml card` are used as initial guesses with reduced ranges for the fit with a background only PDF with 4 parameters to a background only distribution, performed to derive the best-fit parameters modelling the background sample. The results of the fit are shown in Fig. 5.17 and in Tab. 5.8.

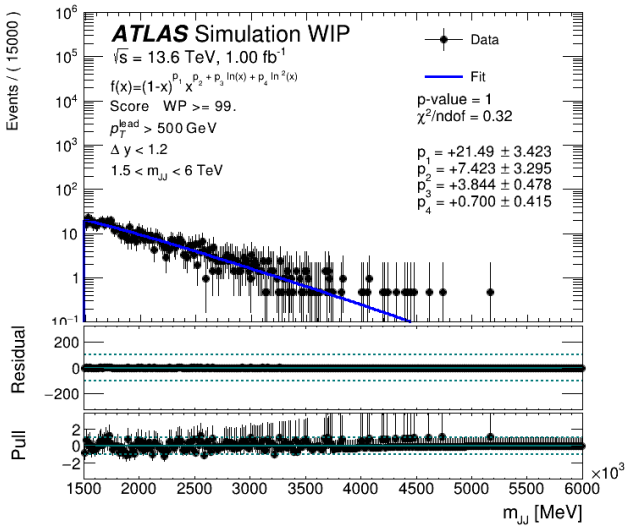



**Figure 5.17** Distributions of the reduced $\chi^2$ for different number of free parameters in the background PDF.

From the results of the fit shown in Fig. 5.17, it is visible the good agreement between the fitted function and the background distribution, given the high p-value, the low reduced $\chi^2$ and the pull distribution (normalized residuals of data with

| Parameter | Fitted value |
|---|---|
| $p_1$ | 21.5 ± 3.4 |
| $p_2$ | 7.4 ± 3.3 |
| $p_3$ | 3.8 ± 0.5 |
| $p_4$ | 0.7 ± 0.4 |

**Table 5.8** Best fit parameters for the background only PDF with 4 free parameters, derived from the fit to the background only sample.

respect to the fit) which is centered around 0 and contained within $\pm 2\sigma$.
The sample is presented and fitted as an histogram with bins of equal width of 15 GeV. This binning is chosen to have a fine granularity in $m_{JJ}$, presenting an almost-unbinned histogram, while avoiding single bin fluctuations due to the too tight width in case of 1/2 GeV bins.

## 5.6 Validating the PDFs

The modelling defined in the previous section for the signal and background samples has to be careful, to avoid rejecting genuine signals or misinterpreting background fluctuations as signal events. Two main validation tests are performed: the *spurious signal tests* (or fit bias tests) and the *signal injection tests*.
To conduct these tests, the binned profile-likelihood in use is defined as the combination of the signal and background PDFs:

$$\mathcal{L}(\vec{n}|\vec{\theta},\mu) = \prod_{i}^{N_{bins}} Poiss(n_i|\mu_s \cdot N_{sig} \cdot f_{DSCB}(\vec{\theta},\mu) + N_{bkg} \cdot f_{BKG}(\vec{\theta},\mu)) \cdot \prod_{j}^{N_{syst}} G(\theta_j) \quad (5.7)$$

where the first product runs over the number of bins which are assumed to follow a Poissonian distribution, with $n_i$ entries in each bin $i$. The second product is associated with the systematic uncertainties, which are assumed to follow a Gaussian distribution with mean 0 and standard deviation related to the uncertainty. The gaussian constraints are applied only during the upper limits derivation, as discussed in Sec. 5.7. The likelihood depends on the nuisance parameters $\vec{\theta}$, which are constrained during the fit, and the parameter of interest (PoI) $\mu$, which is free to vary during the fit. The term $N_{sig}$ is the PoI of this analysis when the signal hypothesis is tested. In the following it will be referred to as $N_{sig} = \mu$. The quantity $\mu_s$ is the signal strength $\mu_s = \frac{\sigma_{exp}}{\sigma_{th}} = \frac{N_{sig,exp}}{N_{sig}^{th}}$, it is a normalization factor for the signal PDF compairing the measured cross-section $\sigma_{exp}$ with the nominal (theoretical) one $\sigma_{th}$ assumed in the samples. $N_{bkg}$ is the number of observed background events, which is a free parameter in the fit.
From the performed fits, a set of values for all the parameters, nuisance and PoI, is obtained. Those parameters are used to compute the likelihood ratio [79], a variable that, for the Neyman-Pearson lemma, discriminates between the presence ($\mu_s > 0$)

or absence ($\mu_s$=0) of a signal in the sample. The likelihood ratio is defined as:

$$\lambda(\mu_s) = \frac{\mathcal{L}(\mu_s, \vec{\hat{\hat{\theta}}}(\mu_s))}{\mathcal{L}(\hat{\mu_s}, \vec{\hat{\theta}})} \tag{5.8}$$

where $\vec{\hat{\hat{\theta}}}$ is the value of $\theta$ that maximizes $\mathcal{L}$ for the specified $\mu$. The denominator term is the maximized likelihood function.
The ratio is used to define the test statistic $t_\mu$:

$$t_{\mu_s} = -2 \cdot \ln(\lambda(\mu_s)) \tag{5.9}$$

$t_{\mu_s}$ is a function of the PoI $\mu$ and, for the Wilk's theorem, follows a $\chi^2$ distribution. The p-value of the fit is computed from it:

$$p_{\mu_s} = \int_{t_{\mu_s,obs}}^{\infty} f(t_{\mu_s}|\mu_s) dt_{\mu_s} \tag{5.10}$$

where $t_{\mu,obs}$ is the value of the statistic $t_\mu$ observed from the data and $f(t_\mu|\mu)$ denotes the PDF of $t_\mu$ under the assumption of the signal strength $\mu$. $p_{\mu_s}$ is associated with the probability of observing $t > t_{\mu_s,obs}$, quantifying the disagreement between the data and the tested hypothesis.
A particular case of test statistic is the one defined for the background only hypothesis, which is obtained setting $\mu_s = 0$ in Eq. 5.9 and it is defined as:

$$t_0 = -2 \cdot \ln(\lambda(0)) \quad \text{for} \quad \hat{\mu_s} \geq 0, \quad t_0 = 0 \quad otherwise \tag{5.11}$$

From this, the p-value for the background only hypothesis can be computed, which is used to quantify the agreement between the data and the background only hypothesis. It is computed as:

$$p_0 = \int_{t_{0,obs}}^{\infty} f(t_0|\mu_s = 0) dt_0 \tag{5.12}$$

If the $\mu_s = 0$ hypothesis is rejected, it means that the data is not compatible with the background only hypothesis and a signal may be present in the sample.
From these tools, the $CL_s$ method can be introduced [79, 80]. The distribution of $t_{\mu_s,obs}$ is scanned for different values of $\mu_s$, to derive the probability of observing a worse t than $t_{\mu_s,obs}$ ($t > t_{\mu_s,obs}$). This defines the $CL_{s+b}$, also known as the p-value $p_{s+b}$. Similarly, the $CL_b$ ($p_b$) is defined as the probability of observing a worse t than $t_{\mu_s,obs}$ under the background only hypothesis ($\mu_s = 0$). The $CL_s$ is then defined as the ratio between the two quantities:

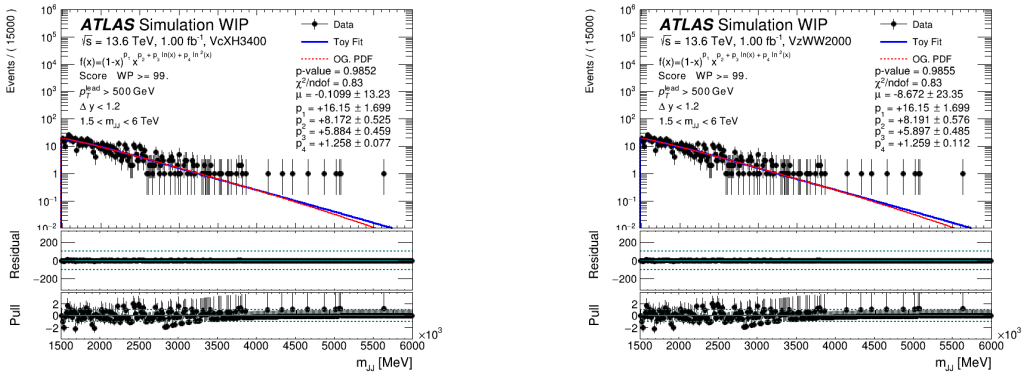
$$CL_s = \frac{CL_{s+b}}{CL_b} \tag{5.13}$$

This quantity is compared with a threshold value $\alpha$, usually set to 0.05. Values of $CL_s$ higher than $\alpha$ are considered to be compatible with the tested hypothesis, pointing out that data do not show a significant statistical disagreement with it. In the case of $CL_s$ lower than the threshold, the null hypothesis (sample composed by background only) can be rejected with a confidence level of $1 - \alpha$ (95%).

The interpretation of the p-value presented above is used to verify the presence of a signal in the sample, by testing the background only hypothesis ($\mu_s = 0$) and the signal+background hypothesis ($\mu_s > 0$). The same quantity can be used when evaluating the goodness of the fit, where the null hypothesis is the good agreement between the data and the fitted function with the best-fit parameters, while the alternative hypothesis is the disagreement between the two.

### 5.6.1 Spurious signal tests

The first validation test performed is the *spurious signal test*, also known as *fit bias test*. In fact, it aims to quantify the bias introduced by the choice of the background PDF in the fit. A possible bias could be that the flexible background model could absorb part of the signal or that the signal+background model returns a non-zero signal yield even when fitting a background only sample to accomodate the fluctuations of the background distribution. The spurious signal test, indeed, corresponds to the difference between the median fitted signal yield and the known signal yield.
The test is performed selecting a background only sample (signal yield = 0) with a 1 $fb^{-1}$ luminosity and a fit with a PDF containing both the signal and the bacgkround component is executed. To take into account the statistical fluctuations of the sample, 100 variations of the background only histogram are generated, where each of them is associated with a Poissonian fluctuation with a different seed. Each of these 100 histograms is fitted with the signal+background PDF. At this point, the fitted amount of signal is extracted from each iteration, the mean value $S_{spur}$ and the width (RMS) $\sigma_{fit}$ of the distribution of fitted values are computed. This test is repeated for each of the different signal hypotheses and the different mass points. For each signal hypotheses, the extracted quantities for each mass point are plotted in a graph, where the x-axis is the true mass of the signal and the y-axis is amount of signal derived from the fits. In principle, $S_{spur}$ should be compatible with 0, given the fact that the fitted events were generated under the background only hypothesis. More importantly, the ratio $S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}$ for each sample is computed and plotted in the lower pad on the same graph. Following the ATLAS recommendations [75], the ratio points should be in a range of $\pm$ 0.5 to pass this first test.
Two example plots of the fits to the signal hypothesis VcXH_2300 and VzWW_2000 to the background only sample for a single seed are shown in Fig. 5.18. Other plots for the other signal samples with the same seed are reported in Appendix A.
As visible from Fig. 5.18, the fits with a combined PDF are in good agreement with the background only histograms, with a p-value of 0.99 for both the signals. Some modelling issues are visible in the tails of the distributions, which are due to the lack of statistics in those regions, which is not enough to constrain the fit.
The results of the fit bias study at 1 $fb^{-1}$ are presented in Fig. 5.19 and in Tab. 5.9. The results presented above in Fig. 5.19 and in Tab. 5.9 show that the spurious signal test is passed for all the signal samples and mass points, given the ratio $|S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}|$ within the required $\pm$ 0.5 range.
The study conducted at 1 $fb^{-1}$ is then repeated scaling the samples to higher luminosities of [1.65, 16.5, 50.0, 100.0, 139.0, 165.0, 332.0] $fb^{-1}$. These values are




**(a)** **(b)**

**Figure 5.18** Fits for the spurious signal test at 1 $fb^{-1}$ for signals hypothesis (a) VcXH_3400 and (b) VzWW_2000. The red curve represents the background function with the best-fit parameters determined from the background only fit. The blue curve represents the signal+background function with the best-fit parameters determined during the S+B fit to a varied background only sample

| **Signal** | VcXH_2300 | VcXH_3400 | VcXH_6000 | VzWW_2000 | VzWW_3000 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\lvert S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}\rvert$ | 0.24 | 0.19 | 0.07 | 0.01 | 0.19 |
| **Signal** | VzWW_4000 | VzWW_5000 | Wprime | DJ | / |
| $\lvert S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}\rvert$ | 0.19 | 0.13 | 0.18 | 0.20 | / |

**Table 5.9** Ratio values $|S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}|$ for the spurious signal test at 1 $fb^{-1}$ for the different signal samples and mass points. All values are within the ± 0.5 range, meaning that the test is considered passed.

chosen since they correspond to fractions of the partial Run 3 sample studied (165.0 $fb^{-1}$ collected from 2022 to 2024), to the full Run 2 sample (139.0 $fb^{-1}$) and to the full Run 3 sample (332.0 $fb^{-1}$), or simply as intermediate values. Those tests are performed to check the stability of the results with increasing statistics and to ensure that the background PDF is still able to model the background sample without introducing a bias in the fit.

The results of this study are presented in Appendix A, where the plots for the different luminosities are shown.

Analysing these results, it is visible that the ratio value is stable in the required range for all the signal, with samples at higher masses showing a reduced uncertainty on the fitted signal, given the lower statistics in the background sample at higher $m_{JJ}$ values. For these reasons, the spurious signal test is considered passed for all the signal samples, mass points and luminosities considered in this study.

The test just discussed is performed to derive a systematic uncertainty to apply when performing the final fits and upper limits derivation. This uncertainty is referred to as *background modelling uncertainty* which is included in the likelihood as a second source of signal with the same $m_{JJ}$ shape of the true signal:

$$N_{sig}(m_{JJ}) = N_{sig}^{true}(m_{JJ}) + S_{modelling}(m_{JJ}) \cdot \theta_{modelling} \tag{5.14}$$

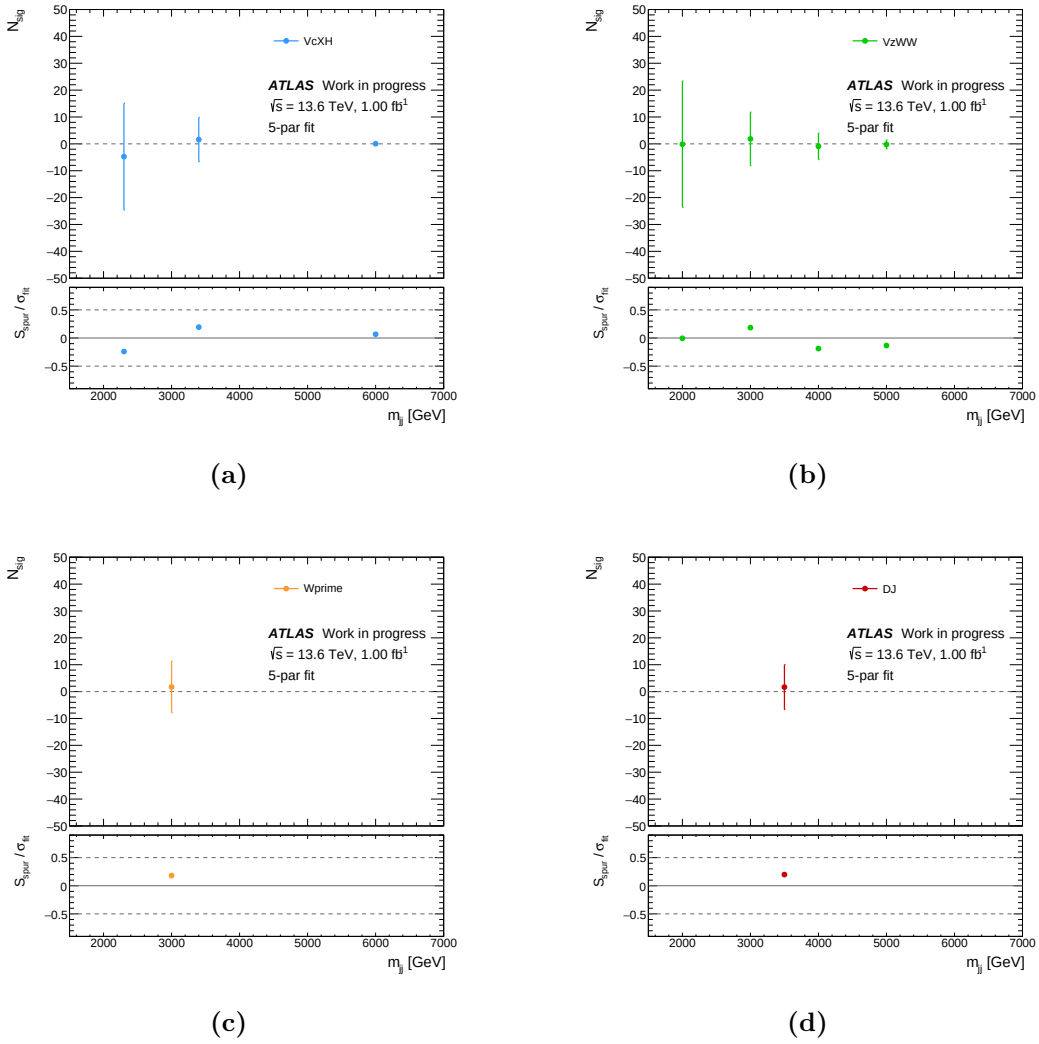



**Figure 5.19** Spurious signal test results at 1 $fb^{-1}$ for signal process (a) VcXH, (b) VzWW, (c) Wprime, (d) DarkJets. The quantity on the x-axis is the true mass of the signal hypothesis, while the y-axis is the fitted amount of signal $S_{spur}$ in the upper pad and the ratio $S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}$ in the lower pad. In all cases, the requirements of $S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}$ within $\pm$ 0.5 are satisfied and this test can be considered passed.

where $S_{modelling}(m_{JJ})$ is the fitted amount of spurious signal, the normalization term $\theta_{modelling}$ is a nuisance parameter constrained by a Gaussian term of mean 0 in the likelihood, with a width set to $|S_{spur}(m_{JJ})|$.
The results of fits and upper limits derivation executed applying this systematic uncertainty are presented in Sec. 5.7.

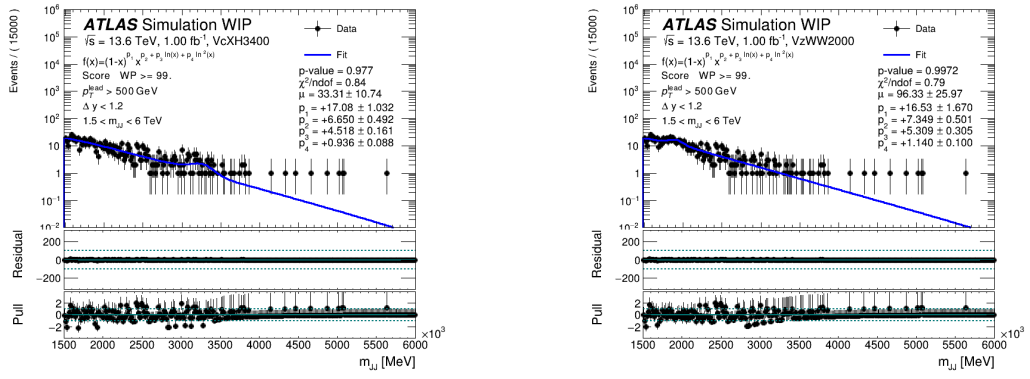
### 5.6.2 Signal injection tests

The second validation test performed is the *signal injection test*, which aims to quantify the ability of the model to recover a given amount of signal injected in a background sample. This validation proceeds in a similar way to previous, with the

main difference situated in the creation of the histogram to fit, which is built as follows.
The amount of injeted signal is quantified in terms of significance Z, which is defined as $Z \sim \frac{S}{\sqrt{B}}$, where S is the number of injected signal events and B is the number of background events in the Region of Interest (RoI). It has to be noted that the definition of significance used in this study is a simplified version, which is assumed to be a limit of the more general one $Z = \sqrt{2\Big((s+b)ln(1+\frac{s}{b}) - s\Big)}$ and it is valid in the regime where B high enough and B»S, which is the case for the samples considered in this analysis [79]. Inverting the definition of Z, the number of injected signal events can be expressed as:

$$S_{inj} \sim Z \cdot \sqrt{B} \tag{5.15}$$

where Z is varied between 1 and 5, in steps of 1. B is defined in the RoI as $B = \sum_i^{bins\ in\ FWHM} B_i$. The RoI, in fact, is defined as the Full Width at Half Maximum (FWHM) of the signal in question, which is computed from the histogram of the signal in question, after the event selection is applied. The number of background events in each bin $B_i$, instead, is not derived from the background histogram but from the background only fit to this sample. This choice is made to avoid the statistical fluctuations of the background sample in the high-mass tails and to be able to extrapolate a background estimate even in this region, where the background sample is not populated enough to allow a reliable estimate.
The injected sample generated as described, is then fitted with the combined PDF, as in the previous test, and the fitted amount of signal $S_{fit}$ is extracted. Two example plots of the fits to the signal hypothesis VcXH_2300 and VzWW_2000 to the injected sample with Z=5 are shown in Fig. 5.20. Other plots for the other signal samples with the same seed are reported in Appendix A.




**(a)** **(b)**

**Figure 5.20** Fits for the signal injection test at 1 $fb^{-1}$ for signals hypothesis (a) VcXH_3400 and (b) VzWW_2000, with a significance Z=5 injected.

The plots in Fig. 5.20 show the good agreement between the fitted function and the injected sample, with a p-value of 0.97 and 0.99 respectively for the two signals. Despite this, some fluctuations, probably due to the binning of the histogram, are

present across the distribution and they are expected to be smoothed out when scaling the samples to higher luminosities, where the statistics is higher and the binning is less subject to fluctuations.
From these fits, the quantity $S_{spur}$ is computed as the difference between the fitted and injected amount of signal, $S_{spur} = S_{fit} - S_{inj}$. The test, once again, is execute with 100 pseudodata samples. Extracting the values from the fits, $S_{spur}$ is mediated over the distribution and the width $\sigma_{fit}$ is computed.
The computed quantities are then plotted, in a similar plane as before, with the x-axis being the amount of injected signal in terms of significance and the y-axis being the fitted significance. Each graph contains curves for the different mass points of the same signal process. The results obtained from the signal injection tests at $1 fb^{-1}$ are shown in Fig. 5.21.
The requirements for the signal injection test are that the main curve of each mass point should be compatible with a linearly increasing function with slope 1 and, as the previous test, the ratio $S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}$ has to be within the $\pm$ 0.5 range. The results presented above in Fig. 5.21 show that the signal injection test pass these requirements for the majority of the signal samples, mass points and injected significances. Some issues are visible for higher mass points as the VcXH_6000, where the statistics is lower and the background sample is not populated enough to allow a reliable estimate of the background in the RoI, resulting in higher variance in the main curve. Other issues are visible for the lower mass points, where the distribution is more subject to statistical fluctuations due to the binning of the histogram.
For these reasons, the signal injection test at 1 $fb^{-1}$ is considered passed for the samples Wprime and Dark Jets, together with the VzWW signal at lower masses and VcXH at 3400 GeV and 6000 GeV. Concerning the other mass points, the test is not passed and the results have to be considered with caution, as discussed in the following.

| **Signal** | VcXH_2300 | VcXH_3400 | VcXH_6000 | VzWW_2000 | VzWW_3000 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Passed** | ✗ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| **Signal** | VzWW_4000 | VzWW_5000 | Wprime | DJ | / |
| **Passed** | ✓ | ✗ | ✓ | ✓ | / |

**Table 5.10** Lists of signal hypotheses passing or not the signal injection test at 1 $fb^{-1}$.

The study conducted at 1 $fb^{-1}$ is in fact repeated scaling the samples to higher luminosities of [1.65, 16.5, 139.0, 165.0, 332.0] $fb^{-1}$, to check the stability of the results with increasing statistics. The plots associated with these latter tests are reported in Appendix A. From those plots, the trend is more crucial than the one observed at lower luminosity. In particular, increasing the statistics it is more evident that the only samples passing the signal injection test with the chosen PDFs and event selection are only those with masses around 3-3.5 TeV. All the other samples, both at lower and higher masses, show high fluctuations in the main curve and the ratio $S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}$ clearly deviating from the $\pm$ 0.5 range, meaning that the test is not passed. The behaviour observed during this study could be associated with a cut on AS too aggressive, especially for the higher mass points: relaxing the requirement on

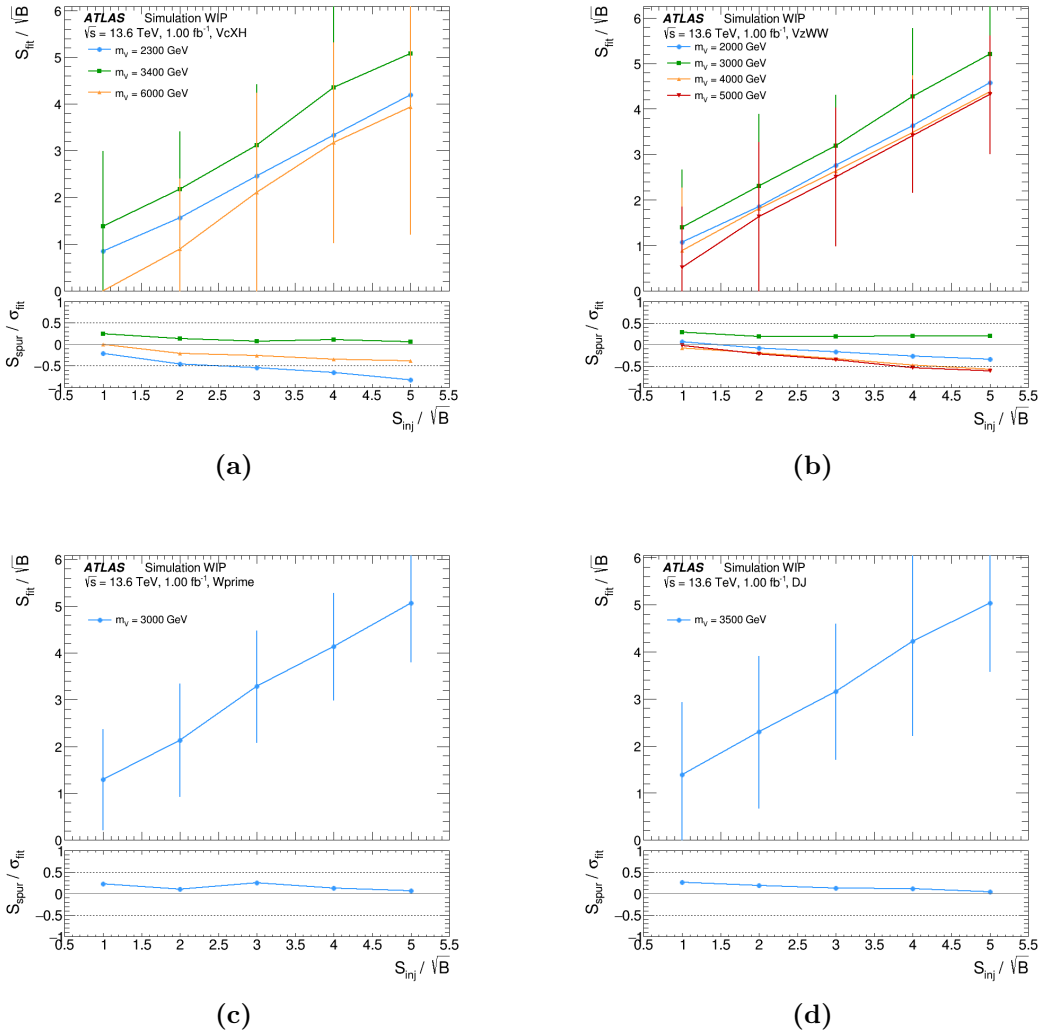



**Figure 5.21** Signal injection test results at 1 $fb^{-1}$ for signal process (a) VcXH, (b) VzWW, (c) Wprime, (d) DarkJets. Each plot shows a different curve for each mass point of the signal hypothesis, with the x-axis being the injected significance and the y-axis being the fitted significance. In most of the cases, the requirements of $S_{spur}/\sigma_{fit}$ within $\pm$ 0.5 are satisfied.

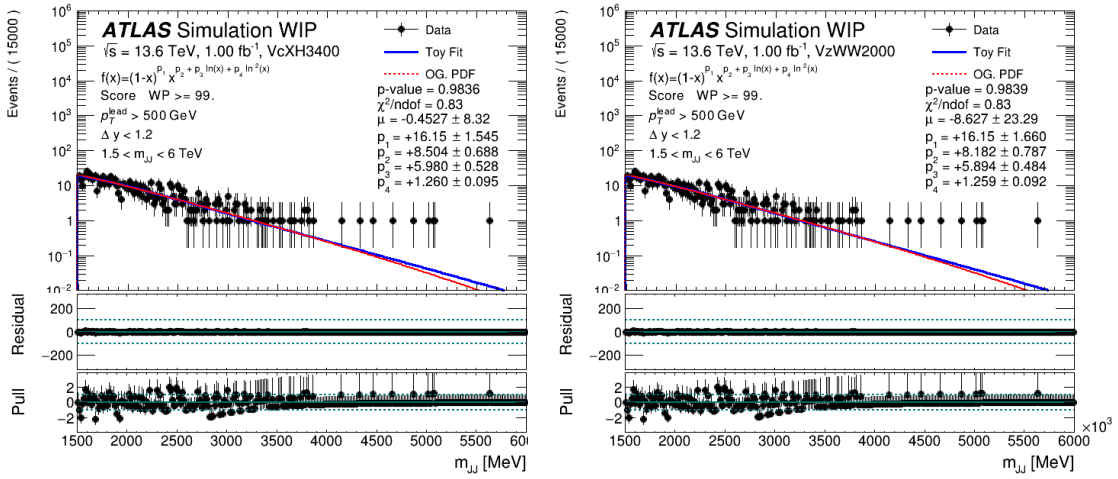
the computed score, moving it from 99% to 90% or 80%, could allow to recover more background events in the RoI, improving the modelling of samples and, consequently, the results of the test. Another possible explanation is that the chosen background PDF, with 4 free parameters, is not flexible enough to model the background sample in the RoI, in particular for higher mass points where the statistics in that region is low. Concerning the lower mass points, the issue is probably associated either with the binning of the histogram, which is too tight and more subject to fluctuations, or with the choice of the background PDF.

In conclusion, despite the event selection with WP99 passes the spurious signal test indicating a contained bias in the background sample modelling, the signal injection one is more critical and not passed for all the signal samples and mass points. For

these reasons, the study presented here is considered as preliminary and the choice of both the WP for the event selection and the background PDF should be further investigated, before applying them in the final analysis on the real data.

## 5.7 Upper limits derivation

Using the validated PDFs for the signal and background samples, the upper limits on the signal cross-section are derived.
This computation is performed with the `quickLimit` utility of the `quickFit` package, which is part of the `Frequentist Framework` of the ATLAS collaboration. The utility implements the $CL_S$ method [79, 80], leveraging the likelihood defined in Eq. 5.7 computed with the best-fit parameters obtained from the fits to the sample considering also the systematic uncertainty associated with background modelling, as discussed in Sec. 5.6.1.
In Fig. 5.22 the fits to the background only sample with the combined PDF, taking into account the systematic uncertainty derived from the spurious signal test, are shown for the VcXH_3400 and VzWW_2000 signals.




**(a)** **(b)**

**Figure 5.22** Fits to the background only sample, with systematic uncertainty applied, at 1 $fb^{-1}$ for signals hypothesis (a) VcXH_3400 and (b) VzWW_2000.

The fits to the other signal hypotheses are reported in Appendix A, where the same study for the different rescaled luminosities is also shown.
The fit results are accepted if the p-value is higher than the canonical 0.05 threshold. Despite some fluctuations in the tails of the distributions due to the low statistics in those regions, the requirement is satisfied for all the fits performed, with p-values higher than 0.05 for all the signal hypotheses and luminosities considered.
For the reasons just discussed, it is expected that once the analysis will be performed on the real data, the results associated with the search for lower mass signals will be more subject to systematic uncertainties, as the background modelling one, and for those at higher masses, the statistical uncertainty will be dominant.

The best-fit parameters are then used to compute the upper limits on the signal cross-section for each signal hypothesis and mass point, at the different tested luminosities. Since the PoI of the likelihood of this analysis is the number of signal $N_{sig}$, referred to as $\mu$, using the definition of signal strength $\mu_s$, limits are derived on this quantity and then converted to the cross-section $\sigma_{exp}$ using the relation:

$$\sigma_{exp} = \frac{\mu}{Sig_{int} \cdot R_{lumi}} \cdot \sigma_{th} \tag{5.16}$$

where $\mu$ is the limit derived on the number of signal events ($N_{sig,exp}$), $Sig_{int}$ is the integral of the signal PDF serving as $N^{th}_{sig}$, $R_{lumi}$ is the ratio between the luminosity to which the sample is rescaled and the initial luminosity (1 $fb^{-1}$) and $\sigma_{th}$ is the assumed theoretical cross-section of the signal in question reported in Tab. 5.1.
The derived expected upper limits on $\sigma_{exp}$, together with $\pm$ 1 and $\pm$ 2 $\sigma$ uncertainty bands, are shown in Fig. 5.23-5.25 for the different signals and luminosities considered in this study.

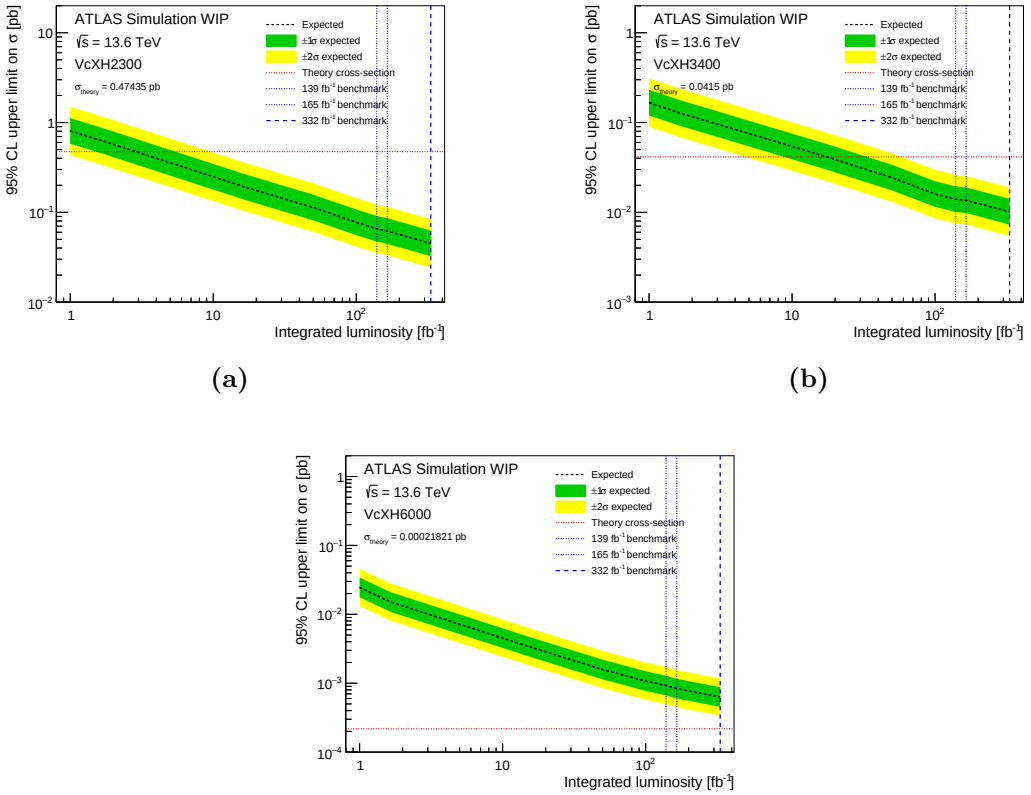



**Figure 5.23** Expected upper limits scan at different luminosities on $\sigma_{exp}$ for the VcXH signal, with mass points (a) 2300, (b) 3400 and (c) 6000 GeV. The plot presents an horizontal red line, corresponding to $\sigma_{th}$, and three blue vertical lines, corresponding to the luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 2 sample), 165 $fb^{-1}$ (partial Run 3 sample) and 332 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 3 sample).

Analaysing the figures 5.23-5.25, it is visible that the $\sigma_{exp}$ limits have a dependence on the luminosity of approximately $1/\sqrt{\mathcal{L}}$, as expected.

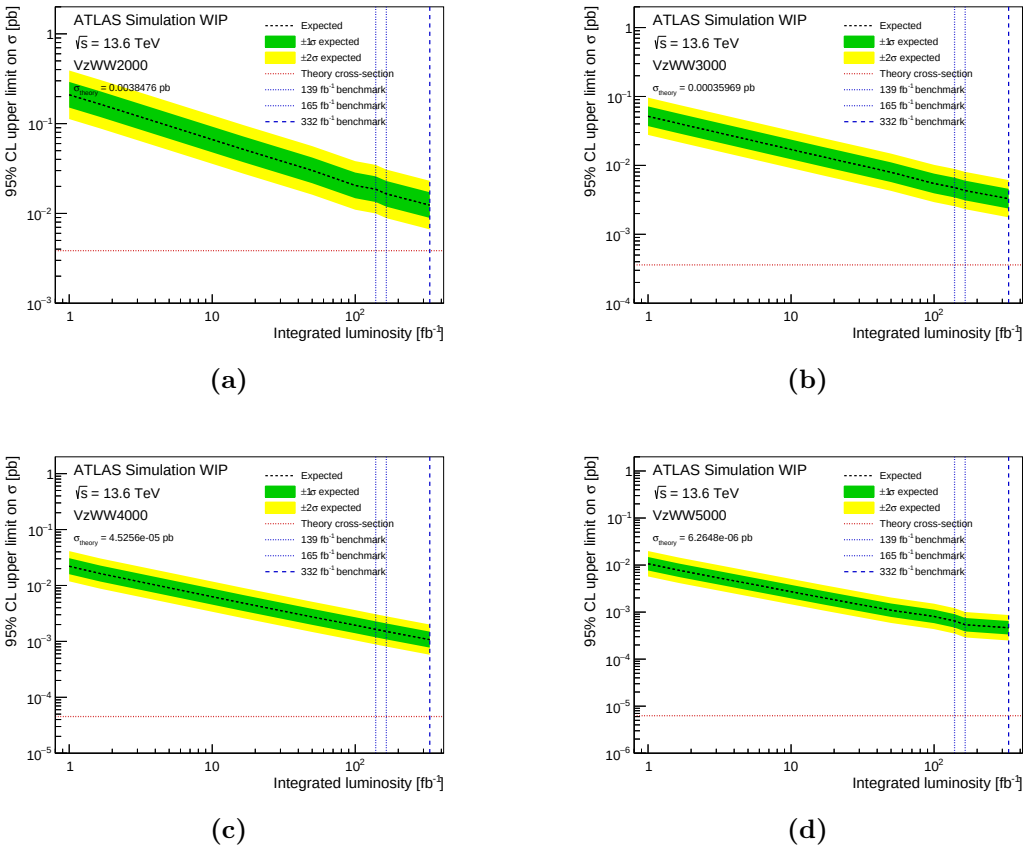
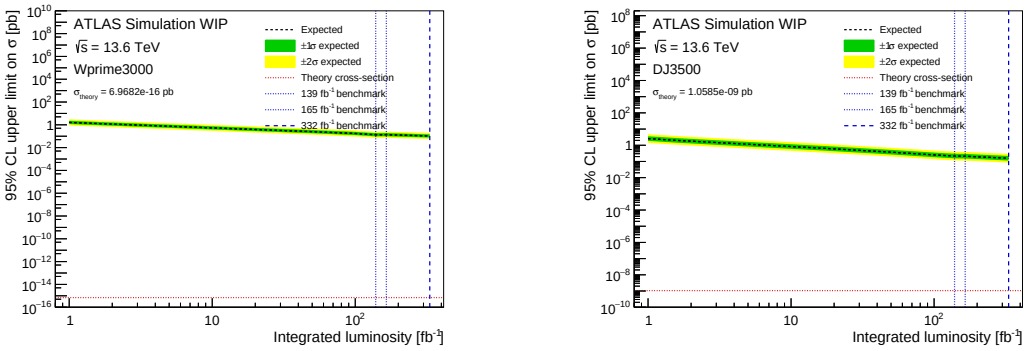



**Figure 5.24** Expected upper limits scan at different luminosities on $\sigma_{exp}$ for the VzWW signal, with mass points (a) 2000, (b) 3000, (c) 4000 and (d)5000 GeV. The plot presents an horizontal red line, corresponding to $\sigma_{th}$, and three blue vertical lines, corresponding to the luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 2 sample), 165 $fb^{-1}$ (partial Run 3 sample) and 332 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 3 sample).

Numerical values of the $\sigma_{exp}$ for the three target luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$, 165 $fb^{-1}$ and 332 $fb^{-1}$ are reported in Tab. 5.11 for the different signal hypotheses and mass points. For the same luminosities and signal hypotheses, a comparison between the $\sigma_{exp}$ and the theoretical cross-section $\sigma_{th}$ is shown in Fig. 5.26, where the ratio $(\sigma_{exp} - \sigma_{th})/\sigma_{th}$ is plotted as a function of the signal. The grids are a rapid visualisation of the results reported in Tab. 5.11 with respect to the the starting point: if the ratio is positive, the limit is above the theoretical cross-section and the signal is not excluded and the square is colored in a red scale. While if the ratio is negative, the limit is below the theoretical cross-section and the signal is excluded with the analysis improving the state of the art for that process. In this latter case the square is colored in a green scale, with darker colors corresponding to a higher exclusion power of the analysis.
From the results presented in Tab. 5.11 and Fig. 5.26, considerations on the exclusion power of the analysis can be made. At the target luminosities, the analysis with an event selection based on AS cuts has sufficient sensitivity to exclude $V \to XH$ signals with masses 2300 GeV and 3400 GeV. It also presents promising performance




**(a)** **(b)**

**Figure 5.25** Expected upper limits scan at different luminosities on $\sigma_{exp}$ for the (a) Wprime and (b) Dark Jets signals. The plot presents an horizontal red line, corresponding to $\sigma_{th}$, and three blue vertical lines, corresponding to the luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 2 sample), 165 $fb^{-1}$ (partial Run 3 sample) and 332 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 3 sample).

for the higher mass point of 6000 GeV together with the lower mass points of the $V \to WW$ signals, with masses 2000 GeV and 3000 GeV. The analysis is not able to exclude the higher mass points of the $V \to WW$ signals, with masses 4000 GeV and 5000 GeV, nor the Wprime and Dark Jets signals.
These results could be associated with multiple aspects. In the first place, combining the distributions of AS and $|\Delta y|$, which are the requirements involved in the event selection, the samples with worse performance in terms of upper limits are those with a smaller deviation from the background sample, in particular the Dark Jets and Wprime. These reduced deviations could be associated with the fact that those samples have a more complex substructure, which is probably not well captured by the trained GNN. Improvements in the training of the GNN could lead to a better discrimination power and, consequently, to an improved performance of the analysis. Secondly, the expected upper limits presented in this section are derived applying a cut on the AS at WP 99%. The validation tests presented in Sec. 5.6 show that a better compromise in terms of WP should be considered, since the current choice performs well in terms of fit bias but it is more critical in terms of recovering the injected signal. This latter aspect is crucial going towards the execution of the analysis on real data where, in the (very rare) case of a signal presence, the analysis should be able to recover it correctly and not to reject it due to an aggressive cut on the AS.
For all the reasons presented above, the AD strategy presents sufficient sensitivity but a more precise choice of the threshold is required to improve the final results.

## 5.8 Comparison with a $D_2$ based event selection

In order to extract an estimation of the advantages of the AD strategy and why it is worth training a GNN to perform an event selection, a comparison with is performed an analysis conducted with requirements on a more standard variable, $D_2$ (Sec. 3.3.2).

| Signal | $\sigma_{th}$ [pb] | $\sigma_{exp}$ [pb] at $\mathcal{L} = 139\ fb^{-1}$ | $\sigma_{exp}$ [pb] at $\mathcal{L} = 165\ fb^{-1}$ | $\sigma_{exp}$ [pb] at $\mathcal{L} = 332\ fb^{-1}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| VcXH_2300 | $4.7435 \cdot 10^{-1}$ | $6.56^{+2.57}_{-1.83} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $6.18^{+2.42}_{-1.73} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $4.51^{+1.77}_{-1.26} \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| VcXH_3400 | $4.1550 \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.40^{+0.55}_{-0.39} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.36^{+0.53}_{-0.38} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.01^{+0.40}_{-0.28} \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| VcXH_6000 | $2.1811 \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $9.24^{+3.62}_{-2.58} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $8.32^{+3.26}_{-2.33} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $6.28^{+2.46}_{-1.76} \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| VzWW_2000 | $3.8476 \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $1.86^{+0.73}_{-0.52} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.65^{+0.65}_{-0.46} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.24^{+0.48}_{-0.35} \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| VzWW_3000 | $3.5969 \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $4.76^{+1.86}_{-1.33} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $4.31^{+1.69}_{-1.20} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $3.28^{+1.29}_{-0.92} \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VzWW_4000 | $4.5256 \cdot 10^{-5}$ | $1.64^{+0.64}_{-0.46} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $1.50^{+0.59}_{-0.42} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $1.07^{+0.42}_{-0.30} \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VzWW_5000 | $6.2648 \cdot 10^{-6}$ | $6.50^{+2.55}_{-1.82} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $5.38^{+2.11}_{-1.50} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $4.64^{+1.82}_{-1.30} \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| Wprime | $6.9682 \cdot 10^{-16}$ | $1.34^{+0.53}_{-0.37} \cdot 10^{-1}$ | $1.36^{+0.53}_{-0.38} \cdot 10^{-1}$ | $1.05^{+0.41}_{-0.29} \cdot 10^{-1}$ |
| DarkJet | $1.05853 \cdot 10^{-9}$ | $2.15^{+0.84}_{-0.60} \cdot 10^{-1}$ | $2.10^{+0.82}_{-0.59} \cdot 10^{-1}$ | $1.57^{+0.62}_{-0.44} \cdot 10^{-1}$ |

**Table 5.11** Expected upper limits derived selecting on AS for each signal and mass point at the three target luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$, 165 $fb^{-1}$ and 332 $fb^{-1}$. The theoretical cross-section $\sigma_{th}$ is also reported.

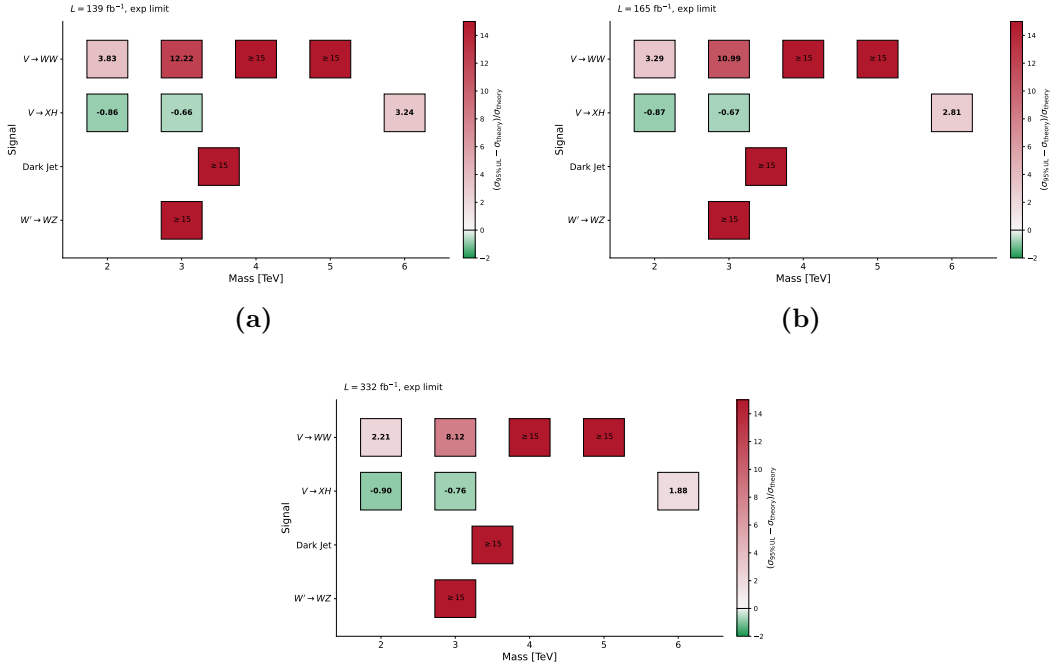



**Figure 5.26** Grid plots showing the exclusion limit $\sigma_{exp}$ compared with $\sigma_{exp}$ at (a) 139 $fb^{-1}$, (b) 165 $fb^{-1}$ and (c) 332 $fb^{-1}$. The grids are a rapid visualisation of the results reported in Tab. 5.11 with respect to the the starting point: if the ratio is positive, the limit is above the theoretical cross-section and the signal is not excluded, while if it is negative, the limit is below the theoretical cross-section and the signal is excluded with the analysis improving the state of the art for that process.

The comparison starts from the definition of the $D_{2,ev}$ variable, which is considered as the product of $D_2$ of the leading and subleading jets, $D_{2,ev} = D_{2,lead} \cdot D_{2,sublead}$. This variable is introduced to get a direct comparison with the AD strategy, where the selection is performed on the AS of the leading and subleading jets separately and then combined using the logical AND operator. After having determined the right variable to deal with, WPs are computed on the $D_{2,ev}$ distirbution presented in Fig. 5.27 to reject from 20% to 99.9% of the background events. The WPs computed are reported in Tab. 5.12.

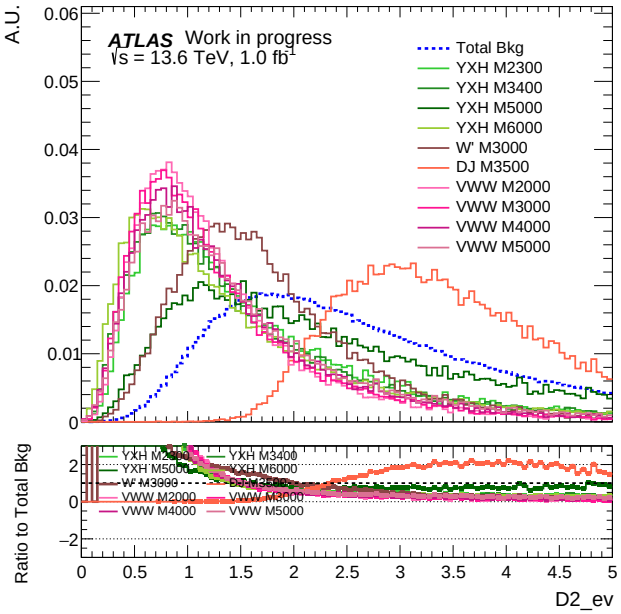



**Figure 5.27** Distributions of the $D_{2,ev}$ variable for the total background and different signal processes.

| **BKG rejection (%)** | 20 | 30 | 40 | 50 | 60 | 70 | 80 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $D_{2,lead}$ **cut value** | 4.48 | 3.66 | 3.07 | 2.61 | 2.23 | 1.89 | 1.57 |
| **BKG rejection (%)** | 85 | 90 | 95 | 97 | 99 | 99.9 | / |
| $D_{2,lead}$ **cut value** | 1.40 | 1.21 | 0.98 | 0.84 | 0.63 | 0.36 | / |

**Table 5.12** WPs and respective rejection factors computed on the QCD background.

Given the $D_{2,ev}$ distribution in Fig. 5.27, it is clear that in this case the SRs are defined as events with $D_{2,ev}$ below the WPs, while the CRs are defined as events with $D_{2,ev}$ above the cut values.
From what is presented above, it is clear that applying a cut on $D_{2,ev}$ at WP 99% to get a direct comparison with AS results, the Dark Jets sample will be rejected almost completely and for this reason following results will not include this sample. A similar outcome is expected, since the discriminative quantity in this case is defined to target events with a 2-prong substructure, while the Dark Jets sample is characterized by a more complex substructure, which is not well captured by it.

The PDFs defined for the selection on AS are used also in this case, assuming them to be valid also for the $D_{2,ev}$ selection. Given this assumption, the results presented below are to be considered as preliminary, because in principle the different event selection, now based on $D_{2,ev}$, could modify the $m_{JJ}$ distribution, the validation tests executed and the chosen PDFs. Following this assumption, expected upper limits on $\sigma_{exp}$ are derived for the different signal hypotheses and mass points, at the same luminosities considered before. The results of the limits are reported in Fig. 5.28-5.29, Tab. 5.13 and Fig. 5.30.

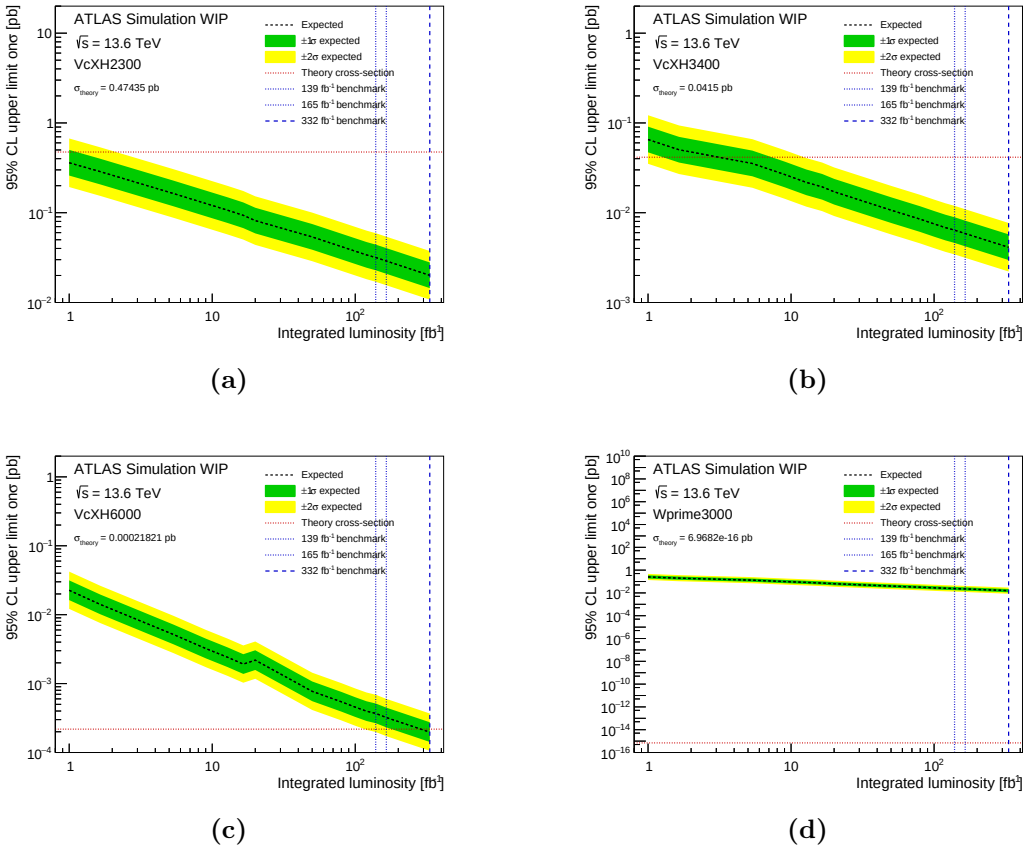
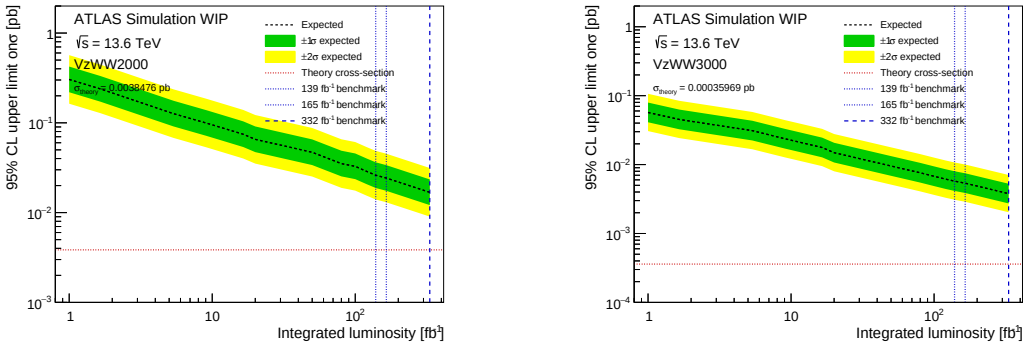



**Figure 5.28** Expected upper limits scan at different luminosities on $\sigma_{exp}$ applying cuts on $D_{2,ev}$ for the VcXH signal, with mass points (a) 2300, (b) 3400 and (c) 6000 GeV, (d) Wprime signal. The plot presents an horizontal red line, corresponding to $\sigma_{th}$, and three blue vertical lines, corresponding to the luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 2 sample), 165 $fb^{-1}$ (partial Run 3 sample) and 332 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 3 sample).

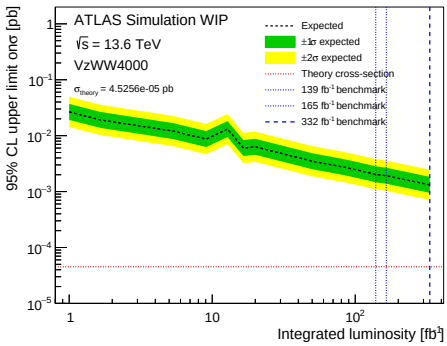
At this point it is possible to compare the results obtained with the two different event selections. As visible from Tab. 5.11 for the AS selection and Tab. 5.13 for the $D_{2,ev}$ selection, the expected upper limits derived with the AD strategy are competitive with respect to the ones derived with the $D_{2,ev}$ selection but not lower for all the benchmark signals. Apparently it is not worth investing time and resources in training a complex GNN to perform an event selection since a simpler variable, such as $D_{2,ev}$, can provide better results. However, this assumption is not



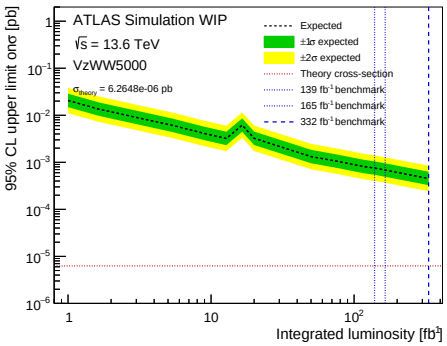

(a)




(b)




(c)




(d)

**Figure 5.29** Expected upper limits scan at different luminosities on $\sigma_{exp}$ applying cuts on $D_{2,ev}$ for the VzWW signal, with mass points (a) 2000, (b) 3000, (c) 4000 and (d)5000 GeV. The plot presents an horizontal red line, corresponding to $\sigma_{th}$, and three blue vertical lines, corresponding to the luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 2 sample), 165 $fb^{-1}$ (partial Run 3 sample) and 332 $fb^{-1}$ (full Run 3 sample).

| Signal | $\sigma_{th}$ [pb] | $\sigma_{exp}$ [pb] at $\mathcal{L} = 139\ fb^{-1}$ | $\sigma_{exp}$ [pb] at $\mathcal{L} = 165\ fb^{-1}$ | $\sigma_{exp}$ [pb] at $\mathcal{L} = 332\ fb^{-1}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| VcXH_2300 | $4.7435 \cdot 10^{-1}$ | $3.17^{+1.24}_{-0.89} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $2.8^{+1.09}_{-0.77} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $2.01^{+0.79}_{-0.56} \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| VcXH_3400 | $4.1550 \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $6.40^{+2.51}_{-1.79} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $5.86^{+2.30}_{-1.64} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $4.12^{+1.61}_{-1.15} \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VcXH_6000 | $2.1811 \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $3.70^{+1.45}_{-1.03} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $3.22^{+1.26}_{-0.90} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $1.97^{+0.77}_{-0.55} \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| VzWW_2000 | $3.8476 \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $2.61^{+1.02}_{-0.73} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $2.43^{+0.95}_{-0.68} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.68^{+0.66}_{-0.47} \cdot 10^{-2}$ |
| VzWW_3000 | $3.5969 \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $5.75^{+2.25}_{-1.61} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $5.37^{+2.10}_{-1.50} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $3.79^{+1.48}_{-1.06} \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VzWW_4000 | $4.5256 \cdot 10^{-5}$ | $2.04^{+0.80}_{-0.57} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $1.92^{+0.75}_{-0.54} \cdot 10^{-3}$ | $1.32^{+0.52}_{-0.37} \cdot 10^{-3}$ |
| VzWW_5000 | $6.2648 \cdot 10^{-6}$ | $7.55^{+2.96}_{-2.11} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $6.82^{+2.67}_{-1.91} \cdot 10^{-4}$ | $4.53^{+1.77}_{-1.27} \cdot 10^{-4}$ |
| Wprime | $6.9682 \cdot 10^{-16}$ | $2.41^{+0.94}_{-0.67} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $2.23^{+0.87}_{-0.62} \cdot 10^{-2}$ | $1.58^{+0.62}_{-0.44} \cdot 10^{-2}$ |

**Table 5.13** Expected upper limits derived selecting based on $D_{2,ev}$ for each signal and mass point at the three target luminosities of 139 $fb^{-1}$, 165 $fb^{-1}$ and 332 $fb^{-1}$. The theoretical cross-section $\sigma_{th}$ is also reported.

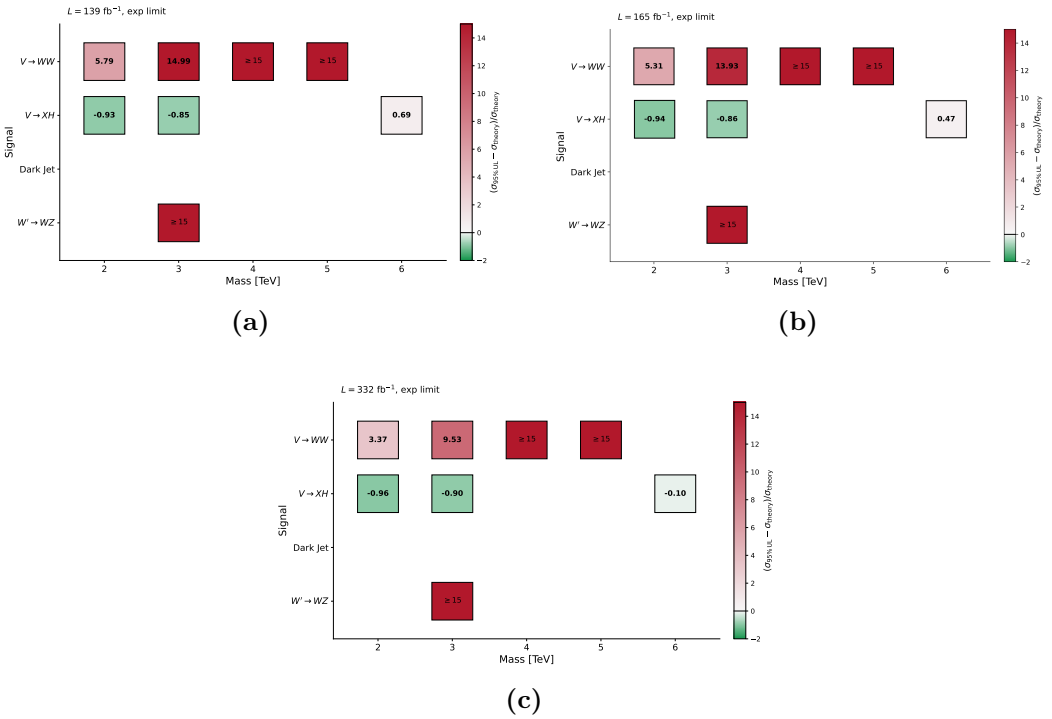



**Figure 5.30** Grid plots showing the exclusion limit $\sigma_{exp}$, derived with cuts on $D_{2,ev}$, compared with $\sigma_{exp}$ at (a) 139 $fb^{-1}$, (b) 165 $fb^{-1}$ and (c) 332 $fb^{-1}$. The grids are a rapid visualisation of the results reported in Tab. 5.11 with respect to the the starting point: if the ratio is positive, the limit is above the theoretical cross-section and the signal is not excluded, while if it is negative, the limit is below the theoretical cross-section and the signal is excluded with the analysis improving the state of the art for that process.

correct. In fact, the AD strategy is a model independent approach, meaning that its main advantages is the ability to identify, with competitive performance, different signal topologies without making any specific BSM assumption during the model training. This is the reason why it is worth implementing a AD approach in the analysis.
After the study presented in this section, the workflow of the analysis on the MC sample is considered completely defined and the next steps before moving to real data are the optimization of the sample modelling and event selection, together with the addition of other systematic uncertainties in the likelihood model, such as JES and JER (uncertainties linked to the jet calibration).

## 5.9 Proposal for analysis workflows on real data

Among the studies conducted during this thesis project, the workflow of the analysis on real data has been analysed and a strategy to be implemented has been proposed. This phase is essential because, based on the requirements for the analysis on real data, the needed tests and validations on the MC sample are performed in order to ensure that the analysis is robust and reliable. It should be noted that the MC phase works as preliminary testing for the final analysis, which will be conducted directly on real data, satisfying the requirement for AD to be data driven.
The workflow of the analysis on real data has been inserted in a diagram. It is presented in Fig. 5.31 - 5.35, and commented step by step below. The diagram has values which refer to a partial Run 3 sample with $\mathcal{L} = 165.0$ fb$^{-1}$ , which is the luminosity on which the analysis on real data should be concluded. On the other hand, as visible from the studies conducted on the MC sample, there is no limitations in principle in using the full Run 3 statistics of $\mathcal{L} = 332.0$ fb$^{-1}$. Whether to use the full Run 3 sample or a partial one is a choice that will be made based on the results of the MC phase after all the optimisations will be done and systematic uncertainties will be taken into account.

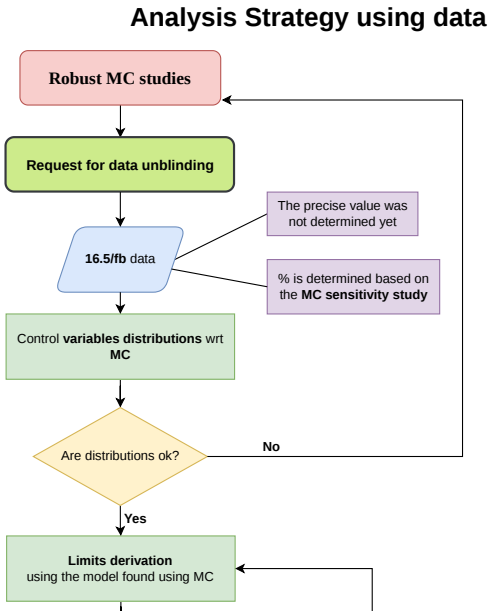



**Figure 5.31** Workflow of the analysis on real data up to determination of the amount of data to use for the GNN training.

The starting point of the data driven analysis is crucial and it is represented by the amount of data to use to train the GNN. In fact, in AD the network should be trained on a sample where it is assumed that the presence of signal is negligible with respect to the background. This requirement is easily satisfied in the case of MC samples, where the truth label about the event is known, but it is more critical in the case of real data, where the possible presence of signal is unknown. For this aspect, the robut MC tests conducted are essential. Based on the results presented

in Sec. 5.7, it should be possible to define a luminosity threshold, below which the presence of signal can be considered negligible, the sensitivity to NP is very low and the GNN can be trained using the equivalent amount of real data. At the moment a threshold can not be determined from the results in Fig. 5.23-5.25 due to the fact that the region where the limits computed in the analysis are below the theoretical values vary from signal to signal and mass point. Moreover, the results of the signal injection tests presented in Sec. 5.6.2 highlight the presence of critical aspects in the analysis, requiring more detailed validations of the possible signal contamination in the sample. A more stable result is expected to be obtained once the MC phase will be fully optimized and concluded. For the moment, the threshold is set in the diagrams at $\mathcal{L} = 16.5$ fb$^{-1}$, which is 10% of the luminosity of the partial Run 3 sample. It is important to underline that this value is only a reference for this discussion and it is not a final choice, which will be made after the conclusion of the MC phase.

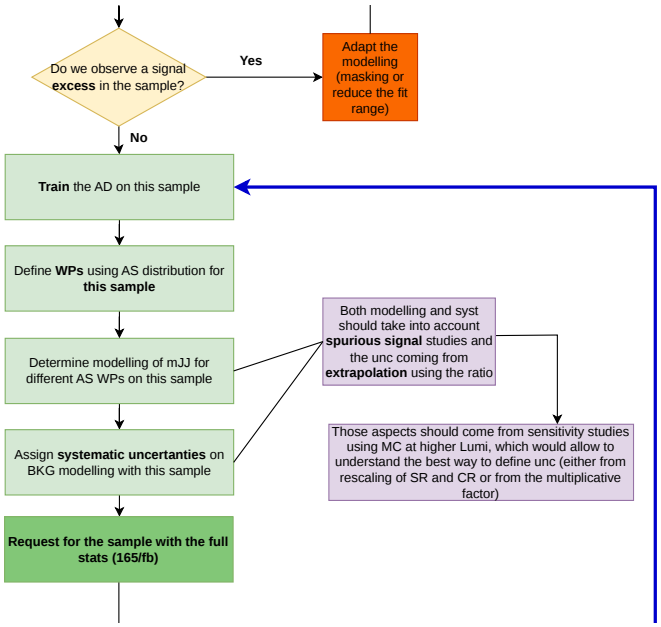



**Figure 5.32** Workflow of the analysis on real data up to the request for the sample with the full target statistics.

After the determination of the threshold, the unblinding of a sample of equivalent amount of data, the check of the correct shape of the distributions of the variables used, the upper limits are derived, planning to not observe any significant excess (p-value $< 0.05$). In case any excess is observed, the masking techinque is applied to the region of the excess and the analysis is carefully repeated, trying to avoid the inclusion of any statistical bias in the analysis, and the excess is interpreted and explained.
Once the sample has been determined to contain only a negligible and not visible amount of signal, the GNN is trained on it and the WPs are computed on the AS distribution as thresholds to reject from 20% to 99.9% of the sample.

At this point, leveraging the validation tests conducted on the MC sample for the PDFs modelling, the functional form modelling the $m_{JJ}$ will be determined. Subsequently, the full target sample will be analysed, executing controls on the distributions of all the variables but the $m_{JJ}$, which is blinded, to avoid any bias in the analysis.

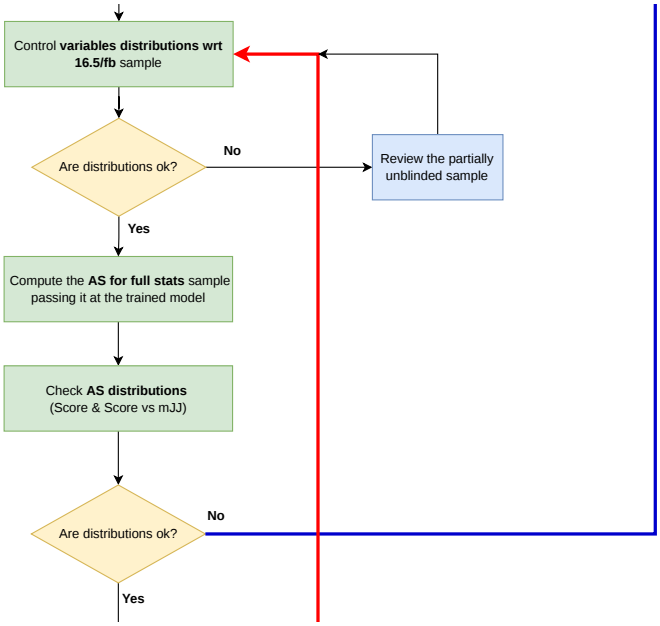



**Figure 5.33** Workflow of the analysis on real data up to the computation of the AS for the sample with the full target statistics.

Then the sample will be passed to the trained GNN and on the computed AS, the cuts at the determined WP will be applied to determine the SR. Only at this stage, the final fit on the $m_{JJ}$ distribution with the unblinding of the data will be performed. If any excess will be observed, they will be interpreted and explained. In the opposite, more probable, scenario, the upper limits will be derived and, after the final comparisons, the analysis will end.
In conclusion, it is necessary to highlight that the workflow of the analysis on real data presented above is still under development and discussion, determinig the crucial aspects to carefully validate on MC samples before moving to real data. For these reasons, the workflow is not yet considered definitive and it is expected to be modified and improved in the next months, before the analysis on real data will be executed.

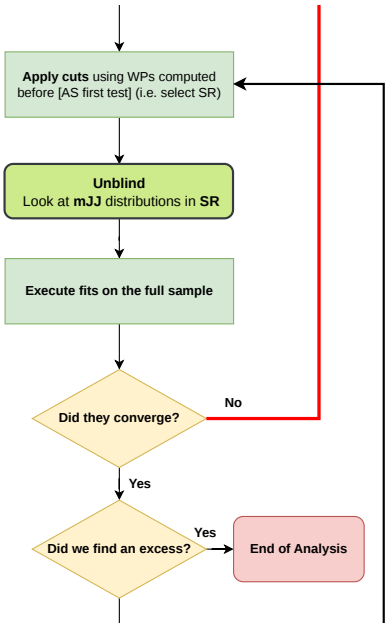



**Figure 5.34** Workflow of the analysis on real data up to the unblinding of the SR.

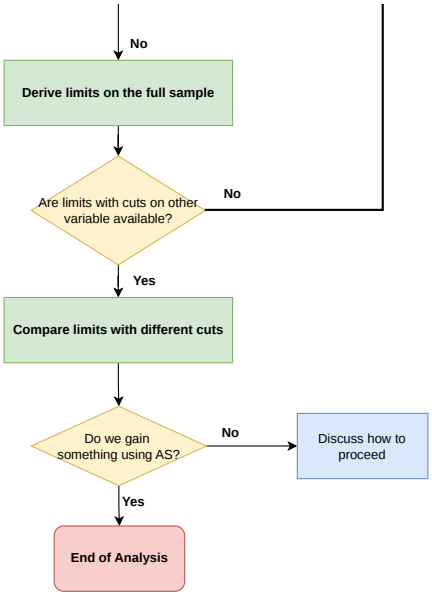



**Figure 5.35** Workflow of the analysis on real data up to the conclusion of the analysis.

# Chapter 6

# Conclusions

This thesis has been the opportunity to investigate the novel Anomaly Detection technique, to search for New Physics Beyond the Standard Model in fully hadronic final states within the ATLAS experiment with data collected during Run 3.
This model agnostic technique could potentially be a powerful tool to observe new phenomena predicted by many theoretical models but never observed in the data collected by the LHC experiments. The main innovative aspect of the approach is that it does not require any prior knowledge of the signal, which is often unknown and difficult to model. To prevent this, using a Monte Carlo (MC) simulated dataset (from the *MC23d* campaign), a Graph Neural Network was trained on a large background sample. It was then tested on a mixed sample, containing benchmark processes chosen for the analysis, such as 2prong, 3prong Heavy Vector Triplets and signals associated to the dark sector, all candidates for New Physics. The signal events, being anomalous for the model, are reconstructed with a higher error than the background events, allowing to distinguish between the two classes using the Anomaly Score variable.
After applying an event selection which allows to reject up to 99% of the background based on the Anomaly Score, combined with requirements on $|\Delta y|$, the difference of rapidity between the two leading jets, a binned maximum likelihood fit was performed to derive the contribution of different signal topologies in the sample. The functions used to model the background and signal samples were chosen and validated, in order to avoid the introduction of biases in the final results. Expected upper limits at 95% Confidence Level on the cross-section of the different signals were derived using the $CL_S$ method. The results were compared with the theoretical predictions of the cross-section for each signal, pointing out the ability of the approach to improve the exclusion limits only on a limited set of signal topologies. This limited performance could be due to the sub-optimal choice of the event selection WP on Anomaly Score which, as also pointed out by signal injection tests, should be improved in order to increase the ability of the fit PDF to detect and measure the contribution of the signal in the sample.
The results obtained in this thesis when executing sensitivity studies on the MC sample at higher luminosities, are compared with the state of the art of the ATLAS experiment. In particular, another analysis [20] searching for one of the benchmark signals considered in this thesis, the Heavy Vector Triplet $Y \to XH$, determined

a 95% CL upper limit on the cross-section of the process at different mass points roughly a factor of 20 lower than the one obtained here. This discrepancy is due to the fact that the cited analysis implements a more sophisticated event selection, applying more stringent requirements on the decay products of the $Y$ boson. It is also possible that the discrepancy could be reabsorbed once the systematic uncertainties on jet calibration (JES and JER) are included in the fit. Those quantities have been previously measured within the analysis team conducting the search discussed in this thesis to have approximately 20% of impact on the fit [81].
Concerning the previous stage of the analysis presented in [81], the implementation of a Graph Neural Network to perform the Anomaly Detection task has been a significant improvement in terms of performance and flexibility of the model, with respect to the previous Transformer-based approach.
In conclusion, the results obtained applying an event selection based on the AS, have been compared with those obtained when selecting events based on the $D_2$ varible, which is meant to target 2-prong structures. The AS based selection has shown a greater ability to generalize the selection and to detect different signal topologies, with performance comparable to those from the other selection but in principle expected to be more sensitive to the specific signal topology considered.
Natural next steps for the analysis would be to improve the choice of background rejection on the AS, before concluding the MC phase of the study and moving towards the analysis of the real data collected by ATLAS during Run 3. Together with this, given the possible presence of discrepancies between results obtained from MC training and those derived from real data, a derivation of results using SM candles as a validation will be necessary. For this purpose, 2-prong W+jet events and 3-prong $t\bar{t}$ events can be used as benchmarks to be re-observed by the trained GNN model. This step will be crucial to validate the approach, ensuring its reliability before searching for less known New Physics processes.

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# Appendix A

## Plots

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